MONDAY
October 12, 2026

INTERNATIONAL EDITION
20 Pages

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com

INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Vol. 4 • No. 242

To subscribe, give a missed call at 9828331787 or scan QR code

Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirapalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna



CENSUS PREPARATION

Mizoram to count refugees separately

NEWS » PAGE 6



'IMMEDIATE EFFECT'

Ukraine, Russia reach 'energy truce', says Trump

WORLD » PAGE 14



'RED ZONE'

Pakistan suspends govt. in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

WORLD » PAGE 14

EVERY VOTE COUNTS

Confronting the democratic crisis

The situation extends beyond one EC to weak institutional safeguard

EDITORIAL & OPINION » PAGES 8 & 9



HAVING THE LAST LAUGH

India prevails in a high-scoring contest

SPORT » PAGE 16

Stop illegal detentions, orders SC as crackdown continues in Delhi

Court directs Centre, Delhi Police to ensure free movement 'subject to law and public order'; Saturday's conditions a 'step away from police state', says lawyer; notices issued to Home Secretary, Delhi Police Commissioner and DMRC chairperson

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A day after mass detentions and a "curfew-like" clampdown on civil rights in Delhi, which senior lawyers compared to the 1975 Emergency, the Supreme Court convened what it called an "extraordinary, exceptional" Sunday hearing to direct the Union government and the Delhi Police to stop illegal detentions and allow free and smooth movement of people and traffic, as well as the operations of Metro and rail services, but "subject to law and public order".

A Special Bench of Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana ordered the police to forthwith review the imposition of barricades on public roads, ensure that Internet connectivity was not disturbed, and lift prohibitory orders issued under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) in and around the Supreme Court and other courts of law in the capital to help litigants access lawyers and justice.

The court did not explicitly comment on the legality of the prohibitory orders. Lawyers described a state crackdown that swept up thousands of people in an operation aimed at preventing them from gathering to demand the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged electoral irregularities.

"Yesterday, we were one step away from a police state. Protect the right of citizens to peacefully protest in the capital city," senior advocate Shadan Farasat, who was dragged into a police van and detained for hours on Saturday told the court.

Court's balancing act

The top court's repeated emphasis on the "subject to law and order" rider signalled a deliberate balancing act of upholding constitutional protections against illegal detention and securing rights to free movement, access to courts and Internet connectivity, while preserving the state's power to enforce reasonable restrictions to maintain public order.

The top court issued notices to Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, and Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) chairperson D. Thara on a petition filed by advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi seeking contempt action against them for allegedly violating an October 9 order which barred any "outright prohibition on the movement of Metro trains" and public transport on Saturday.

Justice Bagchi, dictating the order, observed there would be no detentions except by law outside the four-km prohibitory zone in central Delhi, which includes Jantar Mantar, the designated site for protests.

'Flagrant violations'

The court said people should be allowed to assemble peacefully outside the restricted zone. All, including journalists and lawyers, must be allowed to perform their professional duties, the court directed.

Sunday's session began with Justice Bagchi assuring that the judiciary was in the service of the nation.

He expressed serious concern over the "flagrant violations" committed by the security personnel on October 10. Senior advocate and petitioner-in-person Menaka Guruswamy asked the government how many people were detained on October 10.

"It is not just that there was no free movement allowed; it is not just that Opposition leaders were picked up from their homes; it is not just that protestors were hurled into vans and driven away by police officers without name tags... It is about young people taking to peaceful protests because they think the electoral system is not free and fair. Is this an undeclared Emergency? What is at stake here is whether citizens can peacefully protest. The last time we came to court against a situation like this was 50 years ago during the Emergency. Has Article 19 been suspended? If so, this is done only during the Emergency," Ms. Guruswamy submitted.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan said the Emergency had reached our doorsteps. "A board advertising the prohibitory order is fixed outside this very court as we speak," he said. The court ordered its removal immediately.

Special hearing

SC stresses need to uphold constitutional protections while preserving state's power to enforce reasonable restrictions

Directions to the police:

- Review imposition of barricades on public roads
- Ensure Internet connectivity is not disturbed
- No detentions except by law outside the 4-km prohibitory zone in Delhi
- Allow peaceful assembly outside the restricted zone



Rahul urges citizens to join march to SC

NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday appealed to all citizens to join the INDIA bloc's march to the Supreme Court to submit a memorandum to the CJI on the issue of alleged vote theft. » PAGE 4

Youth and journalists held as anti-CEC protests gather pace

Lavpreet Kaur
Nikhil M. Babu
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha member John Brittas and All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha were among a number of protesters allegedly injured by security forces as they were being detained in the national capital on Sunday, the second day of a protest called by youth organisations demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

Despite the Supreme Court's directives, around a dozen journalists were detained while covering the protest at different locations. There was no official data from the Delhi Police on the total number of detentions on Sunday. Activists of different organisations alleged they were beaten by security forces, which the Delhi Police denied.

'Modi, biggest coward'

Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das, Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) leaders who were released on Sunday after being detained a day earlier, asserted that the protests would continue till the CEC resigns.

Mr. Ranka said that the group's leaders would would visit the Parliament Street police station to seek a date for holding a peaceful protest at Jantar Mantar. "Delhi Police can give us a date for Jantar Mantar in 24 hours, or we will give another protest call ourselves," he said. He also called Prime Minister Narendra Modi the biggest "coward" and urged people to protest peacefully wherever they were.

The unprecedented security arrangements in New Delhi – imposed on Saturday and considerably relaxed after the top court's hearing on Sunday – are likely to be back on Monday in the wake of the Congress's call for a march to the Supreme Court.

While mobile Internet was restored, residents continued a cautious approach. Despite the festive season, footfall and business remained low in Connaught Place, with central Delhi still interspersed with police barricades.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, who was also detained on Saturday, left for Maharashtra after being released on Sunday, following the demise of his grandmother.

As security forces continued to block all entrances to Jantar Mantar, the designated protest site, the agitation shifted to other parts of the city, with Connaught Place becoming the new epicentre.

During the day, some student activists were detained in buses which had cage-like structures resembling police lock-ups, which is uncommon while detaining student protestors in Delhi.

MORE REPORTS ON » PAGES 4 & 5



Ground zero: Police personnel detain a protester near Connaught place in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

INSIDE



Forms on SIR deletions not on ECI portals

BENGALURU/CHENNAI

Details of nearly 29,000 Form 7 applications, submitted to seek the deletion from voter rolls, received in Karnataka until October 8, amid the special intensive revision (SIR) process, have not been made public on the websites of State's Chief Electoral Officer or the Election Commission. » PAGE 3



Musk can't push India on Starlink: House panel chief

NEW DELHI

India does not frame its security policy under pressure from external influences, BJP MP Nishikant Dubey, who chairs the parliamentary panel on Information Technology, said, responding to Elon Musk's criticism of resistance to his Internet service Starlink's entry into Indian market. » PAGE 6

Manipur CM calls for peace as clashes leave nine dead

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

As tension prevailed in Manipur following two days of armed conflict between Kuki and Naga communities that claimed nine lives across three districts, Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Sunday condemned the killing of civilians and the violence. He appealed to public leaders and community-based organisations to exercise restraint and cooperate in defusing the situation.

The unofficial toll stood at 11, with two members of the Kuki National Army-Burma, a Myanmar-based armed group, reportedly killed in a gunfight near the Myanmar border in the Naga-dominated Kamjong district.

"I have instructed the authorities concerned to take immediate and effective steps to control the situation, restore peace and order and ensure the safety and security of all citizens," Mr. Singh said.

The Chief Minister also urged people to prioritise peace, dialogue and harmony. He said additional security forces have been dispatched to Kamjong and Kangpokpi, the two worst-hit districts. The violence began in Kamjong on Friday night and spread to the interior areas of Kuki-majority Kangpokpi district by Saturday afternoon.



Yumnam Khemchand Singh

The first victim in the latest string of violence was a 42-year-old Kuki woman who was killed by unidentified gunmen in Kamjong's Chassad Kuki village on Friday night. The killing led to a gunfight between armed groups that continued till Saturday morning, during which a 22-year-old Kuki man was killed.

Spread of violence

The violence spread to other areas of the district on Saturday, resulting in the death of two Naga men. Almost simultaneously, suspected extremists killed a Gurkha farmer travelling to his leased farm in the Naga-dominated Ukhrul district.

Hours later, four Nagas were killed in two separate attacks in Kangpokpi district. One of them was beheaded, locals said. Leishiyo Keishing, Naga MLA representing the Phungyar constituency in Kamjong, wrote to the State's Home Minister Konthoujam Govindas on Saturday, urging him to deploy adequate security personnel to the district to protect lives and public property.

On Sunday, the All Naga Students' Association condemned the "calculated terror attacks" against Naga people by "Kuki National Army-Burma, Kuki armed militants under Suspension of Operation pact with Government of India and Kuki Village Volunteer Eastern Zone in pursuit of their imaginary dream of Kukiland, a Separate Administration or a Union Territory based on their fabricated history and lopsided story."

The student body also slammed the Manipur Police for allegedly claiming that the overall law-and-order situation remained normal during the preceding 24 hours.

Kuki organisations, in turn, accused the National Socialist Council of Nagalim, or the Isak-Muivah faction of the NSCN, of targeting members of their community.

More than 50 people have died in the Kuki-Naga clashes since they began in February over an alleged drunken brawl. More than half of them were killed since August 27.

Rain check



Clearing the clay: An earthmover clears a mudslide along a road caused by heavy rainfall in Nagrota, near Jammu, on Sunday. Two people lost their lives as the district received 185.6 mm of rain in three hours on Sunday, shattering its 71-year October record, officials said. PTI

'Indian killed in Saudi airport attack'

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

An Indian citizen was killed and at least 10 were injured in an attack at Saudi Arabia's international airport in Riyadh, the Indian Embassy in the kingdom said on Sunday.

At least 12 people were killed and more than 300 were left injured in the attack claimed by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels, the latest of several in the past week targeting the airport.

"It is learnt that one Indian national injured in the Riyadh attack has unfortunately lost his life today. We convey our heartfelt condolences to the family of the deceased," the Indian mission in Riyadh wrote in a statement posted on X. In a separate post, the embassy said that it was in touch with local authorities to track the well-being of those injured.

"It is learnt that 11 Indians are among those injured in the attack... Our officials have reached out to the hospital authorities," the Indian mission said.

The External Affairs Ministry on Sunday strongly condemned the repeated incidents in the kingdom, including Saturday's "dastardly attack", and said the attacks on civilians and civilian infrastructure in the Gulf nation are "completely unacceptable and must cease immediately".

In view of the security situation, the Indian Embassy had issued an advisory on Thursday advising all Indian nationals in Saudi Arabia to remain alert and vigilant.

(With AP inputs)

INBRIEF



Central drought assessment team meets Maharashtra CM

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday said the State government is undertaking detailed planning to provide employment, foodgrains, drinking water, and fodder for livestock in drought-affected areas over the next six to eight months. At a meeting with a Central drought assessment team at his official residence in Mumbai, Mr. Fadnavis said deficient rainfall during a crucial stage of crop growth had severely affected farmers. He said the State will submit a detailed memorandum, backed by data and prepared in accordance with the Centre's norms, to seek drought relief. PTI

Three more held from Gujarat in 'Mad Sandhu' murder case

The Gujarat Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) and the Valsad police have apprehended three men in connection with the killing of Punjabi social media influencer and make-up artist Madhusudan, popularly known as 'Mad Sandhu', in Amritsar earlier this month, officers said on Sunday. The three accused, Harsimranjit Singh alias Simu Singga, Fateh Singh, and Arman Singh, were detained on Saturday from Vapi town in Valsad district, the ATS stated in a release. PTI

'Get your ticket confirmed first': Akhilesh responds to CM over Ayodhya 'face-off'

'Pawan' will blow away BJP's arrogance, says SP chief, referring to party candidate from Ayodhya; Adityanath highlights education reforms; new U.P. Cong. chief takes charge, event witnesses row

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday hit back at Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath over his dare to contest from the Ayodhya Assembly constituency, saying the Opposition party's candidate, Tej Narayan Pandey, also known as Pawan Pandey, is enough to "blow away the arrogance" of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government.

Speaking to reporters at the Jayaprakash Narayan International Centre in Lucknow after garlanding the statue of the freedom fighter, socialist icon, and pioneer of '*Sampoorna Kranti* (Total Revolution)' on his birth anniversary, Mr. Yadav took a dig at the CM. He said that someone who was "unsure of getting a party ticket" to contest the 2027 Assembly poll should not challenge him.



SP president Akhilesh Yadav at an event in Lucknow on Sunday. ANI

On October 8, the SP chief had challenged Mr. Adityanath to fight from Ayodhya, claiming that the BJP was "nervous" after the SP announced its candidate. On Saturday, the Chief Minister said he was ready to contest from the seat and urged Mr. Yadav to enter the fray, saying the two should settle the contest "face to face".

'Does CM allot tickets?'

"Tell me, does a CM distribute [election] tickets? Even he [Mr. Adityanath] has to get in line to get a ticket. Not only that, he has to plead for others to get a ticket. Get your own ticket confirmed, then challenge me," the SP chief said.

He added that the total revolution movement remains relevant and that a movement to "safeguard democratic values" had begun. "The time when the call for *Sampoorna Kranti* was raised was marked by inflation, unemployment, and administrative chaos. The same situation is repeating itself now. A new freedom awaits," Mr. Yadav said.

Addressing an event in Balrampur, the CM spoke about reforms in U.P.'s education sector and attacked the previous SP regime.

"Before 2017 [when the SP was in power], every fifth girl in the State would drop out of school, which lacked facilities such as toilets and drinking water. Today, the government provides 1.60 crore children with two sets of uniforms, bags, books, sweaters, shoes, and socks every year," Mr. Adityanath said.

Heated exchange

Meanwhile, Congress's Aradhana Misra Mona assumed charge as the party's State chief on Sunday. The function was marred by barbs and blows between supporters of two factions. While one group raised slogans in favour of Ms. Mona, the other raised sloganeered for outgoing State party chief Ajay Rai.

(With inputs from PTI)

KMC tweaks poster after Mamata alleges 'imposition of Hindi'

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) changed the wordings of a Bengali poster welcoming Goddess Durga to a "clean city" after the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress faction attacked the BJP government on Sunday over the "imposition of Hindi".

The poster on a cleanliness drive in the city from October 10 to 21 during Durga Puja festivities read: "*Mayer Korbo Swacchata Se Swagat* (Will welcome Mother Goddess with cleanliness)", an unusual mix of both Bengali and Hindi phrases in a single sentence. Later, the civic body changed it to "*Swachhatar sathe Maa ke swagata janai*", a Bengali sentence carrying the same meaning. However, at the top of the new poster, the original "*Swachhata Se Swagat*" was retained.

The poster, bearing the logos of both the KMC and the government, was shared on social media by the corporation, which is currently being run by an administrator. The State's largest civic body is likely to go to polls later this year.



The civic body's new poster carried the main message in Bengali but retained '*Swachhata Se Swagat*' at the top. X/@KMC_KOLKATA

'Language butchered'

The mix of Hindi and Bengali phrases had irked the Opposition party in the State. "No amount of proofreading goes into anything posted by @kmc_kolkata, apparently. As long as OUR BEAUTIFUL LANGUAGE IS BEING BUTCHERED, it gets a go-ahead from @BJP4Bengal government! Stop forcing Hindi down Bengal's throat to appease your masters in Delhi. STOP HINDI IMPOSITION. NOW," stated a social media post by the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress.

BJP will lay siege to police stations if filing of FIRs against party workers continues over Form 7: Vijayendra

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka BJP president B.Y. Vijayendra on Sunday said the party has decided to lay siege to police stations and offices of Superintendents of Police if the government continues to register FIRs against party workers for submitting Form 7 applications under the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Form 7 is a voter application form for objection to the proposed inclusion/deletion of a name in the existing electoral roll.



Karnataka BJP president B.Y. Vijayendra

Briefing presspersons after a meeting of the party's State core committee in the presence of the newly appointed co-in-charge Kasam Venkateshwarlu, he said the Congress government had created confusion on the SIR in general and Form 7 in particular.

He said the party's core panel opposed the government's move to extend powers to issue permanent residential certificate to even Panchayat Development Officers and Municipal Commissioners. Arguing that such powers should be vested only with officers of the grade of tahsildars and above, he said the BJP would seek withdrawal of such powers.

Congress is united, says Pargat Singh as he takes charge of Punjab party unit

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Congress MLA and former Indian hockey captain Pargat Singh officially took charge as the new president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee on Sunday and asserted that the "party is united".

He was addressing party workers after State Congress in-charge and AICC general secretary Sachin Pilot formally handed over the responsibility to him.

Mr. Singh said the Congress has a responsibility not only to contest elections but also to become the voice of the people and stand firmly for their rights. "The people of Punjab are waiting for their rights, justice and a secure future. It is our responsibility to meet the expectations of every section – from farmers to youth. The Congress is united and our struggle is against a system that has failed to secure people's rightful entitlements," he said in the run-up to the 2027 State poll.



Pargat Singh

'Focus on people's woes'

Mr. Singh said it was essential to understand the sentiments of people awaiting justice in sacrilege cases and to raise their voice in support of justice.

Hitting out at Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and the Aam Aadmi Party, Mr. Singh said the government should focus on problems people are facing and not worry about the Congress.

He said the Congress has a strong team of experienced leaders and dedicated workers. Referring to the experience of MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Leader of the Opposition Partap Singh Bajwa and former CM Charanjit Singh Channi, he said the party would work collectively to protect Punjab's interests.

Earlier, Mr. Pilot said the unity of Congress workers and public support would help strengthen the party's position in the State.

IIIT Ranchi student found dead in hostel

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA

A first-year student of the Indian Institute of Information Technology (IIIT) in Ranchi was found dead in his hostel room Saturday, police said on Sunday. Students blocked the Khelgaon-Tatisilwai road over the incident, causing a traffic snarl. The police said investigation is on and action will be taken as per law.

(Those in distress may contact Sanjivini, Society for Mental Health suicide prevention helpline 011-40769002)

SPOTLIGHT

The caste thread travels overseas

Dalit students studying abroad hope to escape oppressive caste hierarchies, only to find that the dominant-caste diaspora has exported its prejudice into classrooms and social settings across borders

Radheshyam Jadhav

When Sanjana Choudhary, 23, landed at Oxford to pursue a master's degree in South Asian History on a prestigious scholarship, it felt like a fresh start. She believed she could finally just be a student, unburdened by the heavy markers of caste, class, and geography.

Growing up on the periphery of Bhopal in Madhya Pradesh, Sanjana recognised early on that for most Dalit students, schools are vulnerable spaces where opportunities are disproportionately divided along caste lines. Her family had struggled for generations to secure formal names and a surname; her grandmother, who recently died, was known simply as Chotibai.

Echoing the words of Rohith Vemula, her "most immediate identity" as a Dalit came into sharp focus when she moved to Delhi University for higher education. There, she found her community reduced to a footnote in the curriculum – a reality she describes as "systemic invisibilisation". Peers routinely dismissed her presence as the product of reservation quotas rather than ability. In response, Sanjana found strength in the anti-caste writings of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, reclaiming reservation as a right. After graduating, she secured a highly competitive, open-merit scholarship that paved her way to Oxford. But her hopes for a blank slate were short-lived.

Struggling to find belonging within the broader Indian student group at Oxford, she quickly realised many of her Indian dominant-caste peers were second- or third-generation attendees. Once she openly shared her caste identity, the social dynamics noticeably shifted. Alienated by the mainstream diaspora, she gravitated towards a smaller, deeply supportive circle of Dalit scholars.

Together, they co-convened the Oxford South Asia Ambedkar Forum, an anti-caste society dedicated to amplifying Dr Ambedkar's ideas, championing marginalised voices, and advocating for caste to be recognised as a protected category under U.K. anti-discrimination laws. "The uppered castes have been moving to the West for generations," Sanjana explains. "This has helped them accumulate immense socioeconomic, intellectual, and caste capital, both abroad and back home in India."

This complex reality does not disappear at national borders, a fact starkly underscored by ongoing conversations back home. The tragedy of Sahil Wakode, a second-year BTech student found dead in his IIT Bombay hostel room on September 18, has once again opened a conversation about the social environment in India's premier institutions. Following allegations from his parents regarding caste-based harassment, the incident brought competing national narratives sharply into focus.



Dr. Ambedkar Society, a student-led initiative, serves as a vital support centre for Dalit students and a forum for critical debate at SOAS University of London. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

In the broader public discourse, there is an ongoing argument that caste is a diminishing factor in modern society, with some suggesting that routine academic and institutional pressures are mistakenly attributed to discrimination. Yet, conversations with Dalit scholars reveal a vastly different lived experience.

Entry points

This imported discrimination often manifests in subtle, modern forms of untouchability within shared living spaces.

Rema (name changed), 27, who completed her Master's in development studies in 2020 at SOAS University of London and her PhD at a UK university in 2025, remains deeply unsettled when recounting her own experiences.

"The immediate priority in university WhatsApp groups is figuring out who you are – specifically, your caste – so they can avoid sharing accommodation with a Dalit," Rema says.

For Dalit students, the policing of their identity is relentless, invasive, and deeply insidious. They share that the dominant-caste diaspora employs a covert toolkit to deduce a person's background. The scrutiny often begins with mundane markers: analysing a mobile phone ringtone, physical appearance, the tone and diction of one's language, or casual questions about vegetarianism.

However, other methods are disturbingly calculated. A seemingly friendly pat on a male student's back is often a deliberate attempt to feel for a janeu (the sacred thread worn by so-called upper-caste men).

For Abhishek Bhosale, 35, a doctoral researcher in development studies and the president of the Dr. Ambedkar Society at SOAS, the battle on foreign soil is twofold: fighting everyday discrimination and dismantling the narratives controlled by dominant-caste groups. He describes the student-led society – dedicated to debating and understanding global struggles against systemic oppression – as a vital sanctuary.

He points out glaring hypocrisy within academia, where dominant-caste Indian professors often act as gatekeepers. "These academicians have a privilege that Dalit students simply don't. For them, it is merely knowledge production; for a Dalit student, it is our internalised, everyday reality," he notes.

Enduring prejudice

Beyond the classroom, the socioeconomic and cultural divide is stark. Relying heavily on scholarships, many Dalit students navigate university life with frugality, cooking their own inexpensive meals, while being quietly shut out of the broader social scene.

Across the Atlantic, Aatika Singh, 29, an Art History student at Stanford University who comes from New Delhi, views her academic journey through a similar lens of profound alienation. "My time at Stanford has been a testament to how many of my mental health concerns stem directly from recognising myself as a Dalit woman engaged in anti-caste scholarship," she explains.

"We carry our caste marginality from India," she notes, "and it is cemented even harder abroad." Aatika points out that the Indian American lobby – heavily dominated by Brahmin Silicon Valley donors – exerts significant influence over how U.S. universities address caste issues and respond to Dalit students' concerns. Because this influence crosses borders, she argues that caste discrimination, harassment, and sexual violence demand global, rather than purely national, interventions.

Furthermore, Aatika highlights the compounding socioeconomic burdens first-generation Dalit students face abroad. While their dominant-caste peers seamlessly access the resources of the developed world, Dalit students are often financially stretched, sending money back home and having to think twice before spending on essential academic networking.

Staying in tune

Not all scholars agree with centring caste in the diaspora experience. A media and communication fellow from the dominant caste at the University of Oxford, who requested anonymity, believes the focus abroad should shift away from rigid caste lines toward a cohesive national identity.

"When students from other countries... present a united front through their university societies, why should Indians be divided?" he asks. He advocates for a mutual effort where both dominant-caste and Dalit students actively cooperate and assimilate on foreign soil.

Dr Ambedkar had the foresight to recognise that the caste system would become a global issue as Indians will take their caste wherever they go. It leaves Dalit scholars like Aatika Singh with the question: "Where do we go?"

radhesyamj@gmail.com

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).

ISSN 0971 - 751X



Chennai-bound IndiGo flight was diverted to Hyderabad. PTI

IndiGo flight diverted to Hyderabad over smoke onboard

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A Chennai-bound IndiGo flight from Delhi was diverted to Hyderabad on Sunday after smoke was detected inside the aircraft from a passenger's personal electronic device.

According to FlightRadar24, IndiGo flight 6E 6115 departed from Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport at 1.30 p.m. and was scheduled to land at the Chennai International Airport at 4 p.m.

Following the incident, the flight was diverted and landed at Hyderabad's Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA) at about 3.15 p.m.

"In line with the established protocols, the pilots diverted the flight and landed safely at Hyderabad. An alternate aircraft has been arranged to continue the journey to Chennai. We regret the inconvenience caused to our customers due to this unforeseen situation", the airline said in a statement.

29,000 forms seeking SIR deletions in Karnataka not available on portals of ECI

While State CEO's statement says 1,10,654 Form 7 applications were received, portal only shows 81,822; details of who filed the forms and against whom are put on the portal for public scrutiny

Rishita Khanna
Pon Vasanth B.A.
BENGALURU/CHENNAI



Besides missing forms, the CEO's own press releases have reported contradictory figures on Form 7 applications. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

Details of nearly 29,000 Form 7 applications, submitted primarily to seek the deletion of names from electoral rolls, received in Karnataka until October 8, amid the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) process, have not been made public on the websites of the State's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) or the Election Commission of India (ECI).

This is despite communications from the CEO and the ECI that details of all Form 7 applications would be made available for public scrutiny.

A statement from the office of CEO V. Anbu Kumar on October 9 said 1,10,654 Form 7 applications had been received between June 16 when the pre-SIR rolls were frozen, and October 8.

The Hindu has found that details of only 81,822 Form 7 applications are available on the ECI website for that period. The remaining 28,832 account for over one-fourth of the number of applications as per the CEO's statement.

Without details of these forms, it is unclear which constituencies they were filed in, by whom and against whom.

The Hindu has found that details of only 81,822 Form 7 applications are available on the ECI website for that period. Following a protest by Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and his Cabinet colleagues, the Karnataka CEO directed District Election Offices (DEOs) to take action following an inquiry into that matter.

The CEO's statement on August 24, 2026, when the draft SIR rolls were released, said, "List of claims & objections in Forms 9, 10, 11, 11A & 11B will also be available on the website of CEO Karnataka so that public are able to see the list and lodge objections with concerned ERO." As per the process, Form 7 applications received every day in each Assembly constituency should be consolidated into Form 10 – another ECI reporting format – and uploaded on the website.

An analysis of all Form 10 details on the portal revealed the gap.

Contradictory figures

Besides the missing forms, the CEO's own press releases have reported contradictory and starkly different figures on Form 7 applications.

The August 24 release said 67,307 Form 7 applications had been received between June 16 and August 23. But a September 11 statement put the figure for June 16 to September 9 at 34,631 – 32,676 fewer than the previous figure.

Another release said 41,792 Form 7 applications were received between June 16 and September 17 – 25,515 short of the August 23 figure.

Even as of September 24, a day after the claims-and-objections period ended, the CEO's tally of 61,130 was still 6,177 short. Since then, the figures have climbed rapidly to 1,10,654 as of October 8.

A comparison of the CEO's figures with those in the portal showed that in some periods, the CEO reported more applications than the portal held, and in others, the reverse could be seen. Between June 16 and August 23, the CEO reported 67,307 Form 7 applications, but the portal held details of only 6,951, leaving 60,356 inaccessible to the public.

Asked about the mismatches, Mr. Anbu Kumar said the "claims-and-objections period should be counted only from August 24 to September 23", but did not elaborate. Even within that period, the discrepancy remained, with the portal showing details of 28,097 applications, while the CEO's cumulative figure fell by 6,177.

When Mr. Anbu Kumar was contacted again, he was unavailable for comment.

Make Data Protection Board active in 8 weeks: HC tells Centre

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has directed the Union government to make the Data Protection Board, constituted under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, functional within eight weeks.

The Division Bench issued the directive while disposing of a public interest litigation plea which sought to ensure that collection, storage, processing and transmission of sensitive personal data of passengers at airports is conducted in strict compliance with the provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025.

The court observed that the petitioner's concerns could not be ignored as it was found that the privacy of citizens was being compromised.

Question of valid proof

The court had earlier directed that Digi Yatra, a portal that collects personal data at airports for identity verification, could not insist on Aadhaar details to establish identity of travellers. In this regard, the Digi Yatra Foundation informed the court that along with the Aadhaar card, driver's licence was accepted as a proof of identity.

In future, the court expected that the authorities may also consider Voter ID as valid proof.



Fostering growth: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay in Chennai on Sunday. R. RAGU

Modi, Vijay commit to working together for T.N.'s development

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Sunday committed themselves to maintaining healthy Centre-State relations and working together for the development of Tamil Nadu.

Inaugurating a slew of projects, including the Chennai Metro Rail services on the Vadapalani-Poonamallee stretch, Mr. Modi said that while governments changed, his commitment to the development of Tamil Nadu and his service to its people had remained the same.

"As the Chief Minister [of Gujarat], I had the opportunity to interact many times with (former Tamil Nadu Chief Ministers) Karunanidhi*ji* and *Amma* Jayalalithaa*ji*. And, after becoming the Prime Minister, I had the opportunity to work with Jayalalithaa*ji*, O. Panneerselvam*ji*, E. Palaniswami*ji*, and M.K. Stalin*ji*. And, today, with that same commitment, we are taking this journey of Tamil Nadu's development forward together with Chief Minister Joseph Vijay," he said.

Earlier, Mr. Vijay assured the Prime Minister that his government believed that when the Union and State governments worked together, the benefits would be reflected in the lives of the people.

"Tamil Nadu continues to contribute to India's progress in industry, science, education, arts, literature, and social justice. Strong States make a strong India. Tamil Nadu has always been the foundation for India's economic, social, and cultural progress," he said.

At an event held at the Kendriya Vidyalaya IIT Madras, Mr. Modi said that as the Chief Minister, he had personally understood the expectations of States.

After becoming the Prime Minister, Mr. Modi had not only sought to fulfil those aspirations but had also made efforts to help each State achieve its own goals.

INBRIEF



Rash driving claims 3 young lives in Kochi; 2 students held

Three youth, including two women, were killed after a speeding a car hit their two-wheeler near Nedumbassery in Ernakulam district, Keralam, on Sunday. The Nedumbassery police arrested two 19-year-old students, including the driver of the car, who were allegedly under the influence of alcohol. "The car came speeding from behind and hit the two-wheeler, fatally injuring the three," the police said. They were thrown off in the impact of the collision and the two-wheeler was destroyed. The windshield and bonnet of the car were also damaged.

Police rule out sexual violence in Assam woman's train death

Police probing the mysterious death of an Assam woman whose body was found by the railway track in Srikakulam district of Andhra Pradesh last week, said the post-mortem report has ruled out physical and sexual violence. Himsri Boro's body was found on October 7 near Penubarthi village. Superintendent of Police K.V. Maheshwar Reddy said the compartment was already packed with passengers, over 100 people."Now we have to establish whether it was an accidental fall or was there anything else. We are probing," he added. PTI

Officials seize 5.8 kg gold worth ₹8.98 crore near Vizag

Officials of the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) seized about 5.832 kg of gold, worth about ₹8.98 crore, from a car near Visakhapatnam. Acting on specific intelligence, the DRI team intercepted a car travelling from Kolkata to Hyderabad on Friday and seized the yellow metal – 24-carat gold of foreign origin. The accused had concealed the gold biscuits in a cabin beneath the leg space of the front co-passenger seat. Two persons smuggling the gold have been arrested.

Mysuru kicks-off 11 days of Dasara festivities

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU



A sacred start: Abhinava Gavisiddeshwara Swami of Gavi Mutt and Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar at the inauguration of Mysuru Dasara atop Chamundi Hills in Mysuru on Sunday. M. A. SRIRAM

The 11-day Mysuru Dasara festivities got off to a traditional start atop the Chamundi Hills in Karnataka on Sunday. Abhinava Gavisiddeshwara Swami of Gavimath, Koppal, lit the traditional lamp and showered flowers on the idol of Goddess Chamundeshwari, placed in a flower-bedecked silver chariot on the temple premises.

The inauguration marked the beginning of a series of Dasara events, including a flower show, citywide illumination, a sports meet, cultural programmes against the backdrop of the illuminated Mysuru Palace, a food festival, a book fair, and traditional wrestling bouts.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and other dignitaries participated in the inaugural ceremony, setting the stage for 11 days of festivities celebrating the city's rich cultural heritage and traditions. For the first time, over 200 swamis and religious heads attended the inaugural event.

Describing Dasara as a confluence of the past, present, and future, Abhinava Gavisiddeshwara Swami, in his inaugural address, said that society should be built on values and ethics rather than caste. "Loving another human being as a human being is humanity," he said, recalling Basavanna's 12th-century message of *"Kayakave Kailasa* (work is worship)".

Recalling the royal family's contribution to the development of the region, he said the Dasara tradition could not be separated from the history of the Wadiyar dynasty. He urged the State government and the public to protect rivers such as the Cauvery, Krishna, and Tungabhadra. "We can import many things, but we cannot import water," he said.

Recalling educationist Harekal Hajabba, who used his earnings from selling fruit to build a school, he urged people to support the development of schools in villages. "If all the 6 crore people in the State pledge to work for development, it will mean 6 crore steps in the right direction," he added.

Shivakumar to join Congress legislators in Delhi protest

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and ruling Congress legislators from Karnataka will be in New Delhi on Monday to participate in the All India Congress Committee's protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities on electoral rolls and the Election Commission of India (ECI)'s special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

Asked if the Congress was supporting the protest by the Cockroach Janta Party, he said the party was taking its own course of action.

Naidu announces 40% reservation for BCs in local elections

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister and TDP national president N. Chandrababu Naidu has said his party will give up to 40% seats to the Backward Classes (BCs) in the upcoming local body elections, and the results will be considered as the yardstick for the performance of the party leaders.

In a virtual meeting with senior TDP leaders ahead of the local body elections on Sunday, Mr. Naidu said the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) went to the court to deprive the BCs of reservations and to delay the elections, and recalled that by reducing the reservations from 34% to 24%, the YSRCP had done grave injustice to them.

"Local body elections are the platform to elevate deserving BC leaders to higher levels, and justice is being done to them, without compromising on the interests of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes," Mr. Naidu observed.

The selection of candidates would be done by factoring in their prospects of victory, honesty, efficiency, and social reengineering, he said.

Wildlife enthusiasts call for release of black panther cub caught in Keralam

K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

The cage-trapping of a black panther cub in Kalanjoor panchayat of Pathanamthitta district, Keralam, on Friday has raised concern among conservationists, who fear it could be permanently kept in captivity.

It is probably the first time a black panther has been caught in a cage in the State, said Forest Department officials. The cub, aged around two, walked into one of the two cages set in the area, which has a history of human-wildlife conflicts involving leopards. The Chief Wildlife Warden (CWW), Keralam, had issued an order to install a cage trap on August 5, 2025, after the presence of a "problematic, straying leopard in human habitation in Kalanjoor panchayat" was reported. It was also directed that the captured animal be released into the deep forest, once it was found healthy.



In shock: The black panther cub that was trapped in a cage set up by the Forest department, in Pathanamthitta. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Wildlife enthusiasts have complained that instead of being released into the wild, the panther was shifted to the zoological park in Thrissur for observation, though it had suffered only minor bruises. They pointed out that considering its age, the caged animal might not have been the one involved in the human-wildlife conflicts. The cub should be released as required by the protocol set by the National Tiger Conservation Authority for handling the animals, they demanded.

A forest veterinarian has advised keeping the animal, which is under stress, at the zoological park for observation and rewilding.

The animal would be released into the wild after observation, said Ayush Kumar Kori, Divisional Forest Officer, Konni.

Hindu outfit backs its men arrested over Delhi assault

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A day after a video showing four men attacking a male protester and a woman during Saturday's protest in central Delhi circulated widely on social media, the Delhi Police arrested all four men on Sunday morning. Hindu Raksha Dal president Pinky Chaudhary subsequently claimed that the accused were members of his organisation and vowed to protect them.

The accused were identified as Raman Saini (50) ;Vivekanand, alias Vivek, (32);Kapil Kumar (27); and Ravinder Singh, alias Govind,k Hindu (35).

The arrests followed the circulation of a video that drew widespread condemnation over the assault and the conduct of police personnel present at the scene. The footage shows four men assaulting the male protester. When the young woman runs towards the scene, the men throw her to the ground, after which one of them begins attacking her.

Police personnel subsequently intervened and walked the attackers away from the scene. The manner in which the personnel appeared to handle the alleged assailants, rather than restraining them firmly, drew criticism across social media platforms.

Bangla Sahib entry row: complaint filed against AAP leaders

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH

The police complaint was filed by the Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee

The Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee (DSGMC) on Sunday filed a police complaint against Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leaders, including its chief Arvind Kejriwal, over alleged disruption at Gurdwara Sri Bangla Sahib and the circulation of "misleading" videos during protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Saturday.

According to the complaint, workers and supporters associated with AAP entered the gurdwara premises and started protesting there, creating chaos and disturbance and attempting to use the sanctity of 'Guru Ghar' for political activity.

A large number of protesters gathered at the gurdwara premises on Saturday while trying to reach Jantar Mantar to join the protest against Mr. Kumar. However, their attempts were thwarted, and they were detained by the police.

"The protesters also raised political slogans inside the sacred premises, disturbing the religious atmosphere and violating the sanctity and *maryada* of *Guru Ghar*. Such deliberate political activity inside a revered place of worship has deeply hurt the religious sentiments of the Sikh Sangat," the complaint read.

A delegation of DSGMC office-bearers, including president Harmeet Singh Kalka, submitted the complaint to the office of New Delhi Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Sachin Sharma and also provided videos of the purported disruption. "We request Delhi Police to identify each of these persons from the videos, ascertain who mobilised, organised and directed them to enter the gurdwara premises, and take appropriate legal action against all those involved," the DSGMC wrote to the police.

'Distorted version'

It added that AAP leaders circulated videos on presenting a "distorted version" of the incident and blaming the management committee itself. "Arvind Kejriwal also publicly supported and amplified this narrative, despite the conduct of his party workers and the circumstances leading to the disturbance being visible from the available material," the complaint stated.

Rahul urges citizens to join INDIA march to top court

'Every single person who believes in democracy' can take part in the march, he says; Congress leader K.C. Venugopal accuses the Delhi Police of turning the capital into a 'torture chamber'

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

A day ahead of the Opposition's planned march to the Supreme Court on Monday, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi appealed to all citizens to join in "as Indians", irrespective of their affiliations. The Opposition alliance plans to submit a memorandum to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on the issue of alleged vote *chori* (theft).

Mr. Gandhi, in a video statement, said they would ask the CJI to halt the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, sack Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, and remove electronic voting machines (EVMs) from the electoral process.

Though the CJI has declined a meeting with Opposition leaders, citing the SIR matter to be *sub judice*, the Congress hasn't called off the march to the top court. "Every single person who believes in democracy, who wants to stand for democracy, please come with us. [It] doesn't matter what your affiliation is, as long as you are affiliated to the Constitution of India and you want to protect it," he said.



Taking centrestage: Rahul Gandhi with students during Saturday's *Chhatron ki Goonj* programme in Chennai. RAGHUNATHAN S.R.

In a post on X, Mr. Gandhi said the march to the Supreme Court would be held by Indians united beyond parties, gender, caste, community and State. Referring to Saturday's protests, called by several youth organisations, including the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), the Opposition leader said the nation's youth had come out in Delhi to protest peacefully but were "beaten, both by "BJP goons and the police".

"This is not the India we want," Mr. Gandhi said, adding, "Come with us and there is nothing to fear. These cowards can do nothing to us."

Earlier, party president Mallikarjun Kharge told reporters in Bengaluru that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Home Minister had imposed an "undeclared emergency". Opposition leaders had requested an appointment with the CJI between 4 p.m. and 5 p.m on Monday, he said.

"With folded hands, we will apprise [the CJI] of the situation. Chaos is being created in the country by the Home Minister and the Prime Minister, and an undeclared emergency has been imposed everywhere," Mr. Kharge said.

The details of Monday's protest plans are not yet public, but Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal is coordinating with other Opposition parties of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA), as well as the party's own State units.

Sharp post

In an unusually sharp social media post, Mr. Venugopal accused the Delhi Police of turning Delhi into a "torture chamber where innocent citizens exercising their fundamental rights are being chased, thrashed and detained".

"All this, while vigilante groups aligned with the ruling regime are given a free hand to assault protesters – under full police protection. Modi-Shah are criminal-minded dictators who have decided to go to any lengths to save their regime from collapsing," Mr. Venugopal said in a post on X. In video statement, Mr. Venugopal said the Monday's march isn't a political one but to "protect people's basic right to vote".

Though the Congress was formally not part of Saturday and Sunday's protests, several INDIA bloc leaders, including Mamata Banerjee and Pinarayi Vijayan, took part and were detained. The Congress, on the other hand, had been protesting in the capital for four days, beginning October 6, as part of the INDIA bloc.

CJI declines request by Rahul for meeting today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Sunday declined a request by the Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, for a meeting on Monday.

The CJI's office confirmed to *The Hindu* that the request for a meeting was "declined with reasons". The office informed mediapersons that the response to Mr. Gandhi was sent to his official mail.

Sources said the meeting was declined as the issues likely to be raised were already sub judice in the Supreme Court. Besides, the court cannot intervene in matters of governance and functioning of the state on its administrative side.

While leaders of Opposition parties are expected to lead a march to the Supreme Court on Monday, sources said the response of the Chief Justice of India was that they could raise questions on fundamental rights with the court on its judicial side. Sources clarified that the CJI has not expressed any view on the proposed march to the Supreme Court.

The court has already listed for October 12 petitions connected to the protest against the Chief Election Commissioner and October 10 clampdown in Delhi.

Many detained near Mumbai's Shivaji Park as police prevent demonstration against CEC

Yohaan Varghese
MUMBAI

The Mumbai Police on Sunday detained several people gathered near the Shivaji Park in Dadar to participate in a protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. The agitators alleged they were prevented from reaching the protest site despite assembling peacefully.



Police detain CJP workers at Shivaji Park during the protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in Mumbai on Sunday. ANI

The protesters claimed police personnel had been deployed at multiple entry points around Shivaji Park and that several people were detained even before they could join the demonstration. Some alleged that people who were merely standing or walking in the area were also taken into custody.

Shafqat Khan, a protester, said demonstrators were denied entry through Gate No. 6 and other entrances to Shivaji Park. "We came to Dadar for the protest, but we were not allowed to enter through Gate No. 6. We tried other gates as well, but were stopped everywhere. Even some people who had not come for the protest were detained simply because they were moving around in groups," he alleged.

Mr. Khan accused the police of using excessive force while detaining demonstrators. "We did nothing wrong; did not misbehave with the police and did not engage in any violence or raise provocative slogans. We are protesting to protect our voting right, which is among the most important rights in a democracy," he said.

'Police action'

Meera Shah, a resident of Mulund, said she had decided to participate in the demonstration after seeing reports of police action against the Cockroach Janta Party protesters in Delhi a day earlier. "I was not sure of coming here, but thanks to the Delhi Police, they did that with Dhruv Rathee and that is why I am here today," Ms. Shah said.

Manya Yadav (name changed), 24, alleged that male police personnel dragged demonstrators by their shirts and verbally abused them. Ms. Yadav said she was detained around 5.50 p.m. and released around 7 p.m.

Meanwhile, student leader Rohit Dhale claimed he was taken into police custody from his residence in Parel ahead of the scheduled protest.

Offered help to Dipke after grandmother's death: police

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Dipke, however, alleged that police demanded he sign arrest papers despite being aware of the situation

The Delhi Police on Sunday said they had offered all possible assistance to Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke after learning of his grandmother's death, responding to his allegation that a delay in his release from detention prevented him from attending her funeral.

At a press meet, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Neha Yadav shared a 1.45-minute video showing officers informing Mr. Dipke of his grandmother's death and offering to arrange travel for him to attend the last rites.

According to Ms. Yadav, the officers approached Mr. Dipke as soon as they received information about the death and sensitively conveyed the news. They offered to help arrange a flight or bus journey and repeatedly asked whether he wished to speak to his parents or another family member, she said.

Mr. Dipke, however, had alleged that the police delayed his release and that he was consequently unable to attend his grandmother's funeral.

Later, Mr. Dipke asked: "Why did you delete the part where I was asking for my phone so that I could retrieve my cousin's number? And where I was asking to let me speak to my lawyers? The same Delhi Police who are now taking the moral high ground for informing me about my grandmother's demise and offering me a ride home came to me at 3.30 a.m. with arrest papers, demanding that I sign them.Where did all that humanity go at 3.30 a.m.? Despite knowing that I had just lost my grandmother, they still insisted that I sign the arrest papers. I refused until I was allowed to speak to my lawyers."

Sixth POCSO Act case booked against 'Gem Granites' Veeramani

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Police have registered one more case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act against Gem Granites chairman R. Veeramani.

The case was registered on the basis of statements given by two minors that they were sexually abused by the businessman. The allegations were clubbed and probed as one case. With this, the police are investigating the alleged exploitation of 10 minor girls, police sources said on Sunday. This is the sixth case registered under the POCSO Act against the octogenarian, who has also been booked in a case of abetment of suicide of a minor in 2004, the sources said.

Investigators will take custody of Mr. Veeramani in the second POCSO Act case soon. He was examined by the police in the first case, in which video evidence was available and the complainant was eventually identified by the police. Meanwhile, a search was launched on the residential premises of Veeramani.

"We have filed a request in the designated court requesting custody of the accused for questioning in another case," a senior officer said.

Mr. Veeramani and his associates were arrested in the first case and lodged at Puzhal Central Prison. They were later detained under the Goondas Act.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, Tele-MANAS 14416 and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050)

How the Mahatma's 1922 court statement echoes amid Delhi detentions of protesters

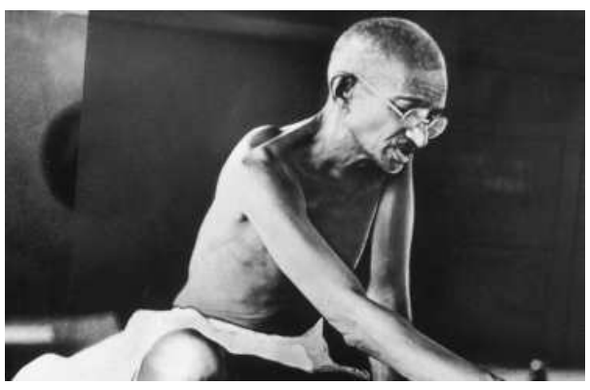
Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The protesters courting detention while peacefully demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on October 10 brings back to life Mahatma Gandhi's statement during a 1922 sedition trial in a colonial court on how dissent must confront power.

The youth protesters had called for passive resistance amidst the massive build-up of security forces in the national capital.

March 18, 1922, which happened to be a Saturday like October 10, saw Mahatma Gandhi accept an offer from the Ahmedabad District and Sessions judge, C.N. Broomfield, to make a statement in open court.

The former lawyer and the future Father of the Nation stated that "affection cannot be manufactured or regulated by law".



Mahatma Gandhi

"If one has no affection for a person or system, one should be free to give the fullest expression of his disaffection, so long as he does not contemplate, promote or incite to violence," Mahatma Gandhi stated.

He urged against what he called "violent non-co-operation", which he said "only multiplied evil".

He said that non-violence implied a "voluntary submission to the penalty for non-co-operation".

Mahatma Gandhi was on trial for publishing three articles in his journal 'Young India'. He and his editor, Shankarlal Ghelabhai Banker, pleaded guilty and were sentenced to six months' imprisonment.

Post-Independence

The Supreme Court, in post-Independence India, has enshrined the spirit of dissent voiced by Mahatma Gandhi in Article 19 of the Constitution, making the right to free speech and expression and the right to association and peaceful assembly fundamental rights.

The court had held that public streets were the natural choice and venue for expressing opinions. The right to assembly was subject to reasonable restrictions for the sake of public order, but the police cannot arm themselves with arbitrary powers and impose blanket bans on meetings.

"The state can only make regulations in aid of the right of assembly of each citizen and can only impose reasonable restrictions in the interest of public order... While prior to the coming into force of the Constitution, the right to assemble could have been abridged or taken away by law, after the coming into force of the Constitution, the right cannot be abridged except by imposing reasonable restrictions," a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court held in a 1972 judgment in *Himat Lal K. Shah v. Commissioner of Police, Ahmedabad*.

Nearly half a century later in 2016, the Supreme Court ensured that the right to peaceful and public dissent did not wane by declaring that holding a peaceful demonstration to air grievances was a fundamental right.

"Organised, non-violent protest marches were a key weapon in the struggle for Independence, and the right to peaceful protest is now recognised as a fundamental right in the Constitution," the apex court had observed in *Anita Thakur vs Government of Jammu and Kashmir*.

Congress to launch voter awareness drive in Delhi

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Congress will launch a public awareness campaign in Delhi to help eligible voters verify their details on electoral rolls and raise complaints, amid opposition protests over alleged irregularities in the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee (DPCC) president Devender Yadav said on Sunday that party workers would reach out to people to explain the revision process, encourage them to check their documents and electoral-roll status, and help them take up grievances with the authorities concerned.

Mr. Yadav warned that negligence or arbitrary action during the revision could adversely affect eligible voters.



Breaking barriers: Activists during a protest march demanding the resignation of CEC in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Leading charge: AISA leader Neha Bora grapples with the police at Connaught Place. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Unstoppable force: Police personnel forcibly removing a student activist. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Under siege: Rapid Action Force personnel seen patrolling the Connaught Place area on Sunday. ANI

Sporadic protests break uneasy calm in capital

Protests continue despite security deployment and restrictions on gatherings; throughout the day, police chase and detain demonstrators; a few shoppers return to Connaught Place; journalists covering the demonstrations were rounded up; several protesters say they returned on Sunday because they did not want to abandon the cause, though they were unable to reach Jantar Mantar

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Hundreds of protesters, including Rajya Sabha member John Brittas and All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha Bora, were detained as sporadic protests against the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar continued across Delhi for the second consecutive day on Sunday amid heavy security deployment and barricading across central Delhi to prevent protesters from reaching Jantar Mantar.

With shops in Connaught Place reopening after 24 hours and metro services resuming at stations shut on Saturday, normalcy returned in the morning. Shoppers trickled into the market, but the relative calm was disrupted as student organisations and other groups attempted to march through the commercial hub, only to be detained by the police. The heavy deployment of police personnel and barricades at key junctions appeared to make visitors hesitant to venture further into the area, as people walked past rows of shops but paused to assess the security arrangements.





Activists take part in a protest on the Yamuna in Delhi; and, right, security personnel detaining a person at Connaught Place in Delhi on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & PTI

Protests continue

The protests, called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), continued despite restrictions on gatherings and movement in New Delhi. With demonstrators unable to assemble at Jantar Mantar, several groups attempted to mobilise at different locations across the city and the Outer Circle of Connaught Place became the epicentre.

Representatives of student and youth organisations, including the All India Students' Federation (AISF), the Students' Federation of India (SFI), the Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) and the Krantikari Yuva Sangathan (KYS), attempted to take out a march in the morning.

'Leave the chair'

Around noon, 60 to 70 protesters began marching from Gate 1 of Rajiv Chowk Metro station towards Gate 6 of Palika Bazaar with banners and placards, and raising slogans of "vote chor, *gaddi* chhod (vote thieves, leave the chair)" .

The protesters demanded the rollback of the SIR exercise and the resignation of Mr. Kumar. The police and the Rapid Action Force (RAF) detained the protesters, and tense scenes unfolded as several demonstrators lay on the road, refusing to leave. Police personnel forcibly lifted some of them and shoved them into a bus. Some protesters sustained injuries and a man was seen bleeding from his forehead.

Barricades erected

By 12.30 p.m., barricades had been erected and access to Janpath Road was cut off, further restricting movement through the area.

Around two hours later, a few AISA representatives gathered near Ramakrishna Ashram Marg Metro station and attempted to march towards Connaught Place. The police quickly moved in to stop them, and the ensuing chase halted traffic.

Police personnel, Central Reserve Police Force personnel and RAF members converged on the junction and detained protesters.

Journalists covering the demonstrations were also rounded up. Ms. Bora and other AISA representatives managed to cross a barricade and run towards Panchkuian Road before being intercepted and detained by a large contingent of police personnel.

Around 4 p.m., nearly 350 people associated with the Revolutionary Workers' Party of India, Disha Students' Organisation, Naujawan Bharat Sabha and Stree Mukti League began a rally from Connaught Place's outer circle. The protesters moved along the inner circle before being picked up by the police near the Pind Balluchi square. Later in the evening, women activists of the SFI were detained after 6 p.m. while taking out a 'Tiranga Yatra'.

Protesters return

Several protesters said they returned on Sunday because they did not want to abandon the cause, even though they were unable to reach Jantar Mantar.

"I was here yesterday, but the police did not allow me to cross even the first barricade, so I had to stand outside the entire day. Today, they at least let me till here. I will come tomorrow, I do not want to give up," said a protester who had travelled from Mumbai.

Sarthak Mishra, a student at Central University of Haryana and who hails from Jharkhand, arrived in Delhi on Saturday night. "I had an exam on Saturday, which is why I missed yesterday, but I made sure I am here today. But no one else has arrived and the protest is not happening," he said.

Questioning the scale of the security deployment, Mr. Mishra said the protesters were ordinary citizens who had come to raise concerns about voting rights. "We are unarmed normal civilians and the police are having the most dangerous weapons, batons for us. Is this needed for us? This is for terrorists, murderers or rapists and not for commoners like us," he said.

"If the government is taking away our basic right to vote, it is a waste to call ourselves a democratic country," he added.

Fanning out

As police action continued in central Delhi, KYS organised demonstrations outside the Supreme Court and on the Yamuna River, saying its activists were being prevented from protesting.

Several KYS activists staged a protest outside the Supreme Court against alleged police brutality. Minutes later, the participants, mostly women, were dragged away.

In a separate demonstration, KYS activists took boats and protested on the Yamuna, describing the river as the "new Jantar Mantar". The organisation said it would continue its mobilisation against the CEC and the Election Commission.

Protests will go on across the country till CEC resigns: CJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), the Students' Federation of India and the All India Students' Federation urged people to protest peacefully across the country. They vowed that protests would continue till Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar resigned.



Ashutosh Ranka, Saurav Das.

Addressing a joint press conference, Ashutosh Ranka, co-convener of the CJP, said the "fight" has now started and that, the way it has been treated like "a war", Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah should be "ashamed". "The fight was against the Election Commission and Gyanesh Kumar. Narendra Modi and Amit Shah have turned it into a fight against themselves," he said.

Saurav Das, CJP co-convener, alleged that there is an "open emergency-like situation" and the state is at "war with its own citizens" to save Mr. Kumar.

"We want to ask Modi and Shah, what such information does Gyanesh Kumar have about you that you are fighting a war with your own citizens? Why are you protecting him? We have been told that RSS is also pressuring the Modi government to remove him, else they will lose power," he said.

"Does he (CEC) know anything about the 2024 election, when Modi was trailing in Varanasi and suddenly he started leading? Does Gyanesh Kumar know how that happened? Does Gyanesh Kumar know how elections were done in other BJP-ruled States," he asked.

The CJP leaders said that they were "kidnapped" from the flight on Saturday by the police. Mr. Das said that after being detained, the police did not allow them to speak to their lawyers. He said they were worried that their phones would have been hacked and evidence planted after the phones were seized by the police.

A Special Executive Magistrate court on Sunday directed Delhi Police to release CJP leaders Abhijeet Dipke, Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka from detention on condition of "no breach of peace for a year".

Mr. Dipke said that they will protest again. "Haven't signed any bond that says we won't protest. We will hit the streets again," he posted on *X*. Referring to it, Mr. Ranka accused Mr. Modi, Mr. Shah, and Mr. Kumar of distubring peace.

Protesters and journalists allege getting roughed up; police defend their actions

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

About a dozen journalists were among those detained by the Delhi Police during Sunday's protests in central Delhi, with several alleging that they were manhandled, shoved into detention vehicles, and prevented from reporting on police action against demonstrators.

The incidents took place at multiple locations, including Connaught Place and near Ramakrishna Ashram Marg Metro station. Several journalists said they had displayed their press cards and identified themselves as media personnel but were detained nonetheless.



Pressing concern: Police detain a media representative during a protest at the Connaught Place area in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

Journalists detained

In the morning, minutes after several student organisations staged a demonstration in Connaught Place, *Peek TV* journalists Vedanta Agarwal and Sara Khan were allegedly dragged by police personnel while reporting on the detention of protesters.

Ms. Khan said she and her colleague were trying to document the police action against demonstrators when officers intervened.

"We were just trying to get in to show how they were brutally handling detainees. A male cop grabbed me by the neck and pushed me towards a woman security personnel. 'She is press, take her first,' he said, and then pushed me," Ms. Khan alleged.

In another incident near Ramakrishna Ashram Marg Metro station, at least seven journalists, including those working for prominent newspapers such as the *Hindustan Times*, were detained and pushed into a van while questioning police personnel about the detention of a journalist moments earlier at the same location.

Three journalists working for the Hindi edition of *The Indian Express*, identified as Shashwat, Siya and Vijay Kumar, were also detained.

They were released after around 45 minutes at Chhatrasal Stadium, nearly 12 km from where they had been detained. Videos also showed journalist Shyam Meera Singh being manhandled and shoved into a detention bus while reporting on the protests. Responding to the incidents, a senior Delhi Police official said some journalists may have been detained because of confusion arising from their proximity to protesters.

"The reporters may have been detained due to confusion, as they worked very close to the protesters and did not back off while protesters were being detained," the official said.

Several protesters reported injuries and alleged that police personnel had assaulted them during detention and while transporting them to detention centres.

The Delhi Police, however, said protesters were "unwilling to cooperate" during detention operations, requiring personnel to use force to remove them. According to the police, some demonstrators refused to get up or move when asked to leave, forcing personnel to lift them and put them into vehicles. The police maintained that such action was necessary when protesters did not cooperate with instructions.

DYFI to move SC over 'illegal detention' of its activists

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI), the youth wing of the CPI (M), will move the Supreme Court challenging what it described as the "illegal detention" and "custodial torture" of its activists, Rajya Sabha member and national president of the organisation, A. A. Rahim, said on Sunday.

Mr. Rahim alleged that DYFI members were holding a peaceful protest when police personnel "dragged them off the road and forced them into a bus". He claimed that, instead of a police station, the detainees were driven to a location without CCTV coverage.

According to Mr. Rahim, the detainees were then segregated by gender and assaulted inside the buses. Accusing the police of subjecting them to brutal treatment, he said, "These vehicles were nothing short of Guantanamo Bay on wheels."

Mr. Rahim further alleged that the police failed to follow established legal procedures, including preparing arrest memos, informing family members, producing them before a magistrate and conducting medical exams.



Police personnel detain CPI (M) MP John Brittas during the protest in Connaught Place area, New Delhi, on Sunday. PTI

Police turned Delhi into a war zone, says Left; MP hospitalised

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Left parties condemned the continued police action against protesters in Delhi on Sunday, which saw Rajya Sabha member John Brittas of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) get injured as police detained and forcibly dragged him to a detention van while he was speaking to the media.

Mr. Brittas was admitted to the Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital, where he was visited by CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby.

"The police have turned Delhi into a war zone," Mr. Baby said, adding that scores of activists from the party's student wing, the Students' Federation of India (SFI), including its president Adarsh M. Saji and Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) leader Jaick C. Thomas, were assaulted inside police vehicles. "They have turned police vans into torture camps. Women are being cruelly attacked and detained for hours inside mobile jails," Mr. Baby said.

The clampdown will not stop the protests, Mr. Baby asserted, saying, "[Prime Minister Narendra] Modi, [Union Home Minister]Amit Shah, and [Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief] Mohan Bhagwat must not be under the impression that unleashing state repression will kill the movement to oust [Chief Election Commissioner] Gyanesh Kumar. The students and the youth are fighting to save our democracy."

Mr. Brittas, who continues to be under treatment as of Sunday evening, said in a post on X: "Even if we are dragged through the streets, beaten with lathis, trampled with boots, or choked to death, we will not step back even an inch. We will forge ahead until victory in this protest to reclaim the democracy of our nation!"

INBRIEF



Mamata AITC MLA attacked; Abhishek served police notice

A legislator of the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress suffered injuries when his vehicle was attacked late on Saturday night. Bibhas Sardar, MLA from Baruipur Purba, was attacked on his way home from his MLA office. Mr. Sardar said his vehicle was stopped by a group of persons while returning towards his residence. Mamata AITC general secretary and Diamond Harbour MP Abhishek Banerjee spoke to Mr. Sardar following the alleged attack. In a separate incident, police personnel also visited the residence of Mr. Banerjee on Sunday and served a notice summoning him for another round of questioning in connection with the Camac Street party office billboard case.

Two die of gas exposure at ESL steel plant in Jharkhand

Two workers died following gas exposure at a steel plant in Jharkhand's Bokaro district on Sunday, prompting the administration to order a probe into the accident. The incident occurred at ESL Steel Limited, a subsidiary of Vedanta Iron and Steel Limited. The two deceased individuals had been identified as Sohan Mahato from Ramgarh in Bokaro, and Samir Ansari from Dhanbad district. "*Prima facie*, it appears that the deaths occurred due to exposure to carbon monoxide. However, we will wait for the probe report and post-mortem reports before making any comment," State Chief Inspector of Factories, Manish Kumar Sinha said. PTI

Delhi High Court acquits man convicted in POCSO case

The Delhi High Court has set aside the conviction and 20-year prison sentence of a man accused of sexually assaulting a minor girl, holding that material contradictions in the testimonies of the victim and her mother created reasonable doubt about the prosecution's case. Justice Madhu Jain allowed the appeal filed by the accused, who had been convicted by a trial court in November 2025 under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and various provisions of the Indian Penal Code. The High Court, in its September 30 judgment, directed that the man be released from jail forthwith if he was not convicted in any other case.

Woman arrested for 'sharing' classified details with ISI

Punjab Police's Counter Intelligence wing has arrested a woman for allegedly transmitting classified information about military installations to Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), while two Army personnel have been booked for their alleged role in the espionage operation, police said on Sunday. Suspect Gurnoor Sidhu, a resident of Faridkot, was arrested on the Hussainiwala border road. She is being interrogated. The two Army personnel, who were deployed along the India-China border, allegedly collected sensitive information, while Sidhu facilitated its transmission, police said. PTI

Mizoram to count refugees separately during Census

Decision follows a meeting to review preparations for the second phase of the exercise; 38,213 refugees from Bangladesh, Myanmar, and Manipur were recorded in the State as of August 20

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Mizoram has decided to enumerate refugees living temporarily in the State as part of the 2027 Census, with their details recorded on a list separate from that of Indian citizens, officials said.

The decision followed a State-level meeting in Aizawl on Saturday to review preparations for the second phase of the Census. Mizoram Chief Secretary Khilli Ram Meena chaired the meeting.

Mizoram Home Minister K. Sapdanga told the 40-member State Assembly a few weeks ago that 38,213 refugees had been registered as of August 20. Of them, 29,575 were from Myanmar, 6,959 from Manipur and 1,679 from Bangladesh, he said. Local organisations, however, put the figure at over 60,000.



Mizoram Home Minister K. Sapdanga had said that people excluded during the SIR will be counted in the Census. FILE PHOTO

Refugees from Myanmar, mostly members of the Chin community, began arriving in Mizoram after the military coup in February 2021. A military offensive in Bangladesh forced members of the Bawm community to flee to Mizoram in November 2022, while the Kuki-Zomi people of Manipur fled ethnic conflicts in May 2023.

Ethnically related

The Chins, Bawms, and Kuki-Zomi people are ethnically related to Mizoram's dominant Mizo community. Mr. Sapdanga also told the House that biometric enrolment of the Bawms had been completed, while that of the Chins reached 98.9%. "Individuals who do not wish to share their Aadhaar numbers will not be compelled to disclose them," an official said after the meeting on Saturday.

Mr. Sapdanga also said people excluded from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) would be counted in the Census.

Altogether, 78,442 names were deleted from the draft electoral rolls published on July 4.

Mr. Meena said the second phase of the enumeration exercise would require greater effort than the first and urged officials to complete it within the stipulated timeframe.

He said the challenge was to become India's first State to complete the Census 2027 work. "The target was set during the first phase of the exercise," he said.

Manipur groups call shutdown over 1949 merger with India

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Seven banned armed groups in Manipur have called for a 12-hour shutdown on October 15 to observe "National Black Day" in protest against the State's merger with the Indian Union in 1949. These groups, largely comprising the Meitei people of Imphal Valley, said essential services, including medical emergencies, media operations and religious activities, will be exempted from the shutdown.

Six of these groups are constituents of the umbrella Coordination Committee. They are the Kangleipak Communist Party, Kanglei Yawol Kanna Lup, People's Revolutionary Party of Kangleipak (PREPAK), PREPAK-Pro, Revolutionary People's Front, and United National Liberation Front. The seventh group, Socialist Revolutionary Party, called for a shutdown against the 1949 merger in a separate statement. Referring to Manipur by its former name, Kangleipak, the groups alleged that the merger violated Article 2(4) of the United Nations Charter, the Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties, the Manipur State Constitution Act, 1947, and the Indian Independence Act, 1947.

Indian 'pressure'

The outfits also claimed that King Bodhchandra was pressured into signing the Manipur Merger Agreement in Shillong on September 21, 1949, allegedly under house arrest and at gunpoint.

They criticised India's post-Independence policies, alleging that the country adopted an imperialist approach by bringing smaller nations under its control and fuelling communal tensions. They contrasted this with global decolonisation movements, and called upon the public to continue resisting New Delhi's "colonial occupation".

Musk can't pressure India on Starlink, says House panel chief

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Nishikant Dubey

India does not frame its security policy under pressure from social media or any external influences, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP Nishikant Dubey, who chairs the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Information Technology, said on Sunday, responding to billionaire businessman Elon Musk's criticism of resistance to his satellite Internet service Starlink's entry into the Indian market.

Mr. Dubey said the committee had examined the security concerns associated with the satellite internet service provider. "As the Chairman of the Parliamentary Committee, our committee has understood the challenges facing the country's security agencies through Starlink," he said.

He added that the Defence Ministry, the Home Ministry, and investigation agencies had raised concerns about what he described as "dangerous games". He claimed that similar concerns had been flagged by the Congress-led government in 2013-14, though he did not elaborate on the nature of the alleged threats. He said India could not be pressured through social media campaigns.

He rejected suggestions that financial considerations had influenced government policy. "If our policy were driven by money, we would have rolled out the red carpet for you despite opposition from the security agencies," he said. Questioning Mr. Musk's criticism of India's approach, Mr. Dubey said, "First, provide connections to the poor in your own country, America, at affordable rates, and then level accusations."

Appointment of new Deputy Election Commissioner puts ECI work hierarchy in focus

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI



Prakash Rajpurohit

Prakash Rajpurohit, an IAS officer of the 2010 batch, has been appointed as Deputy Election Commissioner (DEC) in the Election Commission of India (ECI), filling the vacancy caused by the premature repatriation of Sanjay Kumar, who was incharge of the Electoral Rolls and Information Technology division.

What will be the work allocation in the ECI after this new appointment is crucial, as Sanjay Kumar, who had been DEC from August 2024 to August this year, had been responsible for the Electoral Rolls and IT division of the ECI, and had signed the ECI's June 24, 2025, order initiating the SIR in the country.

It is also important because Election Commissioners S.S. Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had written to the Cabinet Secretary on how files of the IT Department head Seema Khanna not being routed through Mr. Kumar, who was a seasoned officer, was a violation. Dr. Khanna joined the ECI in 2025 on deputation from the National Informatics Centre. She heads the commission's IT Department, and oversees its digital infrastructure, including systems for electoral-roll management.

Officer's repatriation

According to ECI sources, before the repatriation of Mr. Kumar to his parent cadre, Dr. Khanna's files had been routed through him till she was given a promotion to Level 15, which is equivalent to the rank of an Additional Secretary. Since Mr. Kumar was of the rank of Joint Secretary (Level 14), Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Manish Garg issued an internal order that Dr. Khanna's files should go straight to the Election Commissioners from then.

This order was, however, never implemented. Dr. Khanna's files were being routed through Mr. Garg himself following the repatriation of Mr. Kumar, as he was his link officer, which made him responsible for his departments in his absence.

Mr. Rajpurohit's appointment was cleared by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet late on Saturday as per the order by the Department of Personnel and Training. The Rajasthan-cadre officer has been appointed to the post for a tenure up to April 8, 2030.

It remains to be seen how work allocation is done now and whether it addresses the concerns of the two ECs, specially ahead of the crucial Assembly elections.

'Indo-French satellite set for launch in 12-16 months'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Indo-French satellite TRISHNA (Thermal Infra-Red Imaging Satellite for High-resolution Natural Resource Assessment) will be launched in the next 12-16 months, said Jasvinder Singh Khoral, Director (Projects) of the Indian Space Research Organisation's U.R. Rao Satellite Centre (URSC), on Sunday.

He said this was the third satellite that India and France were developing after Megha-Tropiques and SARAL (Satellite with ARGOS and ALTIKA) satellites. "This particular project has been around for a decade or so in its conceptualisation and formalisation. Now it has come to the realisation stage. It is at a point where, in the next 12 -16 months, we will be due for launch," Mr. Khoral said while speaking at the TRISHNA Water for Tomorrow workshop.

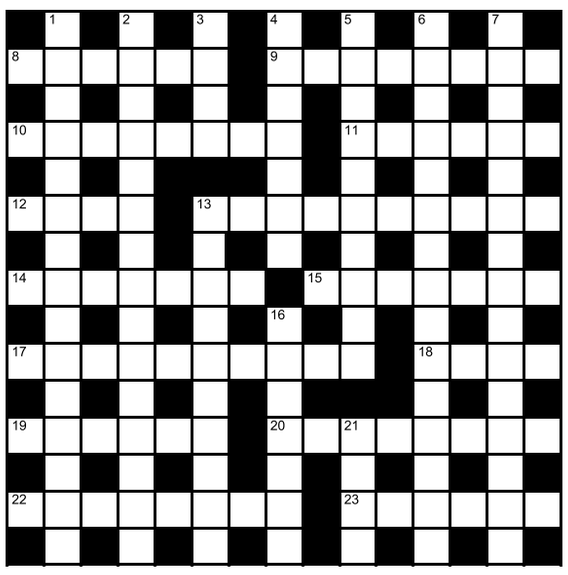
The TRISHNA mission is a collaborative endeavour between the ISRO and the French space agency CNES.

TH CROSSWORD + 14921

(set by Vidwan)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 British National limit for Spooner's sleep (6)
9 Laugh out loud! Almost high, father gets sticky candy! (8)
10 Alien about alien phase or something similar (2,6)
11 Talk about retaining the French country house (6)
12 Intense part of pride! Epiphany! (4)
13 Macho guys having no power before love! No wonder! (10)
14 Talk about India's Himalayan tree (7)
15 Weak, heartless and say vile wish (7)
17 Praise fellow to obtain unlimited dates (10)
18 Pay attention to main killer eliminating sons (4)
19 Pick well regularly within group (6)
20 Train going around hot and popular country (8)
22 Emergency provision for Spooner's dangerous quartet (4,4)
23 Loses sleep over work in constituencies (6)

Down

1 Standard article on regressive units of heredity is describing reproduction without fertilisation (15)
2 One who explains without exhibition and advertising and one competed over support for poor (15)
3 Not the first omission by section of Church (4)
4 Wise burying a hatchet (7)
5 Voters somehow tolerate EC! (10)
6 I retraced the log rolling mouthpiece that prevents lip stains (9,6)
7 Pull head back with the one short string wound for support (5,2,8)
13 Clues regularly ignored in love forecast (10)
16 Large insect occasionally bearing light (7)
21 Further exposed fake love (4)

SUDOKU

							1	
			2	9				8
8	9	6					2	
		4	9		8		5	
	8						7	
	5		3		7	4		
	3					1	4	6
2				4	5			
	7							

No.SS7029 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★☆

Solution to previous puzzle

D	A	I	L	S	P	C		
D	E	S	C	E	N	D	A	N
T	E	X	I	T	P	H	I	W
I	C	T	P	O	V	E	R	T
Y	S	T	R	I	C	K	E	N
A	R	I	S	T	A	N	D	A
R	D	M	I	D	O	F	F	M
E	L	U	A	I	I	F	E	T
E	L	A	P	E	L	L	I	N
T	N	D	E	E	T	L	G	S
T	O	L	I	D	D	O	W	J
O	N	E	S	E	H	R	F	O
R	W	A	R	D	T	H	I	N
K	I	N	G	V	O	U	R	S
A	A	F	E	A	R	B	L	O
C	K	C	H	A	I	N	R	K
Y	Y	Y	N	L				

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

4	3	9	8	6	5	1	7	2
6	5	7	2	9	1	4	3	8
8	1	2	7	4	3	9	5	6
5	6	1	9	3	8	2	4	7
7	9	3	5	2	4	8	6	1
2	8	4	6	1	7	3	9	5
1	7	5	3	8	9	6	2	4
3	2	8	4	7	6	5	1	9
9	4	6	1	5	2	7	8	3

FAITH

Shakti, strength of Siva

As per sastras, pleasures enjoyed by one are all temporary and give one pain; real *anandham* (bliss) comes from knowing the Paramatma, said Damodara Deekshithar in a discourse.

How does one know this formless, nameless entity? The Paramatma gets form, characteristics etc. when He creates, which is known as Parashakti: before Shakti, there is no formation, with Shakti, there is the formed world. This is similar to have before a pot is shaped, there is only clay.

A potter decides to form it into a pot. The shape first takes form in his mind which is not visible to others. When the pot is crafted from that clay, everyone can see and appreciate the pot. Similarly, there is *aviyaktam* (not perceivable by the physical senses) before srishti. Then comes the formation (Parashakti), and She is called *Sarva Jaganmata*.

Adi Sankara says in Soundarya Lahiri, "Lord Siva becomes capable of creating and manifesting the universe when He is united with Shakti. Otherwise, the divine is not even capable of a slight movement or a tremor. Therefore, how can one who has not accumulated great merit even dare to bow to You or praise You, O Goddess?"

This highlights the inseparable relationship between Siva (pure consciousness) and Shakti (dynamic energy). Consciousness needs energy to act. One is very familiar with this concept in daily life and the common line, uttered by one, "I do not have the Shakti (strength) to go to the temple, *Sivvanenu* (in the name of Siva), I will stay at home," drives home the point.

Global warming is turning sex reversal in frogs into extinction risk

Sex reversal is well documented in the animal kingdom, where an individual can begin life with one sex and later switch to another; but a warming planet is making these changes more frequent; in a population skewed towards one sex, individuals may run out of mates to reproduce with

Rupsy Khurana
BENGALURU



A 2017 photograph of an agile frog in the wild. As temperatures continue to give scientists are asking whether increased sex reversal could affect the long-term survival of amphibian populations. PETAR MILOŠEVIĆ (CC BY-SA)

THEGIST

In agile frogs as in mammals, the sex at birth is determined by chromosomes: two X chromosomes make a genetic female whereas an X and a Y make a genetic male

But excessive heat in the tadpole stage can override that genetic recipe and turn some genetically female tadpoles into physically normal and fertile male tadpoles

Researchers have found that sex-reversed male agile frogs in the wild sire fewer offspring — which are in turn more vulnerable to heat and infectious disease

These disadvantages could together speed up population declines as the planet keeps warming

Some fish can switch sex more than once over a lifetime. In lizards, genetically male hatchlings can be born looking and functioning as females. In some frogs, genetically female individuals can develop into fertile males.

This phenomenon is called sex reversal. It is well documented in the animal kingdom, from invertebrates to amphibians to birds, where an individual can begin life with one sex and later switch to another.

But a warming planet is making these changes more frequent and potentially more consequential for animals. In a population skewed towards one sex, individuals may run out of mates to reproduce with, slowing population growth, reducing genetic diversity, and ultimately raising the risk of extinction.

Agile frogs

Around 40% of amphibian species face the risk of extinction, which makes them the most threatened vertebrates on the earth. As temperatures continue to climb, scientists are asking whether increased sex reversal could affect the long-term survival of amphibian populations.

To answer this, a group of researchers turned to agile frogs in Hungary. They found that sex-reversed wild males sire fewer offspring – which are in turn more vulnerable to heat and infectious disease. These disadvantages could together speed up population declines as the planet keeps warming.

The results were published in *Science Advances* on September 3.

In agile frogs as in mammals, the sex at birth is determined by chromosomes. Two X chromosomes make a genetic female whereas an X and a Y make a genetic male. But excessive heat in the tadpole stage can override that genetic recipe and turn some genetically female tadpoles into physically normal and fertile male tadpoles.

"Theoretical models suggest that this threat can be mitigated, up to a certain severity of climate change, for example XX males siring all-XX offspring," said Veronika Bokony, the study's lead author and researcher at the HUN-REN Centre for Agricultural Research. However, "this mitigating effect can be lost if sex-reversed individuals cannot participate in reproduction."

Chance of mating

Bokony *et al*. first looked at whether animals whose sex differs from their genetic sex reproduce just as successfully in the wild. They paired 20 sex-reversed males with 20 sex-concordant males, matched for body size and arrival time at the breeding ponds, two traits known to affect mating success. They let each male mate with a female.

The team then tracked whether the female laid eggs, how long it took, and whether the eggs developed into tadpoles.

The team found that sex-reversed males were just as capable of winning mates and fertilised eggs did develop into tadpoles. However, sex-reversed males did not have an equal chance at mating. About one-third of females paired with sex-reversed males laid only part of their eggs, called the split clutch strategy in which they saved the rest for a better mate.

In an experimental set-up, females had no choice, so sex-reversed males could still coerce the female into mating and sire a clutch. "Had they been free in a real mating aggregation, this could have allowed the female to find another male who could replace the sex-reversed male by fighting," Dr. Bokony said.

Artificial heatwave

So the researchers turned to breeding ponds in the wild. They sampled more than a hundred egg masses from 16 different populations and found that even though the sex-reversed male agile frogs made up roughly 20% of the wild populations, only 4% of egg clutches belonged to them.

"This suggests that when the frogs mate freely, the sex-reversed individuals are not as successful at becoming sires as the sex-concordant males," Dr. Bokony said.

The few offspring they did sire were also not in the clear. As researchers tracked the development of lab-reared tadpoles, they found that 61% of the offspring of sex-reversed males underwent sex reversal, developing as males despite being genetically female. Only 17% of offspring of sex-concordant males did, however.

"We were suspicious that sex reversal might have negative consequences on individual fitness and on population viability," Dr. Bokony said.

A warming climate is also amplifying the threat of infectious diseases. The pathogen ranavirus is of particular concern: in some instances, it has wiped out more than 90% of tadpoles in a single event.

To understand how well these offspring could withstand such climate-driven stressors, researchers exposed eggs from sex-reversed and sex-concordant males to an artificial heat wave along with ranavirus. Under high temperatures, tadpoles of sex-reversed males carried higher viral loads.

With lower paternity, higher rates of sex reversal in offspring, and greater disease susceptibility all being plausible outcomes, the team turned to computer models to test how these combined pressures could affect wild agile frog populations.

Higher extinction risk

"What happens in the laboratory and what occurs in the field are two different matters, and the strength of this study lies in the assessment of the impact of sex reversal in the wild," University of Canberra professor Arthur Georges, who was not involved in the study, said.

Their results showed small populations were especially vulnerable, since losing even a few breeding females could affect a population's ability to reproduce.

While some populations may already have begun declining, others could disappear within 60 to 70 years as heat-driven sex reversal pushed populations towards more males with fewer females to mate with.

When the model factored in the mortality from ranavirus among the offspring of sex-reversed males, population decline began roughly 10 years earlier and extinction came about 9.5 years sooner.

Without ranavirus, populations still declined about eight years earlier – but the extinction occurred only about two years earlier.

"We, as scientists, underestimate the number of sex-reversed individuals in populations and species," Dominique Potvin, associate professor at the University of the Sunshine Coast, Australia, said.

She added that scientists need to know how the environment is affecting sex reversal and affecting the long-term survival of species to update their interpretations and management strategies for conservation.

(Rupsy Khurana is science communication and outreach lead at the National Centre for Biological Science, Bengaluru. khurana.rupsy@gmail.com)

BIG SHOT



The world's oldest-known terrestrial animal, an Aldabra giant tortoise named Jonathan (left) estimated to be about 194 years old, may owe his extraordinary longevity to a combination of genetic traits and an ability to keep key cellular systems functioning in a more youthful way, according to scientists. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Type I and type II errors

Vasudevan Mukunth



There are different ways to track and prevent type-I and type-II errors. Representative photo. QUILIA/UNSPLASH

The null hypothesis is a cornerstone of scientific experiments. It is the hypothesis that an experiment tests. For example, if a hospital is testing a new drug, the null hypothesis will be that the drug has no effect.

In this scenario, scientists are vulnerable to making two kinds of mistakes. One, the type I error, happens when a scientist rejects a null hypothesis that is actually true: they conclude the drug works when in fact it does not. This is called a false positive. In a type II error, a scientist does not reject a null hypothesis even though it is actually false, i.e. a false negative.

There are different ways to measure, and prevent, these mistakes. Often the most effective one is to ensure all involved parties have more information during the test. This way, scientists do not have to work with a too-tight false positive limit or a too-loose false negative error limit.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) is currently conducting a special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls where both these errors are in play. Say a registered voter is eligible. A false positive error happens if ECI officials wrongly remove that voter's name from the electoral rolls. A false negative error occurs if officials include a name on the rolls whereas that person is ineligible to vote.

A good way to reduce both types of error rates would be for all stakeholders — including the ECI and people — is to have more information, e.g. data from the new Census, opportunities to challenge decisions, and independent audits.

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Rights and wrongs

The government must not clamp down on dissent and protest

The Constitution of India guarantees all citizens the fundamental right to peaceful assembly and protest. The right to organise, assemble, and speak is at the core of democracy, and the curtailment of any of the fundamental rights is a curtailment of democracy itself. That being the promise of the Constitution to every citizen, regardless of gender, caste, or status, it is unsettling that the Government of India under Prime Minister Narendra Modi is brazenly knocking down those rights through police high-handedness across the country, particularly in Delhi, the capital. Youth and student organisations, such as the CJP, the AISA, SFI and AISF, had called for a peaceful protest on October 10. Instead of ensuring peaceful assembly, as per the law of the land, the Centre ordered a country-wide swoop, where thousands of young people were taken into preventive detention and Delhi was locked down as if under martial law. Trains were cancelled and stopped, passengers waylaid, and journalists, activists, academics, and lawyers assaulted and detained, all in shocking misuse and weaponisation of the law against democracy itself. In the heart of Delhi, police personnel without identification badges have been recorded on video. What Delhi witnessed on Saturday was a repeat, in a greater degree, of the police high-handedness in July against youth protesters. Despite video evidence of male police personnel assaulting women protesters during that episode, months later, neither the government nor the Supreme Court of India has held anyone accountable for the law enforcement excesses.

On October 9, the Court had said that a blanket ban on travel or assembly could not be allowed. But that is exactly what was done in Delhi, as people, including several former Chief Ministers, senior politicians, and lawyers, were rounded up from around the city. On Sunday, the Court, in its hearing, acknowledged the urgency and seriousness of the issue, and repeated its directives. But piecemeal orders and half-hearted lamentations by the Court have had no restraining impact on a government that seems to be doubling down on its practice of branding critics as foreign agents and anti-nationals instead of coming clean on its record. The BJP government is going this far in defence of an official – the Chief Election Commissioner of India, Gyanesh Kumar. Instead of calling for accountability from the Election Commission of India, which has disenfranchised millions of Indians in a clear act of illegality, the BJP and its central and State governments are deploying the strong arm of the state to defend him. That itself suggests that Mr. Kumar's relationship with the BJP is different from his relationship with all other parties. The Modi government should play by the rules, and not misuse power against citizens.

Message of peace

The Nobel Committee has redeemed itself by awarding Navi Pillay

By awarding the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize to South African jurist Navi Pillay, the Norwegian Nobel committee has sought not only to restore its credibility, tarnished by controversial decisions in the recent past, but also to strengthen the voices defending international law. Ms. Pillay served on the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda and the International Criminal Court (ICC), and chaired the UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory. Born in Durban in 1941 to a family of Indian Tamil origin, Ms. Pillay grew up in apartheid South Africa, opened her own legal firm in the 1960s and defended anti-apartheid political prisoners and activists on the notorious Robben Island, including Nelson Mandela. Her contributions as a jurist have shaped international criminal law. In 1998, as a part of the Rwanda war crimes tribunal, she co-authored the judgment against Jean-Paul Akayesu, a local politician, recognising that rape and sexual violence constitute acts of genocide. Last year, the Palestine commission that she led concluded that Israel had committed acts of genocide in Gaza and that Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and former Defence Minister Yoav Gallant had "incited the commission of genocide" in their speeches and statements. Compared to Barack Obama, the 2009 winner who bombed Libya two years later, or Maria Corina Machado, the 2025 winner who supported Washington's economic strangulation of Venezuela and its illegal strikes on boats in the Caribbean, Ms. Pillay has an untarnished record of standing up for the victims of international crimes.

Ms. Pillay has been honoured at a time when the world is witnessing conflicts, which have effectively jeopardised the law-based international order. Russia's invasion of Ukraine is a challenge to the fundamental principles of sovereignty and territorial integrity. Israel continues to bomb Gaza, Syria and Lebanon and tighten its occupation of Palestinian territories, with impunity. The U.S. under President Donald Trump – who believes he deserved a Nobel Prize – started a war on Iran on February 28 and killed its Supreme Leader, a flagrant violation of international law and norms. He has also launched a frontal attack on international institutions, including the ICC that has been placed under sanctions. What prevents the world from becoming a Hobbesian jungle where the mighty do as they please is the existence of international law and institutions that hold them accountable. The message of the 2026 Peace Prize is that the fight to strengthen those rules and institutions is part of the struggle for a more peaceful and accountable world.

Changing the guard, confronting the democratic crisis



Mehbooba Mufti

President, Jammu and Kashmir Peoples Democratic Party

Will the exit of Chief Election Commissioner of India Gyanesh Kumar be enough to correct an electoral process that, over the years, has come to be seen as increasingly compromised in favour of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government at the Centre and in several States? With protests now growing across the country, he may eventually be forced out, just as Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan was forced to step down following sustained public pressure. But even then, he could simply be replaced by another, perhaps worse, "yes man". Mr. Kumar's exit may therefore be a starting point, but much more will need to be done to restore the credibility of the electoral process in the "mother of democracy".

Under a cloud

The present controversy is not merely about one Election Commissioner. It is about the credibility of the institution. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has already resulted in over 13 crore names being excluded from draft rolls. This has raised grave concerns about the fate of millions of genuine voters and their basic right to vote – concerns that cannot be dismissed so arbitrarily. There are also apprehensions about the integrity and transparency of electronic voting machines (EVMs), including the security of electoral technology, the custody of machines and the auditing process.

Today, all institutions meant to act as checks and balances, including the media, judiciary and executive, are increasingly seen as influenced by a particular ideology, with their independence compromised. The Anna Hazare movement became so powerful largely because the media then did its job with honesty, neutrality and without fear or favour. It questioned those in power relentlessly and brought the concerns of ordinary citizens into every living room. That kind of fearless and independent media scrutiny is nowhere to be seen today.

Then there is the judiciary, which is supposed to oversee the functioning of the executive and intervene whenever constitutional rights are threatened. Where required, it can take *suo motu* cognisance and provide the last line of institutional protection to citizens whose rights have been violated. Yet, during the SIR controversy, serious allegations of wrongful deletions, including cases in which living voters were shown as dead and physically produced before the courts, have not resulted in any tangible action.

> The crisis extends beyond one Election Commissioner to democracy's weakened institutional safeguards

In West Bengal, the then Mamata Banerjee government also approached the judiciary over the Election Commission of India (ECI)'s handling of the SIR process. The response, however, has been deeply disappointing, to say the least. The possible disenfranchisement of genuine voters deserved the most rigorous scrutiny, yet the process appears to have been gradually normalised. When institutions meant to safeguard citizens' rights and hold the executive accountable appear compromised, the government acquires enormous power without having to fear the consequences.

It is not just the SIR or the EVMs. It is also the raids and investigations involving Opposition leaders around election time, followed by media narratives that often criminalise individuals before a court has established their guilt. We have seen this over the last decade in the manner in which central investigative agencies have been weaponised not only against political opponents but also against individuals who dare to question the government. Sitting Chief Ministers, Members of Parliament, Ministers and political leaders have faced arrests and investigations over allegations that have yet to be established at trial. The repeated selective targeting of individuals, combined with the amplification of such accusations by sections of the media, has proved beyond doubt the nexus between the present regime and a system it is alleged to have corrupted to the hilt.



The great weakening of democratic checks

When the executive acts, the media amplifies its actions, and the judiciary appears reluctant to intervene, all three pillars of democracy can appear to be working in tandem against the public interest. Anyone who dares to speak up risks being pushed out of the system.

We have seen this within the ECI itself. Election Commissioner Ashok Lavasa openly dissented from decisions giving clean chits to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and BJP president Amit Shah over alleged violations of the Model Code of Conduct during the 2019 Lok Sabha campaign. He subsequently left the ECI before the end of his tenure to take up a position in a lead bank.

Today, one cannot help but ask what fate awaits Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, who have reportedly recorded objections to several decisions of the ECI under Mr. Kumar, thereby exposing the rot within the system.

This is why the ongoing protests by political parties, civil society groups, non-governmental organisations, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and others cannot remain isolated demonstrations. They must evolve into a sustained democratic movement, perhaps closer in spirit to Gandhiji's Satyagraha, to reclaim what has been lost or weakened over the last decade.

Reclaiming the India we knew

The most difficult task, awakening public consciousness, may already have begun. The challenge now is to turn that awakening into a people's movement powerful enough to reclaim the India we once knew – an India where the judiciary could hold even a sitting Prime Minister, such as Indira Gandhi, accountable; where a robust media could question a Prime Minister without fear; and where an Election Commissioner such as T.N. Seshan could exercise his constitutional authority without fear or favour. The beginning has to be a genuinely free and fair electoral process. Removing Gyanesh Kumar may therefore be a necessary starting point, but it is certainly not the end. A democracy survives on public trust. Today, that trust has been severely eroded.

To expect a fully credible election without first rebuilding confidence in the institutions that conduct, monitor and adjudicate elections is like asking for water in the Sahara. What India needs is not merely a change of one Election Commissioner, but an independent system capable of organising elections whose fairness is beyond suspicion. Is the present BJP government willing to do that?

Much more than Gyanesh Kumar has to go if India is to restore the credibility of its electoral system and become a fully fledged democracy. The entire ecosystem that is eating away at the vitals of India's democracy has to go.

Barricades cannot silence the voice of democracy



M.A. Baby

General Secretary, Communist Party of India (Marxist)

The past few months have seen considerable action at the barricades of Jantar Mantar. A recent media investigation on happenings in the Election Commission of India (ECI) sparked a new wave of protests, this time against the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. The demand for Mr. Kumar's resignation has become a demand for electoral integrity itself. On October 2, 2026, prohibitory orders under Section 163 were imposed across the New Delhi district ahead of the protest against the CEC at Jantar Mantar. A number of Metro stations were closed, and major traffic restrictions were announced.

These measures did not deter protesters, but the mass detentions and restrictions imposed by the Delhi Police raise difficult questions that await answers: Whose capital is this? Whose streets are these? In July 2026, Jantar Mantar, the capital's designated protest site, witnessed one of the biggest youth protests of the year, which eventually culminated in a major victory for the protesters. Since the July 20 NEET protests, the Delhi Police have substantially increased barricading in the area. Closing of the streets and manipulation of the ballot are two sides of the same coin. To protest against the government, citizens must first seek the government's permission. At Jantar Mantar, the Delhi Police have reportedly made it mandatory to submit applications 10 days in advance. The oppressed are allowed to speak against the oppressor only when the oppressor allows it.

The erasure of protest geography

The history of Delhi's protest geography is slowly being erased. The Boat Club was once the designated site for demonstrations before they were shifted to Jantar Mantar. Although Jantar Mantar remains the designated protest site, it is routinely blocked on the pretext of "permission denied". Until the COVID-19 lockdown, the customary rally route ran from Mandi House to Jantar Mantar or the Parliament Street Police Station. Large rallies often began at Ramlila Maidan and culminated on Parliament Street. Since the lockdown, barring a few exceptions, almost no permissions have been granted. Parliament Street was where people symbolically expressed their dissent before their elected representatives.

The legal instrument enabling these blockades is Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), which replaced Section 144 of the Code of Criminal Procedure. Repeated prohibitory orders have raised concerns about whether restrictions intended to regulate demonstrations are, in practice, preventing them altogether, and unchecked discretion to deny permission for demonstrations challenging the government or its policies.

> As protest spaces shrink, citizens must unite to defend the right to dissent

In its 2018 judgment in *Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan vs Union of India*, the Supreme Court recognised peaceful protest as a fundamental right and directed the authorities to formulate guidelines permitting regulated demonstrations at Jantar Mantar. Before that, in the Ramlila Maidan case of 2012, the Court affirmed the same principle.

It is not just Delhi. In Bengaluru, protests once held at Town Hall were moved to Freedom Park, only to face restrictions there as well. In 2022, the Karnataka High Court confined demonstrations to Freedom Park. In December 2025, the park was closed entirely for "redevelopment", with electricity and water supplies cut off. In Hyderabad, protests are permitted only at Dharna Chowk. Farmers marching to Delhi in early 2024 faced barricades, barbed wire, tear gas and even trenches along the Haryana border. Preventive detentions, prohibitory orders targeting workers' strikes and student marches, and Internet shutdowns have become standard responses across States. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is the main driver of this national pattern: protests are first relocated, then confined, and finally banned.



Dissent cannot be contained

History shows that whenever those in power curb, restrict or seal the public sphere, the masses always find a way around. The 2011 Tahrir Square movement, Occupy Wall Street, the Paris Commune and the Petrograd Soviets are some examples.

India, too, has witnessed major protests in recent years, including the historic Shaheen Bagh sit-in against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) and the National Register of Citizens (NRC), the 2020-21 farmers' protests on Delhi's borders, and Left-led workers' and peasants' mobilisations such as the Mahapadav and the Kisan Long March. The Mahapadav of November 2023 brought workers and farmers onto the streets of State capitals across the country for a three-day sit-in.

Spaces are produced through struggle. When the state seals the formal public sphere, resistance creates new spaces at borders, on highways and campuses, across digital networks and in *mohallas*. Repression creates the conditions for such resistance. Every barricade becomes a symbol of dissent and a rallying point. Mohan Bhagwat, Narendra Modi and Amit Shah must understand that dissent cannot be abolished by decree. Internet shutdowns, Metro closures, preventive detentions and imprisonment have not ended people's democratic aspirations. As Pablo Neruda said, they can cut all the flowers, but they cannot prevent spring from arriving. Authoritarian confidence is brittle, and repression is often a sign of political insecurity.

On electoral exclusion

The fight for space is part of a larger fight to defend the Constitution and democratic institutions. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls threatens mass disenfranchisement of the poor, migrants, minorities, and women. The ECI's data shows that vulnerable sections including short-term migrants, illiterate voters and married women risk being deleted from the rolls. The 2023 Act on the appointment of Election Commissioners removed the Chief Justice of India from the selection panel and gave control to the executive. The Act gives total lifelong protection to the Election Commissioner from civil and criminal prosecution. Even the President of India has protection only as long as he or she is holding office.

By blocking dissent in public and tampering with rolls in private, the BJP regime is hollowing out our democratic republic from both ends. The democratic and secular forces need to link the street, the court, and the ballot into a single democratic offensive. The right to protest is the people's inherent right, won through the freedom struggle and enshrined in Article 19. We demand the restoration of the right to assemble and march at Jantar Mantar and along Parliament Street, and an end to the blanket, permanent use of Section 163 of the BNSS in New Delhi. The government must stop detentions and the violent suppression of peaceful protests. If the authorities barricade Jantar Mantar, we will not only defy those barricades but also, as the people of India, create countless Jantar Mantars in every nook and corner of the country.

Democracy can only be defended when it is practised, and our task is to build the broadest struggle to practise it.

Spring will come.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Electoral transparency

If a 'centralised computer system' can remove millions of voters — as if by a sleight of hand — can millions of aggrieved citizens not collectively demand accountability from a Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) of India whose functioning raises serious questions? Power cannot remain concentrated in one Commissioner, with opaque control over electoral data and arbitrary changes, without inviting public scrutiny. Nor can immunity become a licence for impunity. The ballot cannot be protected by machinery that risks eroding public faith in it.

M. Jameel Ahmed,
Mysuru

It is imperative that all citizens who value democracy, particularly the youth, come together to defend constitutional freedoms through peaceful and non-violent means. Their movement should draw inspiration from Mahatma Gandhi's principles of non-violence and civil resistance. As an octogenarian, I cannot help but feel anxious about the kind of India we will leave behind for future generations. We owe our young people a country in which democratic institutions remain independent, dissent is respected, elections inspire public confidence, and the government is accountable to the people. The time has come for all democratic-minded citizens to reflect seriously on these concerns.

Tharcius S. Fernando,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The need to preserve the shine of Indian elections



Akshay Rout

Former Director General, Election Commission of India and a public policy commentator

The intense and unabated protests happening around and about the Election Commission of India (ECI) have thrown up a bigger question – whether the much vaunted Indian election is losing its shine. This concern is irrespective of when and how the immediate fire is doused, for the smoke could linger. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and its management have raised many questions during the last year, inviting attention, litigation and agitation. But the malaise facing the Indian electoral system is even wider. The unidimensional nature of the present noise might be drowning a larger challenge; the current scenario may only be a wakeup call.

Elections, branded as among India's topmost soft powers for decades, may have finally hit a phase of devaluation. The country's enviable delivery of democratic elections, compared to dozens of countries in Asia, Africa and West Asia, which became independent around the same time, might have had the evil eye cast on them. Not only election managers, but the executive, the legislature, the judiciary, the winners and the losers in elections, as well as the wider voting community need to be play an alert remedial role in order to properly address the concerns of the electoral system.

Prime asset

Popular and credible elections have given the Indian nation critical stability, reasonable governance, post-colonial reconstruction and a pathway to development, besides the tenacity to counter external threats. The exercise of equal franchise by the sick and the elderly and by a people who are unequal socially and economically is part of India's electoral folklore as also are the latest trends of women activism in voting. Despite rampart poverty and illiteracy at the time of independence, ordinary Indians have learned about the strength of their votes, and have nurtured a respect for the polling process. They wait for their turn periodically to place or remove candidates at positions of decision making.

The process has worked remarkably well compared to other parts of Indian enterprise. Apart from the framers of the Constitution led by Dr. Bhimrao Ambedkar, who laid the seeds of parliamentary democracy, the credit duly rests on the ECI machinery, from the Nirvachan Sadan in New Delhi to the million plus polling booths across the country. The scale of the task – the 2024 national elections saw about 98 crore electors spread across India's vast and varied topography – with the massive logistics that it entails, and the finesse of its disposal, have kept advanced nations wonder-struck. The ECI has justifiably emerged as a school for election managers from a range of countries which are still groping for ways to execute such a huge and sensitive mandate. Further, the Commission set up the India International Institute of Democracy and Election Management (IIIDEM) to impart lessons in conducting flawless elections. Younger nations look up to India's election management as a guiding star amidst other falling models.

However, there are grey, if not dark clouds on the horizon. It may still be an exaggeration to suggest that the Indian elections are corroded but malignant encroachments cause an unsettling feeling. While elections have always been fiercely contested, with even a few social faultlines such as caste and community getting interwoven into the outcome, the results were mostly received with stoic calm. But no more. What has taken over are chronic allegations about the partisan conduct of the poll body, and aggressive grievance bordering on a rejection of the electoral results. The argument that this is part of a global decline of democratic values, and has also infected developed democracies such as the U.S., holds no consolation. No country on earth needs democracy more than India does. No country needs elections more than India does.

A different game

Elections in India have changed with the times. Ground level campaigns and door-to-door canvassing have given way to digital battles where fast moving disinformation and deep fakes are the new weaponry. While muscular assaults such as booth capturing, voter intimidation, and bogus voting of the earlier decades were bad enough, they were still limited to certain pockets. Now, the possibility of manipulating the voter database through undue enfranchisement or disenfranchisement poses a threat at a larger scale.

The influence of money power over elections, with its ability to upset the sacred level-playing field, has grown enormously compared to localised distribution of cash or goodies in the past. Expenditure reports of candidates submitted to the ECI post-election, and accounted party spends are just tip of the icebergs; unofficial estimates of poll finances are much larger. The institutional release of cash into the wallets of population segments, touted as welfare, has distorted electoral integrity, besides public finance. The Economic Survey 2026 puts the strain of such unconditional cash transfers on States at a staggering ₹1.7 lakh crore. Such brazen transactions through the front door have subverted policy and candidate level contest, causing worries to the ECI and the Supreme Court.



Post poll subversion casts a darker shadow. Wholesale defections increasingly undermine the people's mandate for a candidate and party. Instead of reining in party hoppers, the anti-defection law has induced the bulk transfer of elected legislators thanks to exceptions allowed in the 10th Schedule. Opportunistic realignments have made a mockery of voters' choice in the absence of a recall system. The stream of present-day lawmakers dumping manifesto and ideology and switching parties at ease, make the earlier 'Aya Ram Gaya Rams' in Indian politics look like timid angels. The Speaker's recognition and symbol allocation by the ECI are critical follow ups to such mutations which have also not been free of partisan accusations.

Election management itself has got embroiled in institutional issues sparking opposition and street protests. The SIR exercise, which began a year ago, has left a trail of dust while approaching the finish line. Meanwhile, the provision of appointing Election Commissioners through a collegium under the 2023 enactment has not helped matters; and is still under the study of Supreme Court. The usual regulatory functions of the ECI such as the preparation of the electoral roll, the administration of the Model Code of Conduct, the announcement of results, and more recently, intra-organisational functioning are routinely moving into zones of contention, despite significant back up from higher courts. The distrust vocalised by polarised political entities can percolate down to ordinary citizens and create hopelessness.

Sukumar Sen, the Chief Election Commissioner for the first elections conducted in independent India in 1951, had unimaginable logistical challenges to handle, but certainly not one of trust. Today, after 75 years of experience and growing resources, while the massive logistics in elections is routine, trust has become the issue.

Urgent, collective imperative

Elections are by far the best organised expression of "we, the people" and hence cannot be allowed to fail. Political rhetoric is not part of the solution. The election process and its management are too precious to be made scapegoats in inter-party fights. Political parties need to do a collective and apolitical sit-down for the systemic fortification of Indian elections by building more safeguards and accountability and plugging structural and legal loopholes – basically, doing whatever is necessary and whatever it takes. The introduction of a three-member Commission to replace the single Chief Election Commissioner in 1993 had this very logic. There are multiple demands to be met: the better regulation of political financing and the menace of freebies; shielding of the electoral process from criminalisation; and dealing with the threat of AI-abetted fake narratives. Voters as well as those who are voted for must be insulated against inducements in discharge of their democratic functions. Arresting further deterioration will require collective work beyond partisan self-interest. And above everything else, trust has to be worked back into the system.

Views expressed are personal.



In full force: Security personnel in riot gear stand guard outside the Election Commission office ahead of a planned protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar in New Delhi, on October 10. AP

Elections are by far the best organised expression of "we, the people" and hence cannot be allowed to fail

The gaps in the implementation of the RTI Act

Section 4 of the RTI Act lists 16 types of information which are to be disclosed by public authorities; such voluntary disclosure has not been followed

DATA POINT

Sneha Gandla
Gauri Singavarapu
Sachin Swaraj

The Right to Information (RTI) Act completed 21 years today. Besides empowering citizens to demand information from public authorities, a key aspect of the RTI Act is the provision for *suo motu* mandatory disclosure of a variety of information on their websites so that people do not have to resort to filing requests under the Act for accessing basic information regarding any department.

Section 4 (1) (b) of the Act lists 16 types of information, ranging from contact details of officials to budgetary expenditure, which are to be made public at regular intervals. Moreover, the Department of Personnel and Training has issued guidelines for the disclosure of additional information, under eight broad categories, including information related to procurement, public-private partnerships, and all RTI applications received by each department. An analysis, however, showed that such voluntary disclosure has not been followed.

With the number of official websites of the Union government and State governments running into the thousands, the scope of this analysis is restricted to the departments listed as Public Authorities (PAs) in the Government of India's online portal for filing of applications under the RTI Act and the data presented in the annual reports of the Central Information Commission (CIC). To ensure compliance with Section 4 of the RTI Act, the government has also made it mandatory for transparency audits to be conducted by third parties and the reports of such audits to be shared with the CIC.

The annual report for the year 2024-25 released earlier this year by the CIC says that of the 2,303 PAs from various departments registered with the Commission, only 1,446 had submitted third party audit reports, which is just 62.7% of the total registered **(Table 1)**. Of those submitted, more than 50% scored Grade C or below, which meant that they had scored 80% or below in the transparency audit. Those with Grade E had scored below 60% in the audit. Though nearly 37% of the registered PAs did not submit the audit reports, a look at the trend in the last five years showed that the compliance has improved year-on-year **(Chart 1)**. In 2020-21, only 754 had submitted. This doubled to 1,443 in 2024-25.

The Hindu independently verified the websites of the 94 departments under which these PAs come under. The guidelines recommend the uploading of the transparency audit reports on the websites. However, only 33 of the 94 websites had the audit reports for the year 2024-25. While a majority of them did not have the latest audit reports, a few had older reports. An analysis on the information that is to be mandatorily disclosed under the RTI Act showed that, of the 94 departments, 56 authorities, or 62% have complied with this section on most categories, and have information from 2025-26. The websites of 26 departments did not have the information covered under the Act. For the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, there was no information available **(Table 2)**. The remaining websites had either minimal or dated information on their websites.

Meanwhile, the number of new RTI requests and its pendency with the CIC has grown over the years **(Chart 2)**. The Act states that PAs should provide "as much information *suo motu* to the public ...so that the public have minimum resort to the use of this Act". The efficient implementation of Section 4 can not only improve transparency but also reduce the pendency piling up with the CIC and State Information Commissions.



In defense of transparency: Workers during the laying of the foundation of the National RTI Museum in Beawar, Rajasthan. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

1 Section 4(1) (b) of the RTI Act mandates suo motu disclosure of a range of information by every government authority

2 Public authorities covered under the Act are mandated to conduct independent transparency audits to ensure compliance with Section 4 (1) (b)

3 In 2024-25, only 62.3% of the public authorities had submitted these audit reports to the CIC

4 Most sites checked by *The Hindu* had disclosed only minimal information available

Voluntary non-disclosure

Data for the charts were sourced from the Central Information Commission (CIC) and websites of 94 government departments listed in the RTI portal of the Government of India. The authors are interning with The Hindu's Data team

Table 1: Number of public authorities (PAs) who submitted transparency audit reports to the CIC and their grades

Number of PAs	2,303
Audit report submitted to CIC	1,446
Grade A	410
Grade B	253
Grade C	302
Grade D	215
Grade E	266

Table 2: Availability of transparency audit reports in the websites of 94 departments listed in the RTI portal

Compliance	No. of depts.
Report available with section-wise scores and required compliance classifications	33
Report available, but the latest recorded audit year is older	7
No report found in the portal material reviewed	43
While audit is mentioned or information is available, the full report or expected details are missing	7
Report reference, total score or audit mentioned without complete accessible report	3
Portal did not display the relevant audit information	1
Total	**94**

Chart 1: The number of public authorities (PAs) registered with the CIC and those who submitted the transparency audit reports to the Commission in the last five years

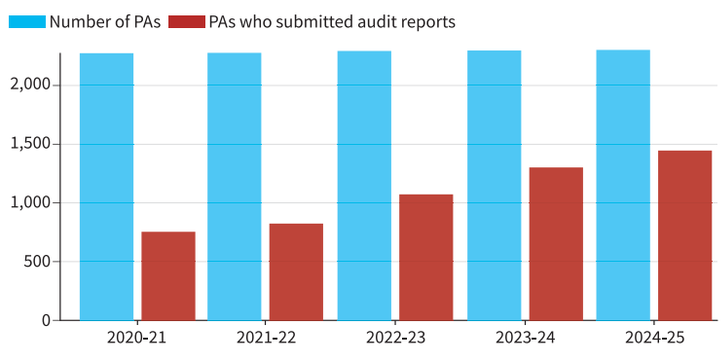
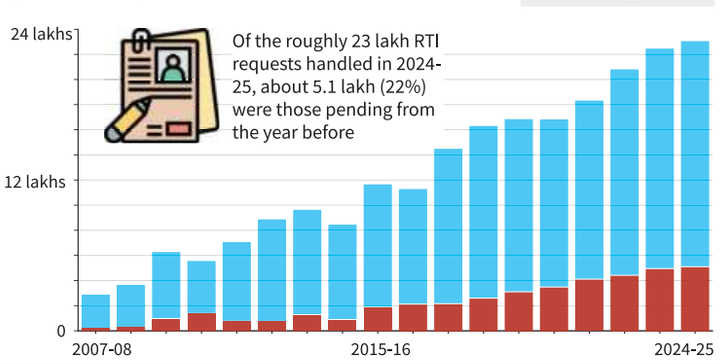


Chart 2: The number of RTI requests filed every year and the pendencies from previous years have consistently grown over the years



FROM THE ARCHIVES
The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 12, 1976

Expert's survey of ENT diseases in Male Island

Madras, October 11: Fishing is their primary occupation and practically every one of them swims and dives. Their staple food is fish and rice. Occupational hazards, vitamin-deficient food and the inclement weather conditions add up to make the 1,25,000 people living in the Maldivian Archipelago "extremely prone to upper respiratory tract infections". "I have never seen so many cases of chronic tonsillitis, adenoiditis and mastoiditis", says Dr. S. Kameswaran, Director of the Institute of Otorhino-laryngology, Madras Medical College, who had been there on a short WHO assignment.

The first ENT expert ever to set foot on the soil of MALE, the capital-island of the Republic of Maldives, Dr. Kameswaran had been asked to conduct a sample survey of ENT diseases, hold special clinics, organise training course for health personnel and to assist and advise the Maldivian Government in setting up ENT units in health centres.

Of the 2,000 islands forming the archipelago, only 192 are permanently inhabited, the total land area being 115 square miles. Male Island, which has a population of 20,000, has a 52-bed modern hospital, with an operational theatre.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 12, 1926

Presenting India to people of Canada

London, October 11: Sir T. Vijayaraghavachariar arrived in London to-day from Canada and will leave for India in a few days to take up his position on the Public Services Commission. Interviewed by Reuter he said he was very glad he had an unequalled opportunity of presenting India to the people of the great Dominion.

He had a wonderful greeting everywhere. He found India little known in Canada, but one of the Dominion Ministers, on his departures, declared that India had at length become more real to the Canadians.

It was no longer a land of mystery for them and its place in the Empire was better understood and appreciated.

Sir T. Vijayaraghavachariar said that he had always emphasised the unity of the Empire and the subordination of local to Imperial results.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of FIRs registered by Delhi Police over CJP protest

20 Delhi Police have registered 20 FIRs in connection with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-called protest demanding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation. More than 7,000 people were detained across the national capital as over 30,000 police personnel were deployed to prevent protesters from reaching Jantar Mantar. PTI

FDI inflows this quarter from India's largest source, Japan

5.71 in $ billion. Japan has emerged as the largest source of foreign direct investment into India during April-June of the current fiscal year, according to government data. FDI inflows from Japan stood at $5.71 billion in the first quarter of 2026-27, surpassing the $3.74 billion India received from the country during the entire 2025-26 fiscal year. PTI

Maximum temperature levels recorded in the national capital

32 degrees Celsius. Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 32 degrees Celsius on Sunday, which was 2.2 notches below the season's average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The minimum temperature was logged at 24.4 degrees Celsius, which was 3.4 notches above the season's average, the IMD data showed. PTI

Number of migrants dead in Djibouti boat accident

109 At least 109 migrants died, including 15 children, and 116 went missing when a boat sank off the shores of Djibouti on the night of October 8-9, a UN agency said on Sunday. Survivors said the vessel — which was carrying 305 people from Djibouti to Yemen — capsized north of the Djibouti town of Obock. About 80 people survived the shipwreck. AFP

Number of people who died in U.S. Cyclone Isaias

4 Cyclone Isaias was the first hurricane of an Atlantic season tamed by a historic El Niño weather phenomenon, and the first hurricane since 2024 to hit the U.S. mainland. At least four deaths were linked to the storm, including two people killed when trees fell onto homes. Nearly 700,000 customers were without power by midday. AFP

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

Why UAPA demands urgent reform

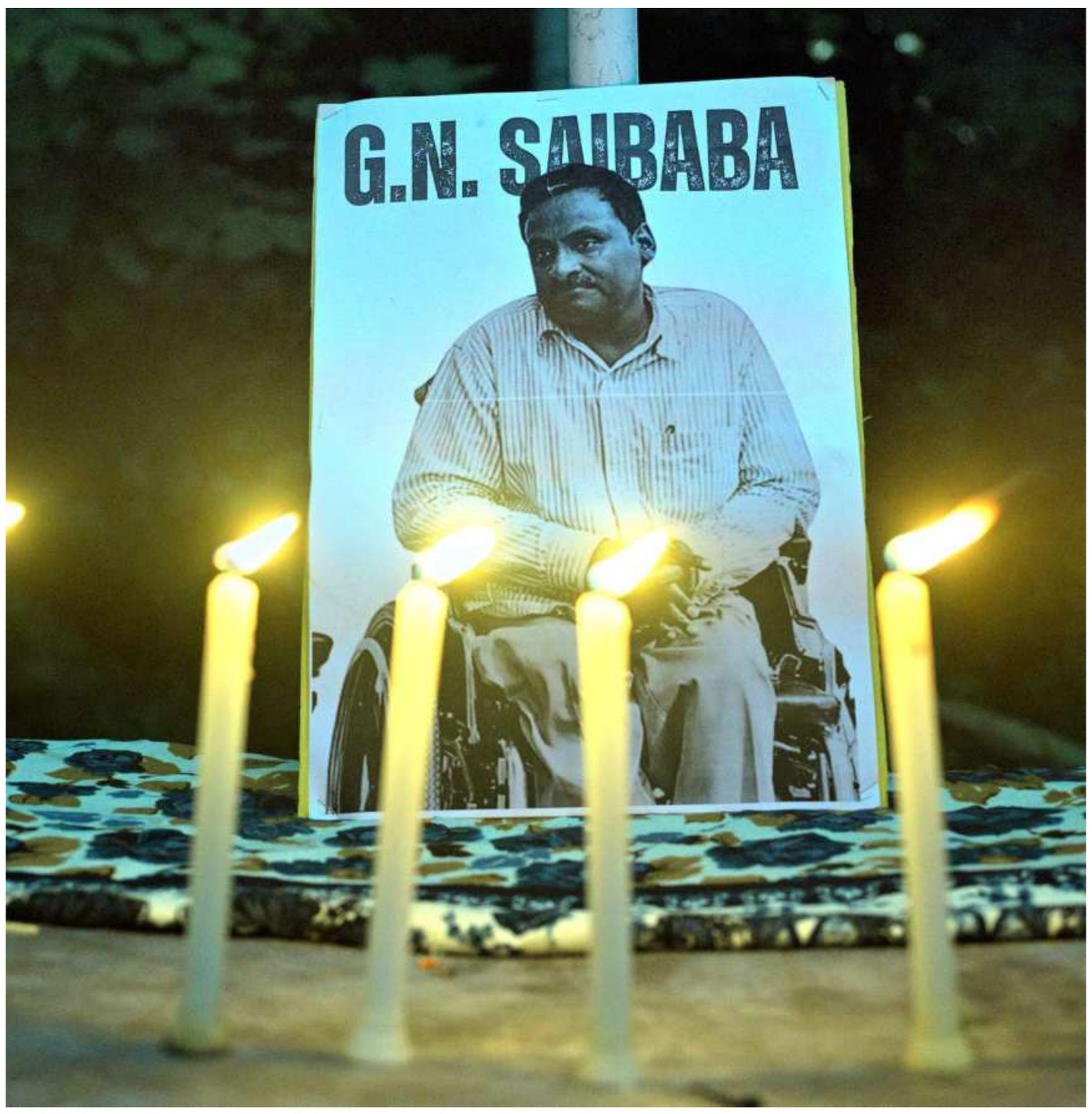
UAPA's vague provisions, stringent bail conditions and inconsistent judicial interpretations have enabled the prolonged imprisonment of activists, scholars and journalists without trial; Prof. G.N. Saibaba's experience shows the urgent need to reform a legal regime that undermines civil liberties, due process and rule of law

LETTER & SPIRIT

Gautam Bhatia

October 12 marks the second death anniversary of Professor G.N. Saibaba. Prof. Saibaba was a professor at Delhi University who was 90% physically disabled. He was arrested under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA) in 2014, on allegations of having links with Maoists. Denied bail, he remained in prison until a trial court convicted him in 2017 and sentenced him to life imprisonment – a judgment that this writer, in the pages of this newspaper, criticised at the time as being based entirely on guilt by association and insinuation.

Vindication eventually arrived in 2024, when the Bombay High Court acquitted him of all charges. By then, Professor Saibaba had spent a decade in prison, much of it in solitary confinement. In prison, his health had further deteriorated, and soon after his release, he passed away.



Candles lit in memory of Professor G.N. Saibaba at JNU on October 13, 2024. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

THE GIST

- Professor G.N. Saibaba was acquitted by the Bombay High Court in 2024 after spending a decade in prison under the UAPA, but died soon after his release as his health had deteriorated
- Activists, scholars and journalists accused under the UAPA, including those in the Bhima Koregaon and Delhi riots cases, have spent years in prison without trial, with bail often granted only after prolonged incarceration
- The Supreme Court has overturned judicial attempts to narrow the UAPA's provisions, while inconsistent interpretations of the law and delays in trials have expanded State discretion and weakened safeguards against arbitrary imprisonment

A law that punishes dissent

The anniversary of Professor Saibaba's death is an occasion to reflect on a legal regime that is designed to – quite literally – imprison dissent and deny justice. Over the years, the UAPA has been used to criminalise political opposition. Following the violence at the Bhima Koregaon commemoration event in 2018, UAPA charges were brought against 16 scholars and activists, all of whom were jailed. Eight years later, the trial has yet to begin, and the court has yet to frame charges against the accused.

Meanwhile, Father Stan Swamy died in custody after his health deteriorated. One after another, 14 of the remaining accused were granted bail, but only after spending years in prison without trial. Their bail conditions remain draconian and restrictive, imposing multiple reporting conditions, restricting travel and severely constraining their lives. The 16th prisoner, lawyer Surendra Gadling, was also granted bail in the case but remained in prison in connection with another case.

Similarly, after the Delhi riots in 2020, UAPA charges were levelled against multiple student leaders, scholars, and activists, accusing them of participating in, or being the brains behind, the riots. Notably, there was no direct evidence against any of these people, only vague charges of conspiracy and of being the "intellectual architects" of the riots.

While a few of these individuals were granted bail soon after, many students and scholars remained in jail for years, with their bail applications denied at all levels of the judiciary. It was only in early 2026, after more than five years in jail, that five of the seven appellants were granted bail by the Supreme Court. However, the Supreme Court denied bail to the remaining two – Sharjeel Imam and Umar Khalid – on the basis that they were "intellectual architects." The term "intellectual architect" is unknown to law and rests entirely on surmises and conjectures. The court also took the unusual step of effectively preventing Imam and Khalid from applying for bail for a year. It has now been more than six years – almost 10% of an average human lifespan – of imprisonment without trial. In the meantime, Khalid has published a book from prison, while Imam continues to work on his PhD, despite significant difficulties in accessing research materials.

In a third example, Khurram Parvez, a Kashmiri activist and the coordinator of the Jammu and Kashmir Coalition of Civil Society (JKCCS), was arrested under the UAPA in 2021 on allegations of terror financing and promoting secessionism. On March 20, 2023, a journalist, Irfan Mehraj, was also arrested and imprisoned in the case. The two were eventually granted bail in July 2026, after Parvez had spent five years in prison without trial.

The list of people who have spent years in jail under UAPA thus spans the length and breadth of the country: it also includes Soni Sori, the Adivasi leader who was allegedly tortured while in prison and eventually acquitted of all charges, Akhil Gogoi – the Assamese anti-CAA activist – and Siddique Kappan, the Kerala journalist who was arrested while travelling to Uttar Pradesh to cover the Hathras gangrape case, and spent two years in jail before eventually being granted bail by the Supreme Court.

The list also includes many other nameless people who do not have the same degree of public prominence, but have spent months and years of their lives in prison, under a law that defines offences in the vaguest of terms, and then makes the grant of bail virtually impossible.

Vague definitions

The UAPA, for example, criminalises "membership" of unlawful organisations without clarifying what the word "membership" means. It has a similar host of provisions that carry broad and vague wording, and which are susceptible to multiple interpretations – including, at their extreme, mere sloganeering or possession of literature.

The courts have not helped. On two occasions, judges have attempted to bring precision and narrowness to the UAPA to prevent, or at least mitigate, some of its excesses. Both attempts were overturned by the Supreme Court. In 2011, a Bench of the court restricted the term "membership" to "active membership", which in turn was defined to mean "incitement to violence." However, in 2023, acting under its "review jurisdiction" – which is only meant to correct "errors on the face of the record" – the Supreme Court overturned this judgment.

Similarly, in an early bail judgment in the Delhi riots cases, the Delhi High Court undertook an extensive analysis of the UAPA's "terrorism" clauses and gave them a specific, concrete interpretation to prevent wide discretion in their application. On appeal, however, the Supreme Court ruled that the judgment would "not be treated as precedent", thus rendering it effectively worthless as a statement of law. Thus, the UAPA's terms remain exceedingly broad and undefined, allowing State authorities wide leeway to bring almost any conduct within its scope by tenuously linking it to terrorism or unlawful activity.

The barriers to bail

Once that is done, the UAPA then makes the grant of bail extremely hard, by requiring the judge to deny bail if, on a reading of the police chargesheet, a prima facie case appears to be made out. Here again, courts have not helped: while one set of judges has accorded a degree of strict scrutiny to police chargesheets, another set has adopted an "eyes wide shut" approach that grants excessive deference to the police version. This inconsistency makes the grant of bail under the UAPA extremely judge-centric. Along with this, courts have also been inconsistent on the consequences of delay: the Supreme Court, for example, did not seem to think that five years in prison without trial was "excessive" delay when denying bail to Imam and Khalid, while other courts have held that five years does constitute excessive delay (for example, in the Khurram Parvez case).

All this leads to a state of affairs that is contrary to the rule of law and contrary to any legal system worth the name: a vague law with stringent punishments, that continues to be interpreted in a way that expands State discretion rather than contains it, and whose result then is long years of imprisonment without trial. The death anniversary of Professor Saibaba, one of the starkest victims of this system, reminds us yet again that an urgent rethink and reset of this system is necessary.

(Gautam Bhatia is a Delhi-based lawyer)

CACHE



Norway is not alone in addressing privacy risks surrounding wearable devices, as a patchwork of regulations and venue-specific restrictions are in progress across Europe and North America. REUTERS

Why is Norway considering a temporary smart glasses ban?

Norway is proposing temporary restrictions on smart glasses in public, sensitive spaces over concerns about covert recording, facial recognition and violations of privacy, as other countries explore similar curbs; this could affect device sales and push manufacturers to strengthen privacy safeguards

Haider Ali Khan

The story so far:

European regulators are training their sights on smart glasses, as the wearable device equipped with high-definition cameras, ambient audio recording, and artificial intelligence is becoming common in Europe, blurring the lines between technological innovation and citizens' privacy.

Norway is taking the lead as its government prepares a proposal seeking a temporary ban on smart glasses in select public and sensitive locations. Led by Minister of Digitalisation and Public Governance Torgeir Micaelsen, the initiative pauses device usage in places where individuals expect personal privacy.

What does the proposal seek?

The temporary restrictions target places frequented by children, including schools, playgrounds, and youth clubs, healthcare facilities, fitness centres, locker rooms, public beaches, parks, museums, and concert venues. Crucially, the government is not proposing a ban on sales of the devices or prohibiting their use in private.

Instead, the proposal is asking an expert committee to evaluate the technological challenges and formulate lasting legal frameworks. Oslo has already banned smart glasses across municipal schools.

The core argument behind Norway's intervention centres on the lack of consent in public spaces. Traditional smartphones require users to visibly hold up a device to record video or snap photos, providing a clear signal to surrounding people. In contrast, smart glasses allow wearers to capture high-resolution imagery, record ambient audio, or live-stream video directly at eye level without offering clear cues to bystanders.

This creates a surveillance system where citizens cannot easily determine whether they are being recorded. Privacy risks are especially acute in sensitive settings like changing rooms and medical clinics, or where unauthorised filming of children raises safety concerns. Furthermore, officials have highlighted risks surrounding real-time facial recognition software. When combined with AI eyewear, facial recognition could enable wearers to instantly identify strangers, access personal data, or facilitate doxxing. Norway's proposed rules acknowledge that traditional privacy frameworks were not designed for head-worn, ambient recording technology.

Is any other country attempting a similar moratorium?

Norway is not alone in addressing privacy risks surrounding wearable devices, as a patchwork of regulations and venue-specific restrictions are in progress across Europe and North America.

In the Netherlands and Germany, eyewear retailer Hans Anders suspended sales of Meta's Ray-Ban smart glasses across its Dutch and Belgian stores while awaiting regulatory clarity. Dutch lawmakers have discussed rules that await guidance from the European Data Protection Board (EDPB). Meanwhile, Hamburg is exploring regional restrictions.

The UK Cinema Association established guidelines restricting or prohibiting camera-equipped glasses in movie theatres to combat piracy and protect the privacy of viewers. Additionally, courts in England and Wales require visitors to surrender smart glasses at security checkpoints.

In the United States, several nightclubs, gyms, and courts in New York have implemented localised bans. California's governor vetoed legislation penalising covert recording in private spaces, but debate continues among state policymakers on next steps.

In Bangkok, smart glasses use is restricted in certain pubs and public places.

How are manufacturers of smart glasses adapting to this regulatory landscape?

To address privacy concerns, hardware manufacturers have built technical safeguards into current-generation devices. Devices such as Ray-Ban Meta glasses feature a white light-emitting diode (LED) on the frame beside the lens. The LED blinks when capturing photos and stays lit continuously during video recording.

Manufacturers have deployed firmware updates that detect if the LED indicator is covered or obstructed. If light obstruction is detected, the system automatically disables the camera's functionality. Devices enforce caps on continuous recording duration and play audible shutter sounds when taking photos.

But privacy advocates have said that small LED lights remain difficult to spot in bright, sunlit conditions or crowded environments, rendering hardware safeguards insufficient for complete bystander protection.

How will the moratorium impact device sales?

Although Norway's proposal focuses on restricting device usage rather than banning sales, the commercial impact on manufacturers could be substantial. The primary selling point of smart glasses is their seamless integration into daily public life. Restricting their use in public spaces like parks, beaches, shopping centres, and fitness clubs undermines their utility, rendering a versatile daily-use accessory into a device restricted to home use.

In addition, voluntary retail suspensions such as the sales halt by Hans Anders create immediate revenue hits in the European market. Regulatory uncertainty across different regions introduces consumer hesitation, discouraging buyers who worry about purchasing expensive hardware that might soon face usage restrictions in public.

How might smart glasses makers tweak functionality?

To comply with evolving privacy standards and maintain consumer trust, manufacturers may likely re-engineer both hardware and software features by implementing larger, brighter, or colour-shifting LED indicators, alongside louder audio signals that cannot be silenced.

Software updates could incorporate AI-driven face-blurring and audio pitch modification, redacting bystander identities before footage is saved or streamed. Smart glasses could utilise GPS data to automatically disable recording capabilities when entering designated privacy zones like schools, hospitals, or locker rooms. Manufacturers can explicitly block facial recognition software and APIs to prevent real-time profiling in public spaces.

Companies are expanding lines to include audio-focused smart glasses without cameras (such as Ray-Ban Meta Audio), catering to users who want AI features without privacy concerns.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Test your knowledge of the Salem witch trials, where mass hysteria, religious fanaticism and judicial injustice led to accusations and executions

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
In which years did the Salem witch trials take place?

QUESTION 2
Which accused farmer was executed on August 19, 1692, after maintaining his innocence during the trials?

QUESTION 3
Which accused man was subjected to *peine forte et dure*, a form of judicial torture involving the application of heavy weights, after refusing to enter a plea?

QUESTION 4
How many people were hanged during the Salem witch trials, and how many others died in prison?

QUESTION 5
What was the name of the enslaved woman whose confession played a pivotal role in the early witchcraft accusations?



Visual Question:
This 1953 play by Arthur Miller dramatises the Salem witch trials and uses them as an allegory for political persecution in 20th-century America. Name the play. FRED FEHL/FRED FEHL COLLECTION, NEW YORK PUBLIC LIBRARY FOR THE PERFORMING ARTS

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. In 2018, no Nobel Prize in Literature was announced. It was postponed and awarded along with the 2019 Nobel. Why? Who won the 2018 Nobel Prize in Literature? **Ans: Due to a sexual abuse and financial crimes scandal involving Jean-Claude Arnault, an influential figure on the Swedish cultural scene and husband of Academy member and poet Katarina Frostenson; Olga Tokarczuk**
2. Which singer-songwriter won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2016? **Ans: Bob Dylan**
3. This Nobel laureate's work includes *Sula, Beloved, The Bluest Eye, Jazz*, etc. She was the first Black woman to win the Nobel Prize in Literature. **Ans: Toni Morrison**
4. An upcoming dystopian science fiction film is based on a book by a Nobel laureate. Name the book and the author. Ans: ***Klara and the Sun*** by Kazuo Ishiguro
5. This philosopher, political activist, and writer was the only awardee to decline the Nobel Prize in Literature. **Ans: Jean-Paul Sartre**
Visual: This image shows the poet and novelist receiving the news that he won the Nobel Prize in Literature. However, he later rejected the award. **Ans: Boris Pasternak**
Early Birds: Aman kumar | Tamal Biswas | Arun Kumar Singh | Gauri Malviya



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

I am afraid we can't offer you the job

She refused to collaborate with her temperamental colleague

S. Upendran

Is it okay to use the word 'dinner' for an afternoon meal? (V Janaki, Trivandrum)
Yes, it is; on Christmas Day, some people have their traditional Christmas dinner around two in the afternoon. The word 'dinner' comes from the French 'disner', and in 13th-century England, the word was used to refer to the first meal of the day – anything that people had to eat between early morning and noon. So, what we today refer to as 'breakfast' and 'lunch' was called 'dinner' in the past. With the passage of time, however, the terms 'breakfast' and 'lunch' were introduced to refer to what we eat in the morning and afternoon – and as a result, the word 'dinner' was used to refer to the last meal of the day. In countries like Britain, 'dinner' continues to be used to refer to the main meal of the day – a meal where an individual's intake is the maximum. So, if your main meal is in the afternoon, you can call it 'dinner'.

We're planning to have an early dinner before leaving for the airport.

What is the difference between 'collaborate' and 'corroborate'? (J Mukund, Hyderabad)
Although the two words sound somewhat similar, they have very different meanings. In terms of pronunciation, both words have the same number of syllables – four each. The vowels in the first and third syllables sound like the 'a' in 'china'. The second syllable in 'collaborate' is pronounced like the word 'lab', while in the case of 'corroborate', it sounds like the word 'rob'. The final syllable in both words is pronounced 'rate'. The two words are pronounced 'ke-LAB-e-rate' and 'ke-ROB-e-rate' respectively, with the stress on the second syllable.

When you 'collaborate' with someone, you work with him on something – it could be a project, report, etc. You team up with another individual; in other words, the two of you 'labour' (col-labor-ate) together! This is one way of remembering the meaning of the word.

Satish is very temperamental. No one wants to collaborate with him on the project.

When you 'corroborate', you provide evidence or proof for something that you or someone else has said. It is a word frequently used in a court of law and in the field of science.

Our findings did not corroborate the new hypothesis.

What is the meaning of 'I'm afraid' in the sentence "I'm afraid I can't help you"? (S Vinita, Vizag)
In isolation, the word 'afraid' is normally used to mean 'scared'. Some children, for example, are afraid of dogs, while many are afraid of being alone in the dark. In the expression 'I'm afraid', however, 'afraid' does not express fear. In informal contexts, the expression is used when you have bad news to pass on to someone; the use of 'afraid' is meant to soften the blow of the message you are about to deliver. When you preface a statement with 'I'm afraid', it means 'I'm sorry to say'.
upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Polemical:
of or involving dispute or controversy

Synonyms: contentious, aggressive, stubborn, irritable, disputatious

Usage: *The politician is known for his polemical remarks.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/polemical

International Phonetic Alphabet: /pəlemɪkəl/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

'Excess': More to pay, not more to receive

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

When you read your insurance policy, if you read it, you may come across a term called 'excess'. Usually, it says 'excess on this policy is ₹1,000' or something like that.

And no, it does not mean the insurance company is going to give you something extra.

It means the exact opposite, that you will pay something. In this case, the first ₹1,000 of each claim in this policy. The insurance company starts paying only after you have picked up your share.

Some policies have a compulsory excess. You can also opt for a voluntary excess which will be over and above any compulsory excess.

Why ever would you opt for bearing part of your own claim? Because of the small silver lining that you get a premium discount for it.

And we all love discounts, remember?

The general insurance industry is reportedly considering imposing a compulsory co-payment of 10% of the claim amount on all new hospitalisation policies from the new year in lieu of a lower premium.

'Deductible'

An excess is also called a 'deductible'. A close cousin is 'co-payment' which denotes that you bear a percentage of the claim rather than a flat sum.

The principle behind all this is risk-sharing. You have heard of profit-sharing; this is loss-sharing. You retain a small part of the risk and the insurance company takes on the rest.

An excess discourages small claims that can cost an insurance company disproportionately in administrative time, paperwork and money. If repairing that scratch on your car costs around your deductible amount, you won't claim. You will choose cost-effective hospital treatment options because you are going to bear part of it.

But should you opt for a voluntary excess? Suppose a ₹2,500 voluntary excess on your car means a ₹750 discount on the Own Damage premium and you have no claim that year, then you are ₹750 ahead. If you have a claim that crosses ₹750, that saving has disappeared. You could end up bearing up to ₹2,500 to save ₹750. So, it's a view for you to take.

Dissect the discount

You will come across excesses in many personal insurance policies. Motor Own Damage policies have a regulator mandated deductible on every claim, with no premium discount for it. Health policies can have deductibles and co-payments. Travel policies frequently have excesses too. Home insurance has them in some covers and add-ons. The idea remains the same: a specified first part of the loss stays with you.

A spin-off series!

And then there is an insurance product built around the idea of excess.

A hospitalisation top-up policy has a pre-agreed deductible called a threshold. If it is set at ₹10 lakh, the top-up responds only after your bills are more than that.

The expenses up to ₹10 lakh should be met by your basic hospitalisation policy or from your pocket. That is also why top-ups can offer large sums insured at relatively attractive premiums. The insurer is not paying from rupee one and smaller claims are more likely and more frequent. So, when your policy says 'excess', don't get carried away by the English. In insurance, 'excess' is one thing you are not getting more of.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



Whither safety: Where money once left a paper trail, it now casts a perpetual digital shadow. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

When our meandering money leaves a mark

If every penny we spend leaves a digital footprint, what happens when strangers follow that indelible trail? For, a trail of transactions can reveal who a person actually is

PRIVACY PARADOX

Sincy Wilson
Vaishali R. Venkat

A cup of coffee, a grab of hot samosas, a premium movie ticket, the book you bought, a health insurance policy you opted for, a stock or mutual fund you invested in, a debt you cleared and what not? From the first Rupee spent to the last one of the month, our financial journey is increasingly out there in the open. Not just us; our money's meandering voyage is also under the scanner.

Money has always left clues in every hand it touches. For instance, from the ledger books of ancient times, one could glean how affluent or frugal a family was, how much it spent, how much it saved and how much it borrowed. Yet, following such a manual trail, leaf by leaf through voluminous, timeworn tomes, was an arduous task, like tracing a tiny creature through a dense forest by the faint paw marks it left behind. In stark contrast to the dust-ridden ledgers, today, we live in the era of digital wallets. The money-paws of our transactions can be traced from mice to monkeys to monsters, all at the click of a button.

Where money once left a paper trail, it now casts a perpetual digital shadow. So, what happens when a stranger wanders into our digital woods?

> The information in our meandering money trail is not a ball that can simply be passed from one player to another; legal safeguards come into play at every stage

To cut a long story short: If every Rupee leaves a trace, are we giving away a slice of our 'financial privacy'? Every single Rupee we spend can reveal something about us: our tastes, interests, habits, preferences, priorities and even our way of life. A transaction may record an amount, but a trail of transactions can reveal who a person actually is.

Yet, safeguarding our so-called 'financial privacy' does not mean that we must return to a time when our money's journey left fewer footprints. Once we progress, there is no looking back to the dusty past. No doubt, digital money is the way forward, and for predominantly good reasons: instant payments, round-the-clock access to financial services, automatic records of transactions, easier tracking of monthly expenditure, seamless payment of subscriptions, instant execution of investments, quicker loan processing, instant alerts for unusual or fraudulent transactions, handy proof of payments, reduction in the costs of printing or handling currency, and much more. Why should we lose all these advantages in the name of 'privacy'?

> The real power lies not in erasing our money footprints, but in learning to notice them, interpret them and, ultimately, master our own money

Yet, on the flip side, the very convenience that digital money offers comes with a trade-off. The same digital trail that makes our financial lives faster also creates a vast pool of information about us. The question now is not whether we should leave a digital trail at all in the first place, but to know how we can use that information to study our own financial behaviour and be aware of what happens to the information left behind.

This drives us naturally to another question: who gets to see this information, and what protection does the law provide for it? The Constitution of India recognises privacy as a fundamental right; but does that extend to our financial lives as well? After all, the right to privacy is not an absolute right to live without leaving any trace. The Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 addresses this tension.

While the Constitution provides the foundation for our fundamental right to live with dignity and autonomy, the DPDP Act provides a modern legal framework to protect personal data in the digital world. Perhaps, the DPDP Act is a form of digital armour. It acts as a guardrail by regulating how our personal data is collected, processed and used. The law labels the banks, apps, and platforms that determine why and how our personal data is processed as *Data Fiduciaries*. Thus, the information in our meandering money trail is not a ball that can simply be passed from one player to another; legal safeguards come into play at every stage.

Let's face it. We may not have much say in stopping the digital trails that feed external algorithms. Yet, we can turn the same trail into a money mirror: one that tracks our cash flow, spots leakages, curbs unnecessary expenditure and helps us make better investment choices. The trail that tells others about us can also teach us about ourselves. Perhaps, the real power lies not in erasing our money footprints, but in learning to notice them, interpret them and, ultimately, master our own money.

(Dr. Sincy Wilson is an assistant professor of Law and a legal researcher specialising in constitutional and administrative law. Dr. Vaishali R. Venkat is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Investing in sector and thematic funds

THINKINVESTOR

Sectoral and thematic funds are structured as active funds or passive funds (either index funds or ETFs)

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Asset management companies continually launch new fund offers (NFOs). In the recent times, several of the NFOs have been sectoral funds and thematic funds. In this article, we discuss whether such funds fit into your investment portfolio.

Sector funds are positioned to bet on specific sectors such as the banking sector and chemicals sector. Thematic funds are positioned to take a bet on multiple sectors at the same time. Defense, for instance, has been a popular theme in recent times. This theme constitutes capital goods, automobile and chemicals sectors. Sectoral and thematic funds are structured as active funds or passive funds (either index funds or ETFs).

We explore how these funds fit into your portfolio from a core-satellite framework. The core portfolio is a goal-based portfolio whereas the satellite portfolio is a trading portfolio. You can also look at the core portfolio as a bet primarily on market movements and the satellite portfolio as a bet to beat the market. Beating the market means you are expecting to earn alpha- returns greater than a benchmark index. You can do this in two ways. One, trade actively in the market. So, market timing becomes the primary factor in generating alpha. Alternatively, you can bet on sectors through sector funds. While betting on sectors is much better than betting on individual stocks, you must have a view on which sector is likely to do well in the near term. Typically, sector funds and thematic funds are launched in response to market interest, not necessarily in anticipation of sectors doing well in the future. You could instead look at funds that are focused on mid-cap and small-cap stocks. Such funds are likely to rotate across sectors based on fund managers' forecast of near-term sector movements.

You must be mindful that mid-cap (small-cap) active funds do not invest only in mid-cap (small-cap) stocks. SEBI regulation allows these funds to invest 35% outside of their chosen benchmark. If you want pure exposure to mid-cap (small-cap) stocks, you must buy units of mid-cap (small-cap) index fund or mid-cap ETF. It is important that you have an outlook on the mid-cap or small-cap index. For instance, you must have a view that mid-caps are likely to outperform other styles (large-cap and small-cap) in the near term. That requires understanding of technical analysis. You can also subscribe to fee-based technical analysis research to enable you to bet on sectors or themes.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	**Interest Rate (%)**	**EMI (Rs)**	**EMI (Rs)**	**Processing fee**
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.75	10,550-12,093	2,110-2,419	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.70 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 1%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	**Interest Rate (%)**	**EMI (Rs)**	**Processing fee**
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	Up to 0.25%
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.50-9.30	10,019 - 10,452	NIL (Till 31.12.2026)
Federal Bank	7.90-9.00	10,114 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
HDFC Bank	8.25 onwards	10,198 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs. 2,500
Indian Bank	7.55-9.65	10,031 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.16-11.66	10,177 - 11,037	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,647	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.30 - 9.35	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 4,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

*0.25% rate concession for home loan borrowers/other customers with at least 6 months banking relationship
**50% waiver on processing fee till December 31
***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on October 7 **Source: Paisabazaar.com**

Insurance reforms: Need for a balanced approach



The IBAI questioned the fundamental position of the regulator on expenses of management. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

G. Naga Sridhar

The insurance industry is now at a crossroads, thanks to the significant line up of regulatory reforms which have now become a widely debated topic among the insurers and all other stakeholders.

In September, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), in a consultation paper, proposed a slew of distribution reforms. While the industry has been expecting distribution reforms for a long time, the proposals were perhaps the most radical in their nature in the regulatory regime so far in the recent past. As per the consultation paper, "Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution" released on September 23, 2026, the regulator said that the regulation would put in place a "customer-centric, competitive, efficient and transparent distribution ecosystem, while enabling better and sustainable outcomes for policyholders, insurers and distributors''.

The key proposals include recalibration of expenses of management (EoM) through lower limits with a phased glide path. For life insurers, the EoM limit would move to a company-level basis linked to Gross Direct Premium Income (GDPI), with the limit proposed at 15% within two years and 12.5% within five years. For general insurers, the basis would shift from Gross Written Premium (GWP) to domestic Gross Direct Premium Income (GDPI), with the EoM limit reducing from 30% of GWP to 20% of GDPI within five years, also through progressive annual reductions.

Other key proposals seek to eliminate scope for regulatory arbitrage, removal of restrictions on non-insurance business opportunities for intermediaries, easing up of entry and capital requirements, lower limits on expenses management, and revision of commission norms.

The authority proposed to replace the existing complex and fragmented architecture with three broad categories of distribution entities namely Insurance Distribution Entities (IDEs), Insurance Distribution Persons (IDPs) and Market Infrastructure Institutions (MIIs). The proposed distribution architecture is guided by the principle of "same structure, same functions, same norms,'' IRDAI said.

All stakeholders, except policyholders, have raised serious concerns regarding the proposals of the authority. While the insurers are yet to officially come out with their reactions to the proposed changes, they have already expressed significant reservations to the authority.

"The dialogue with the regulator has already commenced and it is on. We have submitted our objections to some of the proposals that could adversely affect operational dynamics for insurance companies,'' the MD & CEO of a general insurance company told *businessline* on the condition of anonymity. "From an industry perspective, I suppose the resistance from the insurance companies is very strong compared to any other regulatory changes brought in so far,'' he added.

The Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBAI) also voiced its strong opposition in its response submitted to the authority. It questioned the fundamental position of the regulator on the expenses of management by saying: "the evidence does not support the remedy'' and argued that the total expenses of management in general insurance fell from 28.2% of premium in FY23 to 26.5% in FY25, while premium grew about 13% a year and the reported rise in commission largely reflects reclassification of payments previously booked under other heads, which the paper acknowledges.

"Where cost is high, the consultation paper's own figures place it in forced sales where the policyholder has no choice: loan-linked credit life pays 42-45%; dealer controlled motor pays up to 75%. Independent brokers and agents average 17-18% and brokers serving corporate clients 6-11%; the remedy nevertheless caps every channel, the customer's own broker lowest.'' it said.

In a letter to PM Narendra Modi on October 2, IBAI cautioned that the implementation of the proposed reforms would result in loss of jobs, growth and reduce competition in the industry.

According to Narendra Bharindwal , President, IBAI, the intervention of the PM has been sought so that no regulation on commission or expense limits is notified without a published impact assessment covering policyholders, employment, public sector insurers and foreign investment, and the 2023 framework runs till its scheduled 2028 review.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

WHO prequalifies Serum Institute's quadrivalent HPV vaccine CERVAVAC

CERVAVAC is the first Indian-made quadrivalent HPV vaccine to receive WHO prequalification; This prequalification means the vaccine has met WHO standards for quality, safety and efficacy; The development is significant for India as well as the global effort to prevent cervical cancer

EXPLAINER

Bindu Shajan Perappadan

The Serum Institute of India's indigenously developed quadrivalent human papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine, CERVAVAC, has received prequalification from the World Health Organization (WHO), allowing the vaccine to be procured by United Nations agencies and potentially supplied to countries running HPV immunisation programmes. The WHO lists its prequalification as effective from September 25, 2026.

The development is significant for India as well as the global effort to prevent cervical cancer. CERVAVAC is India's first indigenously developed gender-neutral quadrivalent HPV vaccine and targets HPV types 6, 11, 16 and 18. It is licensed in India for girls and boys aged 9 to 26 years.

CERVAVAC is the first Indian-made quadrivalent HPV vaccine to receive WHO prequalification. This prequalification means the vaccine has met WHO standards for quality, safety and efficacy, following evaluation of data, samples and manufacturing sites.

Globally, cervical cancer caused an estimated 6,04,000 new cases and 3,42,000 deaths in 2020. In India, where cervical cancer remains a public-health burden, the national HPV vaccination programme was launched on February 28, 2026, targeting about 1.2 crore 14-year-old girls with a free single dose; more than 80 lakh doses had been administered by September this year, according to the Union Health Ministry. India's national HPV vaccination programme uses Merck's Gardasil-4, a quadrivalent vaccine protecting against HPV types 6, 11, 16 and 18.



A vaccine already licensed in India can now potentially enter international procurement channels used to supply national immunisation programmes, particularly in low- and middle-income countries. AFP

India also has an indigenous quadrivalent vaccine, CERVAVAC (now WHO-prequalified) and access to other HPV vaccines, including Gardasil 9 and Cervarix, through the private market.

> CERVAVAC is India's first indigenously developed gender-neutral quadrivalent HPV vaccine and targets HPV types 6, 11, 16 and 18. It is licensed for girls and boys aged 9 to 26 years

Biggest significance

WHO prequalification's biggest significance is access. A vaccine that has already been licensed in India can now potentially enter international procurement channels used to supply national immunisation programmes, particularly in low- and middle-income countries.

WHO prequalification is not a marketing authorisation or regulatory approval. For the prequalification, the vaccine undergoes assessment of its quality, safety and efficacy, including evaluation of data, testing of samples and inspection of manufacturing facilities. A vaccine that meets WHO standards is placed on the WHO List of Prequalified Vaccines, making it eligible for procurement by United Nations agencies and giving countries an internationally recognised assurance about the product and manufacturing standards.

What is HPV

HPV is an extremely common sexually transmitted infection. Most infections clear naturally, but persistent infection with high-risk HPV types can lead to cervical cancer. WHO estimates that persistent infection with high-risk HPV types causes more than 95% of cervical cancers. HPV can also cause anal, vulval, vaginal and some other cancers, as well as genital warts.

The vaccine is a cancer-prevention vaccine and not just a vaccine against an infection. WHO's priority target is girls aged 9–14 years, before exposure to HPV. The organisation recommends either a one- or two-dose schedule for this age group, depending on the vaccine and national programme.

The four HPV types targeted by CERVAVAC are important for different reasons. HPV 16 and 18 are high-risk types responsible for a large proportion of cervical cancers.

Types 6 and 11 are responsible for most anogenital warts. The quadrivalent vaccine therefore provides protection against both cancer-associated HPV types and genital warts.

Its indication for both sexes also matters. Although cervical cancer is the largest component of the HPV disease burden, HPV can cause disease in men, including anal cancer and genital warts.

What it means for India

CERVAVAC's WHO prequalification does not automatically mean that it will now be substituted into the Indian government programme. Vaccine selection for a national programme involves considerations including regulatory status, evidence, price, supply capacity, presentations, logistics and programme requirements.

But the new status gives India another WHO-prequalified HPV vaccine from a domestic manufacturer. It could also potentially strengthen competition and supply security if CERVAVAC is considered for future procurement.

Other Indian vaccines

India already has a substantial presence on the WHO prequalified-vaccine list. Serum Institute is among the largest Indian participants. The company has WHO-prequalified vaccines covering a wide range of diseases, including BCG, diphtheria-tetanus-pertussis combinations, hepatitis B, Haemophilus influenzae type b, measles, measles-rubella, measles-mumps-rubella, meningococcal disease, pneumococcal disease, polio, rabies, rotavirus, rubella and malaria, among others.

Other Indian manufacturers with WHO-prequalified vaccines include Bharat Biotech, Biological E, Zydus Lifesciences, GreenSignal Bio Pharma, Haffkine and Panacea Biotec, among others.

Bharat Biotech's Typbar-TCV, for example, was the first typhoid conjugate vaccine to receive WHO prequalification; Zydus's ZyVac TCV received WHO prequalification in September 2026.

The HPV milestone is distinctive because, until now, WHO's prequalified HPV portfolio consisted of vaccines manufactured outside India.

WHO's HPV product-choice document lists bivalent vaccines such as Cecolin, Cervarix and Walrinvax, quadrivalent Gardasil, and nonavalent Gardasil-9. CERVAVAC was previously nationally licensed but was not WHO-prequalified.

Its inclusion therefore adds an Indian-made HPV vaccine to the global WHO-prequalified pool.

For India, the larger significance is that a vaccine developed and manufactured domestically can now potentially contribute not only to India's cervical-cancer prevention programme but also to HPV vaccination programmes elsewhere.

Global target

The WHO's global target is to have 90% of girls fully vaccinated against HPV by age 15, alongside screening and treatment targets for women.

By the end of 2025, HPV vaccination had been introduced in 165 countries, but global first-dose coverage among girls was only about 33%, well below the 90% target.

Massive regulatory crackdown reshaping F&B sector

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

Gone are the days when food safety was a routine compliance check that a quality manager in a company would take care of. Today, it is a high stakes boardroom topic inside India's F&B companies, a priority driven by aggressive regulators on one side and social media vigilantes on the other.

A sweeping nationwide crackdown by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) and State Food and Drug Administrations is forcing packaged food brands, tech platforms, and hospitality giants to drastically overhaul their compliance frameworks and in some cases redo their labelling.

With hyper-vigilant consumers calling out brands and retailers on social media and tagging enforcement agencies, the fear of a raid is real. Equally, a legal pushback is happening as companies are questioning interpretations and as a result a lot more food regulation-related litigation is happening.

The panic – and the pivot – is visible across the entire supply chain. Ashwin Bhadri, Founder & CEO, Equinox Labs said, the firm has seen a rise in R&D sample testing orders by almost 200% in the past two months that involves checks on shelf life, nutritional profile and quality parameters of products.

The company is also now inundated with requests for second party audits for dark stores and dark kitchens.



Food safety officials in action in Bengaluru. FILE PHOTO

Food safety is moving from the back room to the boardroom, says Mr. Bhadri, pointing out, "Larger established players are getting more conscious about their compliance and safety frameworks than they were in the past and asking us to conduct internal audits for them."

The anxiety is even more acute for India's booming Direct-to-Consumer (D2C) ecosystem. "Many D2C brands and smaller players are coming to us to help them adhere to quality and safety parameters," Mr. Bhadri added.

"They understand that even a single food safety issue or complaint can erode their brand equity overnight. We have begun creating quality annual operating plans for our clients to enable them to follow safety and quality standards as they raise funds to scale up fast, add more vendors, warehouses and distribution channels. I am getting a few calls from such companies every other week for guidance on these issues."

The hospitality sector is feeling the heat too. Hotels and restaurants are stepping up staff training.

Pradeep Shetty, Vice President, FHRAI and Hon. Secretary, Hotel And Restaurant Association (Western India), says, "We have consistently contributed practical recommendations to help shape regulations that uphold high standards of food safety while remaining workable for hospitality establishments. Through FoSTaC training programmes conducted in partnership with FSSAI, HRAWI has trained and certified 4,108 food handlers across hotels and restaurants in the five States within our region since 2017."

The efforts have been doubled now, he says.

"In view of the recent enforcement actions, we have intensified our efforts to train food safety handlers and supervisors. Additionally, we are advising our members to conduct more frequent internal audits on a weekly basis to identify and address any compliance gaps."

One immediate fallout of the regulatory scrutiny is a reallocation of corporate budgets towards food safety frameworks. With FSSAI being quick to respond to netizens' complaints on social media, directing them to its Food Safety Connect app, companies are already feeling the consequences. Last Thursday for instance, FSSAI suspended the licence of Shreyas Retail following a deluge of 130 consumer complaints, 70 of which alleged the sale of rotten or expired food.

Forcing shifts

Yet, this intense scrutiny is proving to be a massive catalyst for India's organised, branded food players. Many big companies that were compliant on safety are talking about finally getting a level-playing field as the regulatory spotlight is actively wiping out counterfeit and unorganised segments, particularly in the dairy sector.

Several states have decided to ban sale and manufacturing of analogue paneer. FSSAI is also in the process of bringing in amendments in regulations to restrict manufacture and sale of analogue products as paneer nationwide.

Leading dairy players say this has led to a strengthening of the shift towards branded paneer products not just in the B2C but also B2B channels.

Demand for branded paneer has shot up and players such as Mother Dairy are witnessing 60-70% increase quarter-on-quarter.

Tech platforms are joining the clean-up act too. In August, Zomato announced a zero-tolerance policy on the sale of analogue dairy dishes by restaurants listed on its platform, reserving the right to remove any listing found in violation.

It asked restaurant partners to take immediate corrective actions including transition to natural dairy products, remove items containing analogue dairy products from the menu and ensure accurate representation in terms of product labels and ingredient declarations provided by suppliers.

Rival Swiggy, meanwhile, launched a dedicated 24x7 helpline for customers to report any food safety related concerns. It also introduced a dedicated 'Food Safety' channel within its in-app Help section.

Raids and arrests

Overall, there has been a significant rise in enforcement action across the country . During April 1-August 31, food safety enforcement agencies conducted 7.05 lakh inspections and 13,203 raids while issuing 8151 notices to food business operators. This led to suspension of 677 food licenses and 105 food registrations and also resulted in seizure of 35.48 lakh kgs and 86,921 litres of food products at a reported value of ₹42.01 crore.

FSSAI officials recently told *businessline* that more than 100 companies that were pulled up for misleading claims or non-compliant labels have changed labels. More than 600 people have been arrested or prosecuted in the past few months for violations.

"There is much more awareness among consumers about safety and they are demanding stringent actions. State FDAs have recruited more food safety officers through Public Service Commissions, which have also been asked to expedite the process," officials noted.

On the other hand, companies are fighting back. A slew of companies raging from alcobev players to energy drinks and food firms are seeking legal recourse over some of the enforcement actions.

"Earlier we used to file two-three petitions in a year related to the food safety Act. We have filed as many as 23 petitions in the past three months. So there has been a rise in litigation with some of the larger players taking legal recourse as there are disagreements between how the food safety regulator is interpreting some of the existing regulations. In some of the recent cases, where companies have got stay on regulatory orders have been due to procedures followed by the authorities," said a lawyer, who specialises in food safety regulation cases, but did not wish to be identified.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

CONCORD

Shooting leaves 9 dead including suspect in Pennsylvania, police say



GETTY IMAGES

A man killed eight people including a pregnant woman, children and other relatives at his home in Erie, Pennsylvania, before taking his own life as well, U.S. authorities said on Saturday. Erie Police Chief Rick Lorah said the 45-year-old man was related to seven of the victims in the previous day's shooting. AP

KATHMANDU

Nepal flash floods sweep away houses, five people missing



AFP

Flash floods hit central Nepal on Sunday, sweeping away about 45 houses and leaving at least five people missing, officials said, weeks after devastating flooding that killed hundreds. Three hydropower projects and four bridges were damaged. Evacuation efforts were hastened as water levels in the Budhi Gandaki continued to rise. AFP

ISTANBUL

11 killed, 27 hurt as coach crashes into truck in Turkey: authorities



AFP

Eleven people were killed and 27 hurt in western Turkey on Sunday when a coach turned over after colliding with a truck, authorities said. The coach crashed near the entry to a motorway between the city of Bursa and the seaside city of Izmir, the governor's office of the local Manisa district said on X, stating the toll. AFP

NAIROBI

139 migrants dead, 84 missing as boat capsizes off Djibouti: UN



AFP

At least 139 migrants died, including 15 children, and 84 went missing when an overcrowded boat sank while heading from Djibouti to Yemen, the UN's International Organization for Migration said on Sunday. The boat was carrying 305 people when it capsized north of the Djibouti town of Obock on the night of October 8-9. AFP

Riyadh airport struck again a day after 12 killed in Houthi escalation

300 people wounded in Saturday's strikes and airport was still closed on Sunday; Indian embassy says one citizen killed and at least 10 others injured; Trump says he is planning to speak to Saudi crown prince as as he weighs joining the fight

Associated Press
CAIRO

A projectile struck a passenger terminal at the international airport in Riyadh on Sunday, a day after a missile hit the same terminal and killed 12 people, the Saudi-led coalition fighting Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen said. The Houthis claimed responsibility for those attacks and others.

Saudi authorities said there were injuries in the latest attack on the King Khalid International Airport complex for terminals 3 and 4 for domestic flights. Saturday's missile attack was the deadliest in a Gulf Arab nation since the Iran war began, with another 300 people wounded, some critically. The airport was still closed on Sunday.



A file photo shows King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh. Terminals for domestic flights were attacked on Sunday. AFP

The sharp escalation in the new front threatens to draw in greater U.S. military involvement, as President Donald Trump has said he is weighing joining the fight against the Houthis. There was no immediate White House comment on Sunday.

The latest strike in Riyadh came shortly after the Houthis said the airport in the rebel-held Yemeni capital of Sanaa had been struck again, and blamed the Saudis.

India's embassy in Saudi Arabia said one of its citizens died on Sunday of injuries sustained in Saturday's attack, which would bring the toll to 13. The embassy said at least 10 other Indians were among those injured in the attack.

U.S. intervention

Mr. Trump on Saturday also said he planned to speak with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, who has been seeking assistance.

A U.S. intervention could prompt the Houthis to halt shipping through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait at the southern end of the Red Sea off Yemen and further restrict the flow of oil out of the Persian Gulf.

Earlier on Sunday, the Houthi-run health ministry said a child was killed and six people wounded in a suspected Saudi airstrike on a house in Sanaa. The ministry also said 91 Yemenis have been killed by the Saudi-led coalition in five weeks, 60% of them women and children.

There was no immediate comment from Saudi authorities on the claims.

On Sunday, the Houthis also claimed attacks on King Fahd Airport in the city of Damma, as well as oil and gas facilities in the kingdom's east.

Russia and Ukraine agree to 'energy ceasefire': Trump

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Sunday that Russia and Ukraine had agreed to an "energy ceasefire", but offered no details on its terms.

Mr. Trump's brief social media post said only that the ceasefire took effect immediately and that both sides had agreed to it. "Do not break it!" he wrote.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on X: "We discussed the energy ceasefire announced by President Trump. Ukraine supports the ceasefire, and it is important that Russia support it as well. We are awaiting details from the American side." Mr. Zelenskyy added that he had spoken with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, Finnish President Alexander Stubb and NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte.



Donald Trump

Moscow did not immediately comment on the announcement, and The White House did not clarify the President's post.

Mr. Zelenskyy, in an interview aired on Sunday, said Ukraine was ready to stop striking Russian refineries if Moscow halted attacks on Ukraine's energy system, and asked Mr. Trump to press the Kremlin to agree.

"We are asking President Trump, (to) give them (a) signal, not (to) attack energy infrastructure of Ukraine," he told ABC's "This Week".

Mr. Trump said on Saturday it was time for Ukraine to get a new president, suggesting Mr. Zelenskyy has not done enough to end the war and blaming him for high diesel prices in the U.S.

In response, Mr. Zelenskyy said Ukraine could hold elections if Russia agreed to a 60-day ceasefire. "Give us two months, 60 days off. Total ceasefire, 60 days, and we will organize elections," he said, adding that Ukraine would be ready to accept whatever choice its people made.

"With all respect to President Trump, it's up to our society, up to our people to choose one or another leader," he said.

Brazil's Lula accuses Meta of blocking his content on social media to favour Flavio

Agence France-Presse
BRASILIA

The campaign of Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva accused tech giant Meta of election interference on Saturday after his social media content was allegedly blocked on the company's platforms.

The leftist leader is seeking a fourth non-consecutive term in the October 25 runoff, where he will face Senator Flavio Bolsonaro, the son of far-right former president Jair Bolsonaro.

In a statement, Lula's campaign reported instances where platforms owned by Meta – the parent company of Facebook, WhatsApp, and Instagram – allegedly restricted the distribution of his content.



Lula speaks to the media at a protest in defence of democracy and in his support ahead of the runoff in Sao Paulo on Sunday. REUTERS

"The series of technical issues... raises strong suspicions that Meta's actions constitute an attempt to interfere in the Brazilian electoral process to the benefit of Flavio Bolsonaro's candidacy," it added.

Brazil's Superior Electoral Court (TSE) on Saturday gave the social media giant 48 hours to clarify whether it reduced the reach of posts by Lula's campaign and to explain the irregularities reported. Meta was ordered to "report, profile by profile, all the measures applied" to "Lula's official accounts", the TSE said.

Meta's Brazil office denied the charges, calling them "simply false" and "not supported by the facts."

India has acknowledged Katchatheevu belongs to Sri Lanka, says Dissanayake

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

New Delhi has acknowledged that Katchatheevu belongs to Sri Lanka, President Anura Kumara Dissanayake said on Sunday, while referring to the island nation's "good relations" with India.

At a rally, while outlining his government's efforts to achieve economic stability and good governance, and in maintaining strong ties with other countries, he pointed to the recent reference to Katchatheevu in the Indian Supreme Court. "We maintain good bilateral relations with India. The Central government of India has acknowledged before the Supreme Court that Katchatheevu Island belongs to Sri Lanka," he said, while reiterating his earlier assurance to New Delhi that Sri Lanka "will never allow its airspace, land, or sea to be used in a manner that poses a threat to our neighbour, India".



Anura Kumara Dissanayake

Last week, India's top court heard a batch of petitions challenging the "unconstitutional ceding" of Katchatheevu island to Sri Lanka in the 1970s. According to news reports, Attorney General R. Venkataramani told the court that India had "excellent relations" with Sri Lanka and did not intend reopening the Katchatheevu agreements of 1974 and 1976. While the case is scheduled to be heard next in February 2027, Justice Sanjay Kumar, who along with Justice Sanjeev Sachdeva, is on the Bench, noted that New Delhi and Tamil Nadu must "sensitise" the fishermen to refrain from crossing into Sri Lankan waters.

Politicians in India, both in Tamil Nadu and New Delhi, often invoke Katchatheevu, located close to the International Maritime Boundary on the Sri Lankan side, while taking up Tamil Nadu fishermen's frequent arrests by the Sri Lankan Navy, on charges of illegal fishing in the island's territorial waters.

72 killed in strikes on mine on Sudan-Egypt border: rights group

Agence France-Presse
KHARTOUM

At least 72 workers were killed by airstrikes on a gold mine on the Sudan-Egypt border, a Sudanese rights group said on Sunday, after survivors described scenes of chaos in the mountainous region.

The Emergency Lawyers rights organisation accused the Egyptian air force of carrying out the attack. AFP could not independently confirm the account and Egypt has issued no official comment.

The attack on Saturday was the second this year on Jabal al-Uqaydat, after airstrikes, reportedly by Egypt, killed 23 workers in the informal gold mining site in June.

The Egyptian army did not claim the strikes but said at the time that it had conducted a "large-scale operation" against illegal gold mining within its borders.



A file photo of soldiers at Khartoum airport. AFP

The border between Sudan and Egypt is disputed, with both countries claiming the resource-rich Halayeb triangle. Cairo is however a key ally of Sudan's army, at war with the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces.

Pak. declares emergency in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, suspending its govt.

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan on Sunday declared an emergency in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province over "deteriorating law and order situation", bringing the provincial government led by jailed former Prime Minister Imran Khan's party to an end.

An emergency allows the federal government to assume key executive and legislative powers in a province during a security crisis or breakdown of constitutional governance.

Based on the federal cabinet's recommendation, President Asif Ali Zardari issued a proclamation under Articles 232(1) and 234 (1) of the Constitution, citing rising terrorist attacks and a breakdown of constitutional machinery in the northwestern province, according to the presidential declaration. Under the proclamation, the chief minister, provincial ministers, advisers, special assistants and advocate general will immediately vacate their offices.



Police guard a road leading to the 'Red Zone' in Peshawar, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, in Pakistan on Sunday. REUTERS

The move comes amid an ongoing protest march led by Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KPK) Chief Minister Sohail Afridi, who is pressing for Mr. Khan's release and access to medical treatment for him. The march began in Lakki Marwat on October 4 and has passed through several districts of the province.

Mr. Afridi on Saturday vowed to continue peaceful protests and rejected military operations as a solution to the province's problems. The Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaaf (PTI) party had initially planned to take the march to Islamabad for a sit-in, but the federal government said it would not allow protesters to enter the capital.

The presidential declaration said a report by the provincial governor had highlighted a breakdown of constitutional machinery and the provincial government's inability to function in accordance with the Constitution.

Under the proclamation, the federal government may direct the provincial governor to assume all or some functions of the provincial government.

The powers of the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Assembly will be exercised by Parliament or under its authority, according to the declaration, which took effect immediately.

Poland holds suspect in an 'assassination' plot against PM Tusk

Agence France-Presse
WARSAW

Polish police are investigating after arresting a man suspected of plotting an attack against Prime Minister Donald Tusk and Defence Minister Wladyslaw Kosiniak-Kamysz, the Interior Ministry told AFP on Sunday.

Searches continued at the suspect's home, Ministry Spokeswoman Karolina Galecka said, adding: "information about this man will of course then be verified by the police."

This came after Mr. Tusk and Interior Minister Marcin Kierwinski said that a suspect had been detained.

"The man threatening an attack has been detained," Mr. Tusk wrote on X, praising the police for their "swift and decisive action".

The suspect, a man in his 60s, was arrested in the southwestern region of Lower Silesia, Mr. Kierwinski told public broadcaster TVP Info.

'Thorough probe'

"The services got to him through a thorough analysis of content posted online," he added, saying the man's "contacts and his activity on the internet are being examined".

Earlier, the Interior Ministry said Mr. Tusk and Mr. Kosiniak-Kamysz may have been the targets of assassination attempts.

Ms. Galecka said police had been alerted by the State Protection Service following reports of a potential threat against the PM and defence minister.



After voyage: The container ship *Panstar Acro* is docked at Jaseongdae Pier in Busan, South Korea, on Sunday. AFP

S. Korea finishes trial sail in Arctic shipping route

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

A South Korean container ship returned on Sunday from a trial voyage through the Arctic, testing an alternative route opened by melting sea ice as conflict in West Asia disrupts global shipping.

The *PanStar Acro* made the round trip to Europe in less time than the conventional route through the Suez Canal, officials said, but the initiative has drawn concerns that increased traffic could accelerate Arctic ice loss.

The Arctic route could also expose operators to sanctions-related risks because it runs along Russia's northern coast.

"The *PanStar Acro*, which embarked on a trial voyage along the Arctic shipping route on August 22, docked at Jaseongdae Pier in Busan Port," the South Korean Oceans and Fisheries Ministry said in a statement to *AFP*. The vessel sailed through the Arctic's Northern Sea Route before making port calls at Felixstowe in Britain, Rotterdam in the Netherlands and Gdansk in Poland, and returning via the same route.

President Lee Jae Myung hailed the successful voyage, saying it "shortened the one-way sailing time by 10 days compared with the conventional route via the Suez Canal". "It also allowed us to gain valuable experience operating a South Korean container ship in polar waters and to collect navigational data," Mr. Lee said on X.

The West Asia conflict, sparked by U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran in February, has roiled global shipping, prompting governments and operators to explore alternative routes.

Cuban citizens turn to free community pharmacies as medicines grow scarce

With Cuba's economic crisis deepening, online sellers, street vendors, and WhatsApp and Telegram groups have stepped in to fill gaps left by state pharmacies, once the main source of subsidised meds; shortages of imported materials amid U.S. energy restrictions have compounded the crisis

Associated Press
HAVANA



Strained supply: People wait to receive free medicine distributed by the 'Medicine Is Not for Sale' community project in Havana, Cuba, on Thursday. AP

Every Thursday and Sunday at noon, dozens of people gather outside an apartment building in Havana's Vedado neighbourhood. Laura Mendoza comes downstairs, checks their names against a list and hands out medicine they requested through WhatsApp.

Antihistamines, diuretics, eye drops and antibiotics are among the drugs she distribute. She charges nothing.

Projects like Ms. Mendoza's, called "Medicine Is Not for Sale," have become a lifeline for Cubans struggling to find increasingly scarce medications as the country's economic crisis deepens, compounded by U.S. energy and financial restrictions imposed since January.

Online sellers, street vendors and WhatsApp and Telegram groups have also stepped in to fill gaps left by state pharmacies, which for decades were the main source of subsidised medicines.

The shortages have become so severe that Cuban authorities issued regulations in July allowing private pharmacies to operate – a historic change to the country's state-run health system and part of broader economic reforms.

Until those pharmacies open, projects like Mendoza's provide a lifeline.

"We have five WhatsApp groups in Havana and recently added one in Guanabo," said Ms. Mendoza, who estimates that about 100 similar community projects operate in Havana. Working with the Catholic charity Caritas, her initiative receives more than 13 kilograms (29 pounds) of medicine each week from humanitarian groups in Canada and the United States, travellers carrying donations and local residents.

"People don't just rely on this main pharmacy. They help each other," Ms. Mendoza said, standing beside shelves of medicine in her apartment.

Acute shortage

Volunteers sometimes deliver medicine to patients who cannot collect it themselves. But drugs requiring refrigeration, including some diabetes medications, and cancer treatments are particularly difficult to obtain. Patients also seek gauze, syringes and anesthetics for use in poorly supplied hospitals.

"Six or seven years ago, it was relatively easy to find medicines at state pharmacies," said Cristina Díaz, a 27-year-old physics teacher who came to Mendoza's project seeking clonazepam for a relative.

As shortages worsened, "medicines became much harder to find," she said.

Cuba's Health Ministry lists 603 medicines in its basic drug programme, but only slightly more than one-third are currently available. About 400 are produced by Cuban laboratories using imported raw materials.

Mayda Mauri Pérez, president of the state pharmaceutical company BioCubaFarma, said in June that about 300 of the 395 medicines the company was expected to supply had not been produced because of shortages of imported materials.

The situation is particularly acute in the central province of Ciego de Ávila, where authorities recently acknowledged that state pharmacies had only about 10% of the medicines on the basic list. Officials blamed supply and logistical problems, including fuel shortages.

"Cuba has a medical-pharmaceutical industry that we consider strong," María Fernández Martínez, head of the province's pharmacy company, told the official newspaper Granma. But without supplies, "not even the most capable factory can complete the cycle."

The government also struggles to obtain packaging such as blister packs and bottles and says U.S. financial sanctions complicate payments for imports. Cuban authorities say shipments of medical supplies have also been stranded in third countries because shipping companies fear U.S. penalties for calling at Cuban ports.

Allowing private pharmacies is part of a package of 176 economic measures approved by Cuba's Parliament in June to expand private enterprise and help address the country's economic crisis. The government hopes entrepreneurs can import medicines, as private businesses already do with food and fuel. Authorities say they are reviewing about 36 proposals to open private pharmacies, while state pharmacies will continue to operate.

Affordability question

Private pharmacies will be regulated by the government and barred from selling hospital-only drugs and certain controlled substances. Imports will have to go through state companies, while medicines will require regulatory approval and proper storage.

The Cuban government did not respond to a request for comment.

For many Cubans, however, another question remains unanswered: Will they be able to afford the medicine?

Sara Márquez, 69, takes medication to control her blood pressure. She said a blister pack once cost 0.30 Cuban pesos at state-run pharmacies. In recent months, informal sellers have charged as much as 1,000 pesos ($1.50) for the same amount – more than 30% of her monthly pension.

"At what price will they sell the medicine?... It will depend on people's purchasing power. I can't afford it."

Attacks in schools fuelled by online glorification of violence: Polish PM

Associated Press
WARSAW



Parents hug their wards after a 15-year-old stabbed the caretaker and wounded two others at a school in Poland on Thursday. AFP

The attacks at Polish schools over the past week were "spontaneous acts" driven by the online "glorification of violence," Prime Minister Donald Tusk said on Sunday.

Three attacks at schools in the Mazovian Province in central Poland took place within four days this week, leaving one dead and many wounded, including children.

By Sunday morning, police had detained 117 people across Poland for carrying knives or other dangerous weapons, or for threatening to attack schools or fellow students. Some 64,000 schools were checked. "We are not dealing with any group organised on a big scale," Mr. Tusk said on Sunday morning, during a crisis meeting with government and security services. "These are very often spontaneous actions inspired by online activity."

"In the past years and months, we have noted – globally and in Poland – a rise in the fascination with violence."

Mr. Tusk said the acts could be associated with "nihilistic violence," a term used by authorities to describe acts of violence driven by a nihilistic worldview and misanthropy rather than specific political goals.

In the case of Poland, he said "some of the people detained are active in the ultra-right environment." He said authorities have observed intensified online searches of Nazi content as well as of "mass killers who have become idols online."

"This is essentially a copycat scenario, something of a long trail of attackers going back to at least 2019, if not decades earlier," Kacper Rekawek, senior researcher at the International Center for Counter-terrorism in The Hague, told the *AP*.

He was referring to Brenton Tarrant, the white supremacist who shot and killed 51 Muslims at two mosques in Christchurch, New Zealand, in 2019.

Living through loss



A weary watch: Palestinians look out of a window at the site of a house targeted in Israeli airstrikes after the Israeli military warned residents to evacuate the area on Saturday night, in Al-Zawayda, central Gaza Strip, on Sunday. AFP

Trump's trade wars sting U.S. manufacturers ahead of November's midterms

Agence France-Presse
NORTH JACKSON

For Doug Rende, who runs an aluminum product manufacturer in the U.S. state of Ohio, President Donald Trump's tariffs have meant millions of dollars more in annual costs – and recently, the Iran war has made shipments even more expensive.

Mr. Rende is chief executive at Shapes Unlimited, one of many American producers smarting from Mr. Trump's economic policies as midterm elections approach.

"Frustrating would be one word," Mr. Rende told *AFP*.

"And I think that we're sensing a lack of trust in not only the administration but the governmental process, the role of Congress to rein in executive power," he added.

Since returning to the presidency in January 2025, Mr. Trump has wielded executive authority to slap tariffs on various products and countries.

Besides aluminum, the duties hit steel and autos too, while U.S. trading partners face additional tariffs that vary by country.

Even as some American manufacturers have benefited as their foreign competitors encounter higher barriers, others struggle with ballooning costs and persistent uncertainty.

Mr. Trump's spiraling trade fight with Canada and war with Iran have only deepened worries.

Grievances over Mr. Trump's trade policies are among fault lines that Democrats hope will work in their favour as they push to flip control of the Senate and House of Representatives in November's vote.

Tough to cope

Mr. Rende's company in North Jackson, Ohio, makes and distributes aluminum building products used in fixtures like fences.

Mr. Trump's tariffs on aluminum have steadily climbed, from 10% during his first presidency to 25% and then 50% last year, and Mr. Rende has felt the impact.

"This year alone, it's upwards of $4.5 million to $5 million in additional costs," Mr. Rende said.

"There's only so much that the end consumer is willing to eat," he added. "So, we absorb a healthy portion."

These added costs include steeper transportation fees, as fuel prices surged with the U.S.-Israel war on Iran.



Power play: Since returning to presidency in 2025, Donald Trump has wielded authority to slap tariffs on many products, nations. AFP

Surcharges are "upwards of $6,500 per container" of goods from suppliers, Mr. Rende said.

As a result, he has paused recruitment for new jobs while investing in more robotic assembly.

Sam Miller, another Ohio manufacturer who makes kitchen and bathroom products, has been hit on both fronts in Mr. Trump's trade wars, paying tariffs on imported materials from Asia while finding it harder to expand into Canada because of trade tensions.

"It's been difficult for businesses to manage," Miller told *AFP* from his factory floor in Warren as a machine hummed nearby, cutting countertop material.

Straining ties

"I do think that there will be a shift away from Republican views."

Although Mr. Miller received refunds after the Supreme Court struck down many of Mr. Trump's duties, the U.S. leader has since reinstated many of them.

Deteriorating U.S.-Canada ties add to his challenges, with Washington and Ottawa slapping tariffs on each other's products after trade negotiations collapsed in August.

"We're selling into Canada and it is particularly straining on both us and our customers," Mr. Miller said.

He originally planned on opening a distribution facility in Canada this year, but progress has slowed.

Guy Coviello, president of the Youngstown Warren Regional Chamber, told *AFP* he is monitoring tariffs, the Iran war and immigration very closely.

These are a "mixed bag" for firms but negative overall, said Mr. Coviello, whose business group has some 3,000 members.

Some firms have lost customers or had to downsize, he said.

Canada is also Ohio's biggest export market, with a third of Ohio's exports going to the country.

"Where it gets even more complicated is that there are some goods that go back and forth across the border multiple times," he said.

The Iran war adds to stresses, raising freight costs and hitting aluminum supplies due to drone attacks in West Asia.

With a lack of new U.S. aluminum smelters, Mr. Coviello said: "We are all for tariffs for critical items such as defense and medical industry."

But he added: "We have to be careful when you're talking about products that are not crucial and are not available in the U.S."

T20I RECORD

Abhishek reaches the 2000-run milestone in least number of balls



K.R. DEEPAK

Abhishek Sharma became the fastest batter to score 2,000 T20I runs in terms of balls faced, reaching the milestone in 1,024 deliveries. Abhishek, who laid the foundation for India's win in the Indore T20I on Sunday, eclipsed Suryakumar Yadav's record (1,164 balls). The left-hander also scored his 14th half-century in international cricket.

MR. SAFE HANDS

Smith breaks record for the most catches by a fielder in Tests



AFP

Steve Smith broke the Test record for the most catches by a fielder when he caught South Africa's David Bedingham on the third day of the first Test at Kingsmead on Sunday. It was Smith's 221st catch in his 126th Test, one more than Joe Root. He had equalled the record earlier, *in pic.*, when he caught Temba Bavuma at slips.

IMPRESSIVE

Pacer Mahmud's hat-trick puts Bangladesh in command



FILE PHOTO

Pacer Hasan Mahmud took a hat-trick to help Bangladesh gain a commanding lead over Afghanistan in the one-off Test in Abu Dhabi.**The scores:** Bangladesh 346 & 223/6 in 72 overs (Shanto 82, Mushfiqur 81) vs Afghanistan 240 in 89.1 overs (Abdul Malik 62, Rahmat Shah 105 n.o, Hasan Mahmud 5/55, Ebadot Hossain 4/56).

ON A ROLL

Farhan, Sadaqat star in Pakistan's easy victory against Sri Lanka



AFP

Skipper Sahibzada Farhan (73) and Maaz Sadaqat (96) starred in Pakistan's 82-run win against Sri Lanka in the second T20I in Rawalpindi on Sunday as the host took an unassailable lead in the three-match series. **The scores:** Pakistan 215/3 in 20 overs (Farhan 73, Sadaqat 96) bt Sri Lanka 133/7 in 20 overs (Mohd Imran 3/11).

Abhishek, Arshdeep shine as India wins a run-fest

The opener blasts a 30-ball 69 to power the hosts to another 200-plus score while the left-arm pacer takes three, including the wicket of Hope; Windies fall short despite Kamil and Hetmyer's knocks

WI IN INDIA

S. Shrivathsan
INDORE

After the batathon in Ranchi, it was Indore's turn to celebrate a festival of runs.

But this time though, the result was different. At the Holkar Stadium possessing pocket-sized boundaries, India kept intact its spectacular four-year streak of not losing back-to-back T20Is on home soil as it defeated the West Indies by 14 runs on Sunday.

Asked to set a target, the Men in Blue breached the 200-run mark yet again, recording 223 courtesy opener Abhishek Sharma's blast (69, 30b, 6x4, 5x6). While the West Indies batters kept themselves within touching distance for most part of the chase, they eventually could not pull off an encore, their pursuit ending at 209 for seven.

That the red-hot Shai Hope fell cheaply – missed one completely from Arshdeep Singh (three for 44) to have his stumps rearranged – did not help the Caribbean outfit's cause.

Naman Dhir (two for 39) did the job with his secondary skill by removing set batters Shimron Hetmyer and Kamil Pooran. The off-spinner removed Hetmyer after the ball deflected off the southpaw's pads and onto the stumps and had the last laugh against Kamil in a phase that included three sixes from the opener.

Earlier, Abhishek's street-smart approach in the PowerPlay paid rich dividends.

The left-hander, who had been dismissed in his 20s by off-spinner Roston Chase in the first two games, had a few sighters before going on the rampage.

The 26-year-old showed once again why he is the 'Dada of off-side' in the shortest format, making enough room to find and clear the boundary between sweeper-cover and long-off with elan.

Abhishek was the protagonist in the 108-run second-wicket alliance (40 balls) with Ishan Kishan, which followed the early departure of Sanju Samson. But once Chase inflicted a double blow on the home side with the scalps of Kishan and skipper Shreyas Iyer in the ninth over, the visiting team marched right back into the contest.

By striking at regular intervals - the Men in Blue went from 115 for one to 223 all out – West Indies did not allow India to operate in the gear that Abhishek drove at.

The stretch included the punishment imposed on Tilak Varma in the 17th over, by when Shreyas and Co. lost all their frontline batters.

The casual attitude and not-so-great phase, however, did not haunt India in the end as the host went 2-1 up in the five-match series.





Lights on, lights out! Abhishek provided the launchpad for India's big total before Hetmyer's dismissal derailed West Indies' chase. K.R. DEEPAK

SCOREBOARD

INDIA
Sanju Samson c Kamil b Shamar 3 *(6b)*, Abhishek Sharma c & b Springer 69 *(30b, 6x4, 5x6)*, Ishan Kishan st. Hope b Chase 37 *(18b, 6x4, 1x6)*, Shreyas Iyer lbw b Chase 1 *(2b)*, Tilak Varma run out 28 *(16b, 4x4)*, Naman Dhir c Springer b Motie 10 *(5b, 1x6)*, Nitish Kumar c Hope b Paul 21 *(14b, 3x4)*, Axar Patel run out 20 *(14b, 2x4)*, Arshdeep Singh lbw b Springer 11 *(8b, 1x6)*, Prince Yadav (not out) 13 *(6b, 3x4)*, Mayank Yadav b Shamar 0 *(1b)*; Extras (b-5, lb-1, w-4): 10; Total (in 20 overs): 223.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-7 (Samson, 1.4 overs), 2-115 (Kishan, 8.2), 3-117 (Shreyas, 8.5), 4-124 (Abhishek, 9.5), 5-135 (Dhir, 10.5), 6-169 (Nitish, 14.2), 7-194 (Tilak, 16.4), 8-202 (Axar, 18.1), 9-210 (Arshdeep, 18.6).

WEST INDIES BOWLING
Chase 4-0-38-2, Shamar 4-0-54-2, Paul 4-0-38-1, Springer 4-0-50-2, Motie 4-0-37-1.

WEST INDIES
Shai Hope b Arshdeep 5 *(5b, 1x4)*, Kamil Pooran c Arshdeep b Dhir 42 *(27b, 3x4, 3x6)*, Shimron Hetmyer b Dhir 43 *(26b, 6x4, 2x6)*, Rovman Powell c Kishan b Axar 5 *(7b)*, Sherfane Rutherford b Arshdeep 32 *(20b, 2x4, 2x6)*, Quentin Sampson c Tilak b Nitish 21 *(15b, 1x4, 1x6)*, Keemo Paul c Tilak b Arshdeep 10 *(6b, 1x6)*, Shamar Springer (not out) 35 *(11b, 2x4, 4x6)*, Roston Chase (not out) 5 *(4b)*; Extras (b-1, lb-2, nb-1, w-7): 11; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 209.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-7 (Hope, 1.5), 2-67 (Hetmyer, 6.6), 3-82 (Powell, 9.4), 4-105 (Kamil, 10.6), 5-151 (Sampson, 15.3), 6-169 (Paul, 17.2), 7-174 (Rutherford, 17.5).

INDIA BOWLING
Mayank 4-0-34-0, Arshdeep 4-0-44-3, Prince 4-0-37-0, Dhir 3-0-39-2, Axar 3-0-33-1, Nitish 2-0-19-1.

Toss: WI; **PoM:** Arshdeep.
India won by 14 runs to lead five-match series 2-1.
Fourth T20I: October 14, Hyderabad, 7 p.m.



Cummins... roaring back. AFP

Bowlers hand Australia the advantage

Agence France-Presse
DURBAN

Steve Smith broke the Test record for the most career catches by a fielder as Australia played itself into a strong position on the third day of the first Test against South Africa at Kingsmead on Sunday.

Smith held four catches, taking his total to 223, as South Africa was bowled out for 284 in reply to Australia's first innings of 390. Nic Maddinson (17 not out) and Travis Head (10 not out) added 33 runs to stretch Australia's overall lead to 139 before bad light ended play.

Captain Pat Cummins took three for 54 and Mitchell Starc, Josh Hazlewood and Nathan Lyon claimed two wickets each as the bowling quartet combined with efficiency. Six batters reached 30 but David Bedingham's 49 was the top score.

The scores: Australia 390 & 33/0 in 5.4 overs vs. South Africa 284 in 78 overs (Bedingham 49).

Archers too hot for Knights; Yodhas lord over Chiefs, Marathas pip Royals

APL

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Chero Archers registered a clean sweep against Kakatiya Knights in Sunday's opening clash of the Archery Premier League season 2 at People's Plaza. A third win in four matches pushed it to the top spot in the standings.

The first set was neck-and-neck before Elia Canales shot a 7 to give Archers the advantage. While Casey Kaufhold could only manage a 6, her team had enough in the bank to nose ahead.

Atanu Das led Archers' charge in the second set before the third turned into a thrilling one.

But once Atanu and Casey bagged 10s, there was no fight left in the Knights.

Gatha Anandrao Khadake came up with some clutch arrows under pressure to power Prithviraj Yodhas past Chola Chiefs 6-2.

Her 10 at the end of the third set was crucial as it gave her side a 77-76 scoreline before Chiefs faltered in the decider.

The final match of the day was a close affair. Kushal Dalal, picked ahead of Ojas Pravin Deotale, gave Rajputana Royals a good start while Mete Gazoz anchored it with a high-pressure 10.





Hogging the limelight: Atanu and Gatha were in their element and made it a special Sunday for their teams. SIDDHANT THAKUR

The contest panned into a keen battle between Gazoz and Dhiraj Bommadevara. The latter barely missed a beat in the second set as Mighty Marathas bounced back.

The teams shared the third set before the final one boiled down to a showdown between Mete Gazoz and Dhiraj.

While the latter got 8 with his final arrow, the former managed only 7, sending Marathas into ecstatic celebrations.

The scores: Kakatiya Knights lost to Chero Archers 0-6 (74-75, 72-75, 76-77); Prithviraj Yodhas bt Chola Chiefs 6-2 (74-72, 74-77, 77-76, 76-71); Rajputana Royals lost to Mighty Marathas 3-5 (77-73, 76-77, 76-76, 74-76).

Verstappen finally wins the Singapore GP

FORMULA ONE

Agence France-Presse
SINGAPORE

Max Verstappen won the Singapore Grand Prix for the first time in his career on Sunday to complete a perfect weekend where he also finished first in the sprint and was on pole for both races.

Red Bull's Verstappen finished 7.335 seconds ahead of Ferrari's Charles Leclerc with championship leader Kimi Antonelli third for Mercedes after 62 laps under the lights of the Marina Bay Street Circuit.

The four-time World champion had previously never won or even achieved a pole position in nine previous attempts going back to his debut for Toro Rosso in 2015.

"It has taken a while but I think this race was very good," said a delighted Verstappen, who was celebrating back-to-back wins after triumphing in Malaysia seven days ago, his first victory of 2026. "We had pace when we needed to have it on the soft tyre and the medium. So of course very happy to win here."

The results: 1. Max Verstappen (Red Bull); 2. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari) +7.335s; 3. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) 24.573; 4. Lando Norris (McLaren) 40.506; 5. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) 49.644; 6. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) 53.188; 7. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls) 1:21.666; 8. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi) 1:23.386; 9. George Russell (Mercedes) 1:24.677; 10. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull) 1:30.862. **+1 Lap:** 11. Pierre Gasly (Alpine); 12. Oliver Bearman (Haas); 13. Esteban Ocon (Haas); 14. Carlos Sainz (Williams); 15. Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls); 16. Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin). **+2 laps:** 17. Sergio Perez (Cadillac). **+3 laps:** 18. Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac). **DNF:** Lance Stroll (Aston Martin), Franco Colapinto (Alpine), Gabriel Bortoleto (Audi), Alexander Albon (Williams).

Standings: Drivers: 1. Antonelli 340; 2. Russell 238; 3. Hamilton 229; 4. Verstappen 221; 5. Leclerc 215.

Constructors: 1. Mercedes 578; 2. Ferrari 444; 3. McLaren 339; 4. Red Bull 332; 5. Racing Bulls 100.



Long time coming: Verstappen tasted success at the Marina Bay Street circuit on his 10th attempt. AFP



Haaland. AP

City routs Liverpool

Agence France-Presse
LIVERPOOL

Manchester City shrugged off the threat of swingeing sanctions to beat 10-man Liverpool 3-0 in its first game since being found guilty on more than 100 charges of breaking Premier League financial rules.

Japan forward Keisuke Goto's late header fired ten-man Freiburg over Bayern Munich and Borussia Dortmund to the top of the Bundesliga with a 2-1 win over Schalke on Sunday.

The results: Premier League: Crystal Palace 3 (Kamada 41, Lerma 45+4, Pino 59) bt Nottingham Forest 1 (Ndoye 3); Hull 2 (Gelhardt 48, Belloumi 74) drew with Everton 2 (Dewsbury-Hall 55, Barry 68); Liverpool 0 lost to Manchester City 3 (Haaland 65, Doku 68, Cherki 78). **Serie A:** Como 0 drew with Roma 0; Lazio 3 (Tavares 3, Isaksen 23, Pinamonti 88) bt Monza 1 (Goglichidze 46); Lecce 1 (Fatah 64) lost to Bologna 2 (Orsolini 17, Enem 75).
On Saturday: LaLiga: Real Madrid 1 (Diomande 63) bt Villarreal 0. **Serie A:** Napoli 3 (De Bruyne 29-pen, 90+4, Lang 32) bt Frosinone 0.

INBRIEF



Smriti named UNICEF India celebrity advocate

Smriti Mandhana has been named a celebrity advocate by UNICEF India, with the organisation seeking to leverage her influence to promote equal opportunities, health and well-being for adolescent girls. The announcement was made on Sunday to mark the International Day of the Girl, which draws attention to girls' rights, safety, leadership and potential, while highlighting the barriers that continue to restrict their choices. In her new role, Smriti will build on her previous association with initiatives promoting equal rights and opportunities for children and young people, and advocate for an environment in which girls can participate in sports and realise their potential.

Arunachal forfeits Ranji game against Nagaland

A Ranji Trophy match was forfeited for the first time in 17 years after Arunachal Pradesh failed to field a team for its Plate Group fixture against Nagaland in Ahmedabad on Sunday due to a legal tussle within its cricket association. The BCCI had informed the stakeholders that the fixture would not take place. There's uncertainty over Arunachal's next match, against Sikkim, given the legal impasse.

Allen, Ferguson, Seifert back in NZ squad for India ODIs

Rachin Ravindra and Mark Chapman were on Sunday named in New Zealand's squad for its home one-day series against India after injury sidelined the batting pair from the preceding Twenty20 clashes.

The squad: First three ODIs: Mitchell Santner (Capt.), Michael Bracewell, Mark Chapman, Devon Conway, Jacob Duffy, Matt Henry, Kyle Jamieson, Tom Latham (wk), Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Rachin Ravindra, Nathan Smith, Will Young, and Blair Tickner.
Last two ODIs: Santner (Capt.), Finn Allen, Michael Bracewell, Chapman, Kristian Clarke, Duffy, Matt Fisher, Lockie Ferguson, Mitch Hay (wk), Nick Kelly, Tim Seifert (wk), Tickner, and Will Young.
The schedule: 1st ODI: Nov. 4 (Auckland), 2nd – Nov. 7 (Wellington), 3rd – Nov. 10 (Hamilton), 4th – Nov. 13 and 5th – Nov. 15 (both Mount Maunganui).

Udhayveer claims 10m air pistol gold at Cairo ISSF WC

India's Udhayveer Sidhu shot his way to a gold medal in the men's 10m air pistol event at the ISSF World Cup Rifle/Pistol in Cairo on Sunday. The 24-year-old shot a total of 240.6 in the final to finish ahead of Germany's Christian Reitz (240.1) and Italy's Paolo Monna (219.8). The other Indian in the fray, Jonathan Gavin Antony, finished second in qualification but was competing for ranking points only. Ajendra Singh Chauhan and Sarabjot Singh finished 14th and 31st, respectively in qualification.

Italy's Bezzecchi wins MotoGP Grand Prix in Indonesia

Marco Bezzecchi stormed to victory in Indonesia on Sunday as Jorge Martin was third to retake the lead from Marc Marquez in the Indonesian MotoGP world championship. The Italian Bezzecchi, riding an Aprilia, made his move on pole-sitter Raul Fernandez in the final third of a captivating GP at Mandalika International Circuit.



India U-17 women enter Asian Cup second time running

The Indian Under-17 women's football team has qualified for the AFC U-17 Women's Asian Cup 2027 to be held in China after beating Malaysia 4-0 at the MP Selayang Stadium in Selayang on Sunday. India will take part in the continental competition for the second consecutive edition after reaching the quarterfinals in its latest appearance earlier this year.

The result: Malaysia 0 lost to India 4 (Redima Devi 30, Pritika Barman 51, Anushka Kumari 57, Nidhi Pawan Kumar 87).

Shikhar notches up this edition's first ton as Jharkhand wins the initial exchanges

Kerala works its way back in the contest thanks to fine spells of off-spin by Jalaj and Vaisakh as the visitor puts a brake on the host's march

RANJI TROPHY

P.K. Ajith Kumar
JAMSHEDPUR

Tournaments change. Shikhar Mohan's form doesn't.

After making 85 and 52 in the Duleep Trophy final and then 60 in the Irani Cup, the left-handed opener scored an excellent143 (196b, 18x4, 2x6) for Jharkhand on the opening day of the Ranji Trophy match against Kerala at the Keenan Stadium.

That was the first hundred of the 92nd edition of India's premier domestic tournament. He deserves that honour.

His hundred and his partnerships for the first and second wickets had put the host in a strong position, but Kerala fought back gamely to ensure the honours were even on the opening day. Jharkhand finished at 289 for five on what appears to be a good wicket to bat on.

At one stage, Jharkhand was 250 for one, but it lost four wickets for the addition of another 29 runs. That collapse was caused by fine spells of off-spin by Jalaj Saxena and Vaisakh Chandran.



Rich vein of form: Shikhar's partnerships for the first and second wickets put Jharkhand in a strong position. P.K. AJITH KUMAR

Earlier, the home team, opting to bat first, was given a fine start of 87 by Shikhar and his opening partner Sharandeep Singh (33, 92, 3x2). They saw off a probing spell with the new-ball by the hard-wokring M.D. Nidheesh.

Kerala was struggling for a breakthrough, which came only after 26 overs. It was provided by Jalaj, who removed Sharandeep with a ball that turned and disturbed the leg-stump.

Utkarsh Singh (71, 147b, 9x4) now joined Shikhar and they looked in control. Their stand was worth 163 when Shikhar missed the line and was bowled by Vaisakh. The 21-year-old, who had spent an eternity in the 90s before reaching his third Ranji hundred with a clean six off Jalaj, had begun to open up.

Utkarsh followed him soon in the dressing room. Vaisaksh then removed Robin Minz and Kounain Quraishi in quick succession, and it took a doughty effort from captain Virat Singh to see to it that there was no further damage till stumps.

The scores: Jharkhand — 1st innings: Shikhar Mohan b Vaisakh 143, Sharandeep Singh b Jalaj 33, Utkarsh Singh c Baby b Jalaj 71, Virat Singh (batting) 12, Robin Minz b Vaisakh 10, Kounain Quraishi c Baby b Vaisakh 10, Aditya Singh (batting) 5; Extras (b-4, lb-1) 5; Total (for five wkts. in 90 overs): 289.
Fall of wickets: 1-87, 2-250, 3-252, 4-269, 5-279.
Kerala bowling: Nidheesh 12-2-33-0, Eden 10-1-45-0, Jalaj 31-7-80-2, Sarwate 15-4-44-0, Vaisakh 21-3-71-3, Abhishek 1-0-11-0.
Toss: Jharkhand.

Shami happy to see Bhuvneshwar back in the Indian team

Y.B. Sarangi
KALYANI

Even at 36, Mohammed Shami stands out with his skill-set and hard work to underline his worth.

Having started his Ranji Trophy season well with a four-wicket haul for Bengal in its outing against Delhi at the Bengal Cricket Academy ground here on Sunday, Shami said he did not feel any difference about his 'inbuilt skill.'

Enjoying his game

"You should have the smartness to know when to make the ball move in and out. I don't feel any change (about my performance). People express their opinions, such as I don't have the rhythm and fitness. I don't care about all this and I enjoy my game," said Shami, leading the Bengal attack, also comprising international pacers Akash Deep and Mukesh Kumar.

Shami parried a question on whether he had contacted the National selectors, but spoke about his fitness. "You people (reporters) can see and write. I am inside the ground and am playing," said Shami, while expressing his happiness over fellow pacer Bhuvneshwar Kumar's India selection after four years.

On Bengal's ongoing match, Shami reiterated his demand that the home team should get a favourable track instead of a slow one.

'Have to work smartly'

"We wanted a helpful pitch. No other team has such a fast bowling attack in India. We have requested many times. I don't think there is a response.

"It was humid. You have to work smartly.

"When you don't get help from the pitch, I don't think there's any smartness in putting in long spells and finishing one's energy. I had planned for everyone," said Shami.

RANJI SCORES — ROUND ONE, DAY ONE

Elite: Group A: At Rajgir: Uttar Pradesh 287/3 in 84 overs (Madhav Kaushik 124 batting, Rinku Singh 109 batting) vs. Bihar. **Toss:** Bihar.
At Panaji: Baroda 204/3 in 85 overs (Shivalik Sharma 62, Shashwat Rawat 40 batting) vs. Goa. **Toss:** Baroda.
At Srinagar: Madhya Pradesh 196 in 74.2 overs (Shubham Sharma 79, Sunil Kumar 4/69, Rohit Sharma 5/36) vs. Jammu & Kashmir 3/1 in three overs.
Toss: J & K.
At Nagpur: Vidarbha 300/5 in 85 overs (Yash Rathod 131 batting, Akshay Wadkar 112 batting) vs. Pondicherry.
Toss: Vidarbha.
Group B: At Hyderabad: Tripura 134 in 44 overs (Bikramkumar Das 50, Aniketh Reddy 5/21) vs. Hyderabad 121/4 in 41 overs (Tanmay Agarwal 48 batting, Sandip Sarkar 4/44).
Toss: Tripura.
At Vijayawada: Karnataka 274 in 82.2 overs (R. Smaran 126, K.L. Shrijith 58) vs. Andhra 16/2 in five overs. **Toss:** Karnataka.
At New Chandigarh: Assam 68/3 in 23 overs vs. Punjab.
Toss: Punjab.
At Rajkot: Saurashtra 308/4 in 90 overs (Chirag Jani 83, Ravindra Jadeja 72 batting, Prerak Mankad 92 batting) vs. Chhattisgarh.
Toss: Chhattisgarh.
Group C: At Jamshedpur: Jharkhand 289/5 in 90 overs (Shikhar Mohan 143, Utkarsh Singh 71) vs. Kerala.
Toss: Jharkhand.
At Kalyani: Delhi 240 in 77.3 overs (Ayush Doseja 45, Hrithik Shokeen 56, Mohammed Shami 4/30) vs. Bengal. **Toss:** Bengal.
At Ahmedabad: Odisha 272/3 in 90 overs (Gourav Choudhary 121 batting, Sandeep Pattnaik 69 batting) vs. Gujarat.
Toss: Odisha.
At New Delhi: Maharashtra 287/5 in 90 overs (Prithvi Shaw 70, Ankit Bawne 105 batting) vs. Services. **Toss:** Maharashtra.
Group D: At Lahli: Himachal Pradesh 153/7 in 77 overs (Akash Vasisht 49 batting, Anshul Kamboj 4/32) vs. Haryana.
Toss: HP.
At Mumbai (Brabourne Stadium): Railways 278 in 87.5 overs (Vivek Singh 112, Devendra Bora 5/49) vs. Uttarakhand.
Toss: Uttarakhand.
At Jaipur: Rajasthan 286/4 in 85 overs (Rohan Rajbhar 95, Sumit Godara 49, Karan Lamba 103 batting) vs. Tamil Nadu.
Toss: Rajasthan.
At Mumbai (Wankhede Stadium): Mumbai 249/5 in 84 overs (Ayush Mhatre 48, Musheer Khan 65, Siddesh Lad 80 batting) vs. Chandigarh.
Toss: Chandigarh.
Plate: At Rangpo: Sikkim 245 in 80.5 overs (Satyajeet Bachhav 45, Ram Gurung 5/32) vs. Meghalaya 2/0 in one over. **Toss:** Meghalaya.
At Nadiad: Mizoram 183 in 62.3 overs (Kishan Singha 6/52) vs. Manipur 39/4 in 26 overs.
Toss: Mizoram.

Rohit happy to be playing after injury woes

Shayan Acharya
SRINAGAR

As Jammu and Kashmir began its Ranji Trophy title defence against Madhya Pradesh, fast bowler Rohit Sharma made his return to First Class cricket after two years on the sidelines, claiming five wickets.

For Rohit, the haul marked a significant milestone after an Achilles tendon rupture and a heel bone fracture. Having recovered once, he suffered a similar injury again, forcing another lengthy rehabilitation.

"Especially after an injury, it is very satisfying. But for me, this is a new beginning," Rohit told *The Hindu* on Sunday.

The recovery was as much a mental challenge as a physical one. "It is more mental than physical.

"You want to play, but your body does not allow you to. That is challenging," he said.

The Jammu and Kashmir Cricket Association kept him with the team during rehabilitation, while Rohit worked on his fitness and bowling.

I am just staying in the present: Smaran

N. Sudarshan
VIJAYAWADA

Over the last two weeks, R. Smaran has lived life in the fast lane. In Devdutt Padikkal's absence, he was named Karnataka skipper for the Ranji Trophy opener against Andhra.

After playing a match-winning hand for Rest of India in the Irani Cup, he was drafted into the squad for the upcoming India-A tour of New Zealand.

And on Sunday in Mulapadu, near here, the 23-year-old scored an excellent, back-to-the-wall century on captaincy debut.

Asked how he was processing all this, Smaran said: "Even if there is time to process, I don't want to think much of it.

"Just taking it as it comes and not keeping any expectations of playing or reaching any particular level. I am just staying in the present."

Such level-headedness is prerequisite if one has to succeed in the cut-throat Indian cricketing universe. And handling the burden of captaincy of a powerhouse side like Karnataka is never easy.

"It's a huge privilege and honour to lead Karnataka," Smaran said.



Karnataka's Smaran celebrates after scoring a century. K.V.S. GIRI

"There are so many stalwarts who have led Karnataka to a lot of victories. Obviously, our coach Vinay Kumar... We don't have to go far for inspiration.

"The last two titles back-to-back [in 2014 and 2015] were won under him. So, it's a very proud moment for me."

"We came very close to winning the Ranji Trophy last year.

"But second place is just not good enough. Reaching the final was a positive, but we are not there yet until we get our hands on the trophy.

"So the focus is to end the drought," the southpaw added.

Zheng wins China Open

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

Zheng Qinwen won her home China Open on Sunday as she beat Russian teenager Mirra Andreeva 7-5, 6-4 for her first title in nearly two years.

The former World No. 4 was a wildcard entry in Beijing.

Kipchoge ends victory drought

Eliud Kipchoge set a race record Sunday in winning the Melbourne Marathon.

The Kenyan 41-year-old, who won his last marathon in September 2023 at Berlin, crossed the finish line in 2h, 9m, 10s, 2s inside the previous race record.

LIVE TELECAST

Ranji Trophy: day 2, JioHotstar, 9 a.m.
Afghanistan vs Bangladesh: One-off Test, day 4, FanCode, 11 a.m.
South Africa vs Australia: First Test, day 4, Eurosport & FanCode, 1 p.m.
ISL: Sony LIV, App 7.30 p.m.
Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHotstar, 12.30 a.m. (Tuesday)
Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday)
LaLiga: FanCode, 12.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Memorable day for Gutte and Ishaan



Great finish: Ishaan, winner of Race 3 in the Formula 2000 class.

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Mumbai's Krishay Gutte and Ishaan Madesh of Bengaluru won a race apiece in the premier MRF Formula 2000 class as the third round of the MRF National Racing Challenge 4W concluded at the Madras International Circuit on Sunday.

The results (provisional, all 10 laps unless mentioned):
MRF Formula 2000 (Race-2): 1. Krishay Gutte (Mumbai) 16m 05.519s; 2. Ishaan Madesh (Bengaluru) 16:08.403; 3. Saishiva Sankaran (Pune) 16:10.092.
Race-3 (8 laps): 1. Ishaan (12:48.891); 2. Saishiva (12:52.037); 3. Gutte (12:58.348).
MRF Formula 1600 (Race-2): 1. Shivansh Bejoy (New Delhi) 17:29.757; 2. Evan Shrawan (Mumbai) 17:50.229; 3. S. Gyan (Chennai) 17:50.374. **Race-3 (8 laps)**: 1. Gyan (14:09.009); 2. Bhuvan Bonu (Visakhapatnam) 14:13.738; 3. Shivansh (New Delhi) 14:14.674.
Formula LGB 1300 (Race-2, Open): 1. Viswas Vijayaraj (Nellore, DTS Racing) 18:53.100; 2. T.S. Diljith (Thrissur, DTS Racing) 18:53.550; 3. Liron Jaden Samuels (Tirunelveli, DTS Racing) 19:20.125. **Race-3 (8 laps):** 1. Viswas (Nellore, DTS Racing) 16:07.296; 2. Vinithkumar (Tirupur, DTS Racing) 16:07.838; 3. Diljith (Thrissur, DTS Racing) 16:08.063.
Junior (Race-2): 1. Augustine Boby (Greater Noida, DTS Racing) 19:07.657; 2. Kaveen Rajapaksa (Colombo, Momentum Motorsports) 19:09.751; 3. Neythan McPherson (Pune, Delta Speeds) 19:21.053.
Race-3 (8 laps): 1. Augustine (Greater Noida, DTS Racing) 16:10.519; 2. Shatveer Shetty (Bengaluru, Meco Racing) 16:11.894; 3. Kaveen Rajapaksa (Colombo, Momentum Motorsports) 16:18.355.
Super Stock (Race-2): 1. T.S. Diljith (Thrissur) 20:53.561; 2. Lal Kattikulam Bharathan (Thrissur) 20:54.722; 3. Deepa S. John (Thiruvananthapuram) 20:57.362.
MRF Saloons (Race-2): 1. Alisha Abdulla (Chennai) 21:36.180; 2. Aakash Vivek (Chennai) 21:36.592; 3. R. Hemachandran (Puducherry) 21:40.599. **Race-3 (8 laps):** 1. Aakash (Chennai) 17:07.238; 2. Qian Jun Kek (Kuala Lumpur) 17:21.821; 3. Alisha (17:22.071).

INTERVIEW

Pranavi Urs

My Olympics preparation is not going to change much

The golfer says the experience in Hangzhou helped her in Aichi-Nagoya where she won the individual gold and the team silver; feels that she benefitted by playing on the Ladies European Tour



Nihit Sachdeva

Lakshman Singh in 1982 (New Delhi). Shiv Kapur in 2002 (Busan). Pranavi Urs in 2026 (Aichi-Nagoya).

For only the third time in history, an Indian golfer won the individual gold at the Asian Games but this one was a bit more special - no Indian woman had achieved this before the 23-year-old from Karnataka. The journey to the top step of the podium had its ups and downs but Pranavi stayed strong, patient and eventually finished the job.

In a media interaction facilitated by the Sports Authority of India, Pranavi shares snippets from the dramatic final day in Japan and how a certain Rory McIlroy played a role in her victory, what this gold means for women's golf in India, and the way forward:-

What does being the first Indian woman golfer to win an individual Asian Games gold medal mean to you?

I'll always be the first. There are going to be multiple winners after me but I'm the one who set that record. For me, that means the world.

What is the next first that you want to chase after this?

Either to win a Major or an Olympic medal.

Can you recap the final hole?

When I hit that tee shot, I knew I hit it well and I was going to cover the water. It's a difficult hole. When Shannon (Singapore's Shannon Tan, the bronze medallist) was in the bunker, with that pin position, she wasn't going to hit it close. And Ruoning (China's Ruoning Yin, the silver medallist) also couldn't hit the shot because she had a long iron in.

With my distance, I had an advantage. I just had to keep the ball in play after the second shot. And at the time, I also didn't know I was going to win. I thought making par would force a playoff. Little did I know that the last putt that I hit was a putt to win.

You didn't know that you were putting for the win?

No, I didn't. I was, perhaps, too zoned in and I had one of Shannon's scores wrong on my scorecard because I was marking hers. I thought I needed to putt. Maybe, there's a playoff and I'll still have a medal chance. I didn't know and that's why I didn't celebrate after I won. I wish I had known.

If you could go back in time and you knew that the final putt would win you the gold medal, how would you celebrate?

I don't know because I haven't really thought about it. I've played so many different victory celebrations of mine in my head. I don't know which one I was going to do. Maybe just a fist bump. It was so surreal that that happened and I didn't know.

What went wrong when you had a triple bogey early in the final round?

I just got unlucky. It wasn't even a bad shot. I just started a bit right and ended up in the bunker. Normally, if it's a plugged ball, you still have a chance but I didn't really have one. Then, I hit the shot and it came back in my divot, which was deeper. I hit my shot again and it returned to the same spot. So, I was helpless. Now, looking back at it, I wish I had taken an unplayable and things could have maybe played out a bit different but I've still got the medal, so I'm not complaining.

How did you mentally bounce back from the triple bogey?

I've been working with my psychologist for years now. At the end of the day, the goal is to keep calm when you're nervous, stick to your game plan, don't think about anything else and just focus on what you need to do and what's in your control more than the outcome. On the fourth hole, she (Yin) went one shot ahead and I'm someone who loves chasing. I thought, "You've got nothing to lose. You've hit rock bottom now. The worst thing has already happened."

I just stayed patient.

Did the experience of Hangzhou help in the final stages in Aichi-Nagoya?

Yes. I knew what to expect this time and how it really works. Being in a team event as well, I knew what I was stepping into whereas in China, it was my first time playing and representing the country. I was not as experienced three years ago. Since China, I've secured my card on the LET (Ladies European Tour). I've played in a lot of different conditions. I've put myself in a lot of different positions. I've also put myself in positions where I was in Japan. So, that experience helped me calm my nerves a little bit.

When you said that you were so zoned in that you didn't know you were about to win, is it a good thing or is it a bad thing to be so locked in?

If I'm getting a gold, then it's definitely good. Maybe for my social media, it isn't because I didn't celebrate. So, I don't have a lot of pictures of me celebrating. But jokes apart, it's good as it shows how much you were invested in the game on that particular day, regardless of what happened or under the circumstances I was in. When we were on the 18th green, they called out our names before we could putt, saying we're so-and-so (positions). I don't remember that at all.

How significant is this gold when you look at the growth of women's golf, especially in India?

The greatest joy and pride that I have is to give back to the sport because the sport has given me everything.

It's given more than I could have asked for. If I could win a medal and grow the sport in India, that means the world to me. Not just people in bigger cities but even in villages and smaller towns, if they can see what I did and somehow pick up a club, enjoy the sport or even get to know about the sport, that's still growth.

You've played a lot on the LET tour and a few events on the LPGA as well. Going forward, what do you think you need to do to be a more permanent member on the LPGA tour?

There are certain stats that I need to work on. My coach (Steven Giuliano) and I have been working towards that.

And that's why I feel like my game has also improved so much from the first half of the season. I'm going to continue to do that.

Aditi Ashok's fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics changed a lot of things for golf in India. Do you feel that you actually winning gold, albeit in a different competition, is a seminal moment in women's golf in India?

What Aditi did in Tokyo was unreal and that's when golf in India became popular. I would give all the credits to her. People are comparing me with Aditi and I don't think I'm as good as her. She's still way above me and she's my senior. What she's done for the sport, I wish and hope to do as much. She's also a silver medallist at the Asian Games in China.

What kind of decisions were the most important and challenging for you in Japan? Also, how does this gold change your preparation for the Olympics?

The thing that I did on the last hole, if you saw the video, I changed my club on my second shot after I hit the drive. I had a 6-iron but then, I said to my caddy that I'm feeling the adrenaline rush and I can't be hitting 6-iron because it's going to go over the green. I'm just going to hit a 7-iron

That was one of the moments where I thought this change might help me get the medal because I didn't know if it was gold or silver.

My preparation for the Olympics is not going to change much. I'm going to be playing a lot of events on the LET. The cutoff date is in June 2028.

How did you celebrate your win?

My parents were there with me. I don't think it hit all of us that I had won and we didn't know what was happening. They had a gazillion phone calls and texts so they were overwhelmed as well. And then, the next day we went shopping in Tokyo.

Do you also believe in the power of manifestation?

You can't just manifest and not do anything. You still have to work hard. Manifestation just shows that that's your dream and this is what you need to work towards. So, I wouldn't say you manifest and sit at home doing absolutely nothing.

If anything, you work harder because you've manifested that and that's what you want. I do believe in manifestation but that just gives me a goal to work towards.

How was your day prior to the final round?

The night before the final round, me and my psychologist spoke about different scenarios and what start I could have. For the first time, I was more aware of my breath work.

Normally, when we have sessions, I'm always goofing around. For the first time, I paid more attention to what she was saying because that's how nervous I was and that's how badly I wanted the gold. I had an advantage - a three-shot lead. I had to keep it all together as anything could happen. Till it's done, it's not done. While thinking about what I wanted to caption after winning, I was also thinking about things that could go wrong.

On the last hole, of course, you were focusing on yourself but you must have also seen that Yin had a lip out?

I played with her for two days and I don't think she made a single bogey in those two days and that's why she's world number six and former world number one. She's a Major champion but sometimes, if it's meant to be, it is, right? Nothing can stop you from winning. I think it'll just be it.

But at the same time, I feel like the way I handled my situation, coming down the stretch, I holed a few important putts, which she went on to miss after me. So, I had to put that pressure on her which I did.

Who is your favourite golfer?

Rory McIlroy.

After the third hole, he was one of the people I thought about. It was pretty random. But I thought if he can win the Masters (in 2025) after having a terrible start, so can I (win the gold). That's one way that got me motivated towards the round as well.

Are you thinking of going to Delhi during the DP World India championship and trying to meet McIlroy and have a moment with him if possible?

Absolutely. My partner (Karandeep Singh Kochhar) is also a golfer. So, he's playing that event. I'm going to go watch him play anyway. I've asked my sources a little bit to get me to meet him (McIlroy). Hopefully that happens. And if that happens, I think I'm going to be more nervous meeting him than winning the gold.

> The greatest joy and pride that I have is to give back to the sport because the sport has given me everything. It's given more than I could have asked for. If I could win a medal and grow the sport in India, that means the world to me

> What Aditi did in Tokyo was unreal and that's when golf in India became popular. I would give all the credits to her. People are comparing me with Aditi and I don't think I'm as good as her. She's still way above me and she's my senior

Seema and Neha, born two years apart, grew up together on the streets of Yamuna Bazar in Old Delhi, where they were pushed into a drug habit. In a childcare institution, one sister overcame addiction with education and support; the other slipped deeper into substance use disorder and depression. Shrimansi Kaushik speaks to them about their shared struggle for survival and the warmth they share as sisters

A tale of two sisters



Sisters Seema and Neha, who grew up on the streets, now live in paying-guest accommodation in South Delhi's Mehrauli. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Shobha, 46, lives in a makeshift home along a road in Old Delhi's Yamuna Bazar. She came here two decades ago, from Kanpur, in Uttar Pradesh, after she separated from her husband and found no support from her family. She brought her five children; one of them went missing as a baby and another died, she believes, of a drug overdose. Initially, she begged for survival, but soon realised it was not enough to feed her children. She started selling stickers, earning ₹100-150 a day. "I dream of my daughters living their lives without having to beg for safety and freedom. I know I haven't been able to provide for them but despite that, they have done way better than me in their lives. I am also changing because of them," she says. Seema and Neha (names changed to protect privacy), her two daughters who grew up on the streets, now live about 20 kilometres away from their mother in paying guest accommodation in south Delhi's Mehrauli. While Seema goes to college and works part-time at a pizza place, Neha is grappling with depression and trying to find her footing in life.

Seema: the hope for a home of her own

For Seema, 19, home has always been a road in Yamuna Bazar. Here, traffic hurtles past footpaths lined with tarpaulin-covered dwellings. Located on the western bank of the Yamuna river, about a kilometre away from the old Yamuna bridge, "*sadak*", road in Hindi, is how she describes her childhood home.

Her matter-of-fact tone belies the complexity of the life she has lived there. "I was seven when I first sniffed '*sulochan*'," she says, a corruption of solution, the fast-drying glue used to plug holes in cycle tyre tubes. "My sister started it first when she was nine. Our peers were already into it, so naturally, we fell into it too," she says.

The glue is easily available at any cycle repair or mechanic's shop.

In Seema's words, the inhalant provided a cushion from the hard everyday life of road-dwelling: fighting off sexual offenders, bullying by older kids, hunger, and a general sense of loss and non-belonging. "We would not have a sense of the world (after inhaling the solution). My sister's condition kept getting worse," Seema says. Once, she kept on saying, '*Mai kaun hoon* (Who am I)?' She was 13 then. That's when our mother decided to seek help."

Someone had told their mother about a shelter home. "We went to Kilkari, a shelter home run by the Salaam Baalak Trust at Kashmere Gate. Later we were shifted to Udaan, also run by the same organisation, which was in Kamla Nagar then (now in Dilshad Garden)," she says.

The shelter home had a strict daily regimen: wake up at 6 a.m., get ready for school, go to school at 8 a.m., come back at 4 p.m., have dinner at 8 p.m., and be in bed by 9 p.m.

"It took some time to get used to it. Initially it felt like it was curbing my freedom," Seema says. "But gradually, I settled there, found an interest in reading books, even found art, dance, and music. For the first time, someone asked me what I wanted my life to be like. That made all the difference," Seema says.

That's when she began to dream, to see herself living near the mountains, in a home with a room of her own. "No one would be able to enter or touch my things without my permission. I want a place where I am not judged, where I feel safe and respected," she says.

> For the first time, someone asked me what I wanted my life to be like. That made all the difference
>
> **SEEMA**
> Student and part-time worker

She adds that she was able to anchor her life with the counselling and guidance she received in the shelter home. Seema says she has no interest in marriage. "I have seen my parents' marriage fail. I don't think I can marry anyone ever," she says. But she did hope for a foster family.

A Comptroller and Auditor General report tabled in the Delhi Assembly in March 2026 flagged systemic gaps in the childcare system, from unreliable data, dysfunctional child-protection bodies to a 76% staff shortage, poor infrastructure and healthcare. It also flagged delayed rehabilitation and the failure to implement sponsorship and foster care schemes.

Having enrolled in Class VI, Seema was forced to leave by Class XI, when her mother fractured her hand. "I had thought I had left Yamuna Bazaar forever. When that happened I felt I would always end up there," she says.

While taking care of her mother in the hospital, she studied, earned money, and financially supported her family. After passing Class XI, she managed to get admission at Tech Mahindra Smart Academy for Healthcare, where she is pursuing a year-long Diploma in Medical Laboratory Techniques, with the help of NGOs Rainbow and Udayan.

Seema worries about her mother. "Members of the Bajrang Dal and local police continue to harass her for setting up a tiny shop on the road. They use force and extract money, saying it is illegal to set up shops in that area," she says. She complained to senior police officers about a mobile theft. "They directed all their anger at us and started harassing my mother," she says. Shobha is exhausted. She plans to move back to Mathura and live with friends.

On May 11, the Delhi government announced the Aftercare Scheme for Young Persons, meant to support those who leave childcare institutions at 18. The scheme, with a ₹3.5 crore budget, aims to provide financial assistance and guidance for higher education and employment opportunities. Officials say it is yet to come into operation.

Neha: somewhere over the rainbow

Ever since she was born, Neha, 21, has only known that to survive, she had to fight, says her mother. "She fought off sexual assaulters, she fought to live on her own terms. Neha cannot be contained," Shobha says.

"Even in school, she was the first to run away the moment any teacher forced discipline upon her. At the shelter, she got interested in art and craft, and after she turned 18, she found a job at an art studio," she says, viewing her daughter's ability to overcome struggles as an achievement in itself.

Neha, dismissing her mother's analysis of her experience, says she never felt "at home" anywhere: not on the streets, not in the art studio, not even where she lives now.

"Drugs have been a part of my life since I was born. The group of children around us used it; so did I," she says. "I did not want to be rescued. I wanted to stay with my family," she adds.

In 2018, their elder sister died.

"Our mother married her off. She had stopped using (inhalants), but after marriage she started again. Then one day, we heard she had died," Neha says. That day, she went and bought drugs worth ₹2,000 and used them all in one go.

"I had to be hospitalised after that. I don't remember what happened to me. I just lost all control," she says.

Her mother, worried about her, sent her off to the shelter home after that. She went, reluctantly. "I did not like the controlling environment at the shelter. On the streets, both of us would roam around freely, eat whatever we wanted to, and sleep wherever we felt safe. There, I had to ask for permission for everything," she says.

At the shelter, Neha did not find anyone who understood her. Lonely, she started chatting with a stranger on Instagram.

"Gradually, I developed a bond with him and we started dating," Neha says.

After three years, Neha left the shelter with a ₹12,000 job at the art studio.

At the shelter, she says she was judged for being in a relationship. "People would assume I was not serious about my life," she says.

However, things did not go as planned.

A year into the relationship, she left her job and began to take drugs again despite abstaining for three years.

"I was living in a tent in a park with him. We started fighting a lot. He would not go to find work and was dependent on me," she says.

Two months ago, Neha realised she did not want to live with him anymore. "I had a fight. I hit him with a cooker lid," she says. She moved in with her sister.

Seema worries about Neha.

"She doesn't talk much. I prepare food and leave it in a tiffin box in front of her before leaving. When I come back, I find it there, untouched," Seema says.

Seema approached Udayan and Rainbow for help. At a counselling session, Neha was diagnosed with depression.

Rita Singh, former member, Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) and founder of Udayan, says, "The mental health of children at childcare institutions is a major issue. There is a shortage of trained counsellors and psychologists who can guide children, especially adolescents," Singh says.

Neha says some day she will go abroad, though she is not too sure where.

For now, just moving out of the city will do.

"We have decided to take her to Bangalore. There is an NGO that provides support till 23 years of age. We hope she finds her footing in the next two years," Seema says.

Kundan Kanskar, a member of DCPCR says children do not exist in a vacuum.

"We need to address the root causes: poverty, family distress, migration, school dropouts, substance use, trafficking, and exploitation. Every intervention must remain child-sensitive and centred on the child's best interests and dignity," he says.

He hopes that the system can move from a rescue-oriented approach to a comprehensive protection, rehabilitation, and reintegration system.

For help with de-addiction, call 14446.

shrimansi.kaushik@thehindu.co.in

Caught in a **safety net**

■ There is no recent official census of children living on Delhi's streets. Estimates by non-profits have put the range between 50,000 and 80,000. In 2021 the Kailash Satyarthi Children's Foundation undertook a rapid assessment, interviewing 481 children on the street. The report said, "A very conservative calculation suggests that the approximate number of street children in the NCT (National Capital Territory) of Delhi is 60,431."

■ Kundan Kanskar, a member, of the Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights, says Delhi faces multiple and interconnected challenges. One is that there are several entities involved in the system: the Delhi Police, Child Welfare Committees, District Child Protection Units, the Women and Child Development Department, local bodies, health and education authorities, and non-profits. A child rescued from a vulnerable situation requires a coordinated response rather than an isolated intervention, and there are gaps between the working of these agencies.

■ There are 88 childcare institutions in Delhi, which take care of Children in Need of Care and Protection (CNCP): those who may be in conflict with the law or may not have parental support. Of these, 58 are operated by non-profits.

■ Any child on the streets without parental support can go to the Child Welfare Committee (CWC) to seek help. Sometimes the CWC, non-profits, or the police take a child in. CWCs are statutory authorities responsible for CNCP. It conducts inquiries into children's circumstances and decides on whether they should stay in a Child Care Institution (CCI)— shelter homes —or with their parents. ACWC has five members: one must be a woman, and one must be a childcare professional. Delhi currently has 10 CWCs in different districts.

■ Many children on the street take to sniffing Chemical Vulcanising Fluids (CVF), inhalants that produce a high when breathed in. "Inhalant abuse in India has been tracked since the 1970s," says Jateen Ukrani, a psychiatrist with experience of working with children who have substance use disorder. The gases replace oxygen in the lungs and can cause suffocation. "CVFs are dangerous as they can cause sudden death due to arrhythmias. Even the first use can cause sudden sniffing death." Beyond six months, children may experience a loss of memory, hearing, and vision.





Visible change: In a contrast to his Assembly poll campaign, when he made personal appearances only in a handful of areas, TVK leader and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay devoted two days each to Dharapuram and Madurantakam, seeking votes with his nominees. S. SIVA SARAVANAN, PTI

Two seats and Tamil Nadu's return to a political duopoly

While the ruling TVK has won both the constituencies — Madurantakam and Dharapuram — in the recent byelections, the question today is whether Tamil Nadu will shift to a bipolar political landscape, an arrangement it has been familiar with. **T. Ramakrishnan** looks beyond the results of the byelections declared on Friday

As the cliche goes, one week is a long period in politics. And five months, therefore, would technically be very long. The political changes that Tamil Nadu witnessed in the past five months since the assumption of office by the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government have been reflected in the byelections to the Madurantakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies, both reserved for the Scheduled Castes (SCs).

Internally, the two Dravidian parties – the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) – witnessed high drama soon after the TVK emerged as the single largest party in the Assembly election held in April-May. Three days after C. Joseph Vijay became the Chief Minister (on May 10), a group of 25 AIADMK MLAs broke ranks with party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami and voted in favour of the TVK in the Assembly during the trust motion. By then, most of the allies had deserted the DMK and jumped on to the TVK bandwagon. Four MLAs – two from the Congress and one MLA each from the Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi and the Indian Union Muslim League – were later made Ministers. The State's first multi-party Council of Ministers was in place. Meanwhile, the AIADMK's six MLAs, who cross-voted in favour of the TVK in the Assembly in violation of the party's direction, had quit their Assembly seats and joined the ruling party. A number of former Ministers and functionaries of the party followed suit.

On expected lines

It was against this backdrop that the byelections were held on October 6. When the results were out on October 9, they were along expected lines as byelections in the State have always gone in favour of the ruling party. In that sense, the victory of the TVK in the two constituencies was not surprising. However, while it was definitely among the probabilities, it was nevertheless not considered a certainty for a couple of reasons: first, the TVK did not secure a majority of its own in the April-May Assembly election, though it had a vote share of about 35%. Second, given a high degree of SC representation in the Cabinet, the talk had been doing the rounds in political and bureaucratic circles about the possible consolidation of intermediary castes, accounting for a substantial section of the population in the two constituencies.

Factors that were also expected to impact the elections included old caste and political alignments. In Dharapuram, the ruling party came third five months ago, securing around 23% of the votes polled. Besides, the constituency, where the intermediary community of Kongu Vellala Gounders accounts for around 40% and the SCs around 30% of the electors, is the AIADMK's traditional stronghold in the western belt. In a conversation a few weeks ago, a TVK Minister sounded more confident about his party's prospects in Madurantakam than in Dharapuram. Another factor in the mix was that the two TVK candidates had been victors in the Assembly election, as AIADMK candidates. A significant feature of the byelections was that the number of complaints about money distribution was fewer than in the past.

Apart from the changes in political alignments, the big change that was noticed in the byelections was the manner Mr. Vijay had campaigned in the two places. In a stark contrast to his propaganda work during the Assembly election, when he made personal appearances only in a handful of areas, he devoted two days each to Madurantakam and Dharapuram, taking along his nominees with him on the campaign vehicle. His campaign tour was packed with drama: he had a cup of tea at a roadside shop; drove a tractor; had a bullock cart ride; and even plucked drumsticks at a farm. "Mr. Vijay staked his personal image and aura to overcome widespread dissatisfaction with the party's candidates, particularly in Dharapuram. He literally sweated through intense public outreach and campaigning across these constituencies, while his Ministers and party workers left nothing to chance," says R. Kannan, a former diplomat-turned-writer.

> Mr. Vijay staked his personal image and aura to overcome widespread dissatisfaction with the party's candidates, particularly in Dharapuram
>
> **R. KANNAN,** former diplomat-turned-writer

Notably, in the course of his campaign, Mr. Vijay did not make any grand announcements or perceptive observations. However, both in Madurantakam and Dharapuram, he sought to project the TVK as the "true inheritor" of the legacies of AIADMK stalwarts M.G. Ramachandran and Jayalalithaa. He came down heavily on the AIADMK for "getting closer" to its traditional adversary, the DMK.

Shorn of theatrics

Comparatively, the campaigns of his political rivals seemed shorn of theatrics. Mr. Vijay's key challengers – former Chief Ministers M.K. Stalin of the DMK and Edappadi K. Palaniswami of the AIADMK – stuck to the conventional style of campaign. Both his opponents criticised Mr. Vijay for not being "serious" in matters of governance. Both attacked him and the TVK for having "forced" the byelections, which were held only to ensure that their government kept going.

Mr. Stalin charged the ruling party with being more interested in "purchasing" MLAs to protect the government. The AIADMK leader's repeated message to the electors was to teach a "befitting lesson" to the nominees of the TVK, who had crossed over from his party and were in the fray again. The Naam Tamilar Katchi and the Left were present, but their performance did not make any qualitative difference.

For all the intense campaigning by the Chief Minister, the results were not "one-sided". In both constituencies, the TVK's vote share did not exceed the 40% mark, despite the ruling party adding many parties to its alliance this time, unlike in April-May when it was on its own. The ruling party must have had its moments of anxiety when AIADMK nominee K. Banumathi was ahead of TVK candidate P. Sathyabama in the initial four rounds of counting in Dharapuram. Subsequently, the latter overtook her and DMK nominee S. Suganya finished as the runner-up.

Encouraging for the DMK

"As far as the DMK is concerned, I would say the result is, in a sense, encouraging, as we faced the electorate virtually single-handedly, barring the support of the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK). In both places, our vote share is about 30%, which is an achievement," says A. Subburathinam, who was elected in 1991 to the Assembly from Palani on AIADMK ticket and crossed over to the DMK early this year.

Despite the reduction in his party's vote share, former AIADMK Minister 'Pollachi' V. Jayaraman does not feel that the party's base has been eroded. He also contends that the TVK does not mean what it says. Referring to the Chief Minister's statement during the campaign on how the previous governments did not follow up properly with Keralam regarding the Anamalaiyar-Nallar scheme, a project to provide water to the western belt, the AIADMK's functionary points to reports that suddenly surfaced in the media about a group of Ministers who would go to Thiruvananthapuram on the eve of polling day to discuss the scheme. Eventually, the visit did not materialise.

Another former Minister of the AIADMK, R.B. Udhayakumar, is quick to restate that traditionally in Tamil Nadu, byelections have been favourable to the ruling party. "You have to view the outcome only that way. I do not think this will have serious implications for our party," he says.

It remains to be seen how the rebels in the party, including former Ministers S.P. Velumani and C.Ve. Shanmugam, make their next move, as they have not been able to corner Mr. Palaniswami within the organisation.

More dissidents

There is a perception that the outcome may encourage the TVK to attract more dissidents from the AIADMK to its fold. "What would cranes do in a dry pond?" asks S. Semmalai, Health and Education Minister in Jayalalithaa's Cabinet during 2001-04, who joined the TVK at Dharapuram on September 30, 2026. "We do not have to do anything, as the AIADMK's volunteers would have seen the writing on the wall when their party finished third at both the places," he explains.

Despite the TVK government being seen as one that is being propped up by diverse social groups, including the SCs, Mr. Vijay did not refer in his speeches in a significant way to his government's work and plans for the welfare of the community. After all, it is his government that has eight Ministers from the SCs. On the other hand, in the run-up to the byelections, the Chief Minister's visit to the Vanjiamman temple near Dharapuram, a place of worship dear to the Gounders, and Public Works Minister Aadhav Arjuna's reported statement about his party having 17 legislators from another intermediary community, the Vanniyars, did not go unnoticed.

A seasoned leader of the SCs from northern districts says, "It looks that the TVK, just like the DMK while in power, is of the view that there is no necessity to woo the community in a deliberate manner, as the votes of the SCs will go to it even otherwise." However, Mr. Semmalai, who hails from Salem and belongs to the Vanniyar community, says, "In the reserved constituencies, only the SCs can contest. But electors are from all communities. Besides, Mr. Vijay respects all communities, apart from representing all of them."

In a nutshell, the results, though favourable to the TVK, have not provided any overwhelming support to the ruling party and the nature of the verdict should keep Mr. Vijay and his colleagues on toes. As Dr. Kannan says, it is still too early to declare the State is shifting back to a bipolar political landscape, though current trends point to that possibility.

Eating into AIADMK votes

In Madurantakam and Dharapuram, which is the AIADMK's traditional stronghold in the western belt, the TVK put up candidates who had won as AIADMK nominees in the April-May Assembly election. In his campaign, the Chief Minister sought to project the TVK as the "true inheritor" of the legacies of AIADMK stalwarts M.G. Ramachandran and Jayalalithaa.



VOTER TURNOUT IN THE TWO CONSTITUENCIES

Year	Madurantakam			Dharapuram		
	Electorate	Votes polled	Turnout (%)	Electorate	Votes polled	Turnout (%)
2011	1,80,495	1,47,781	81.88%	2,05,145	1,62,499	79.21%
2016	2,18,831	1,77,879	81.29%	2,38,070	1,82,911	76.83%
2021	2,26,715	1,85,842	81.97%	2,58,581	1,93,991	75.02%
2026 (April-May)	2,12,666	1,98,251	93.22%	2,22,434	1,99,944	89.89%
2026 (October)	2,13,788	1,85,292	86.67%	2,23,333	1,80,532	80.84%

BREAKDOWN OF ELECTORS

Feature	Madurantakam	Dharapuram
Electors	2,13,788	2,23,333
Men	1,04,926	1,07,312
Women	1,08,797	1,16,013
Third Gender	65	8
Service Electors	27	27
First-time Electors	5,916	4,640
Persons with Disability	2,462	1,344
85 plus	1,383	2,658

HOW PEOPLE VOTED IN THESE CONSTITUENCIES

Year	Madurantakam			Dharapuram		
	VOTE SHARE					
	Winner	Runner-up	Third slot	Winner	Runner-up	Third slot
2011	AIADMK 53.64%	Congress 41.13%	Independent 1.28%	AIADMK 51.68%	DMK 42.42%	BJP 2.07%
2016	DMK 41.43%	AIADMK 39.77%	PMK 9.12%	Congress 45.67%	AIADMK 40.19%	BJP 4.24%
2021	AIADMK 46.62%	DMK 44.7%	NTK 5%	DMK 46.39%	BJP 45.67%	NTK 3.48%
2026 (April-May)	AIADMK 32.58%	TVK 29.2%	DMK 28.14%	AIADMK 40.56%	DMK 32.2%	TVK 23.23%
2026 (October)	TVK 39.96%	DMK 29.15%	AIADMK 25.61%	TVK 37.02%	DMK 31.78%	AIADMK 25.08%